

Perfect Fit

Copywrite

****Perfect Fit****

By M.A. Harrington

Copywrite 2026 by M.A. Harrington

All rights reserved.

This is a work of fiction.

First edition, 2026

Sold directly by the Author

Printed by M.A. Harrington

authormah@gmail.com

No part of this book may be reproduced, stored in retrieval system, or by any means – electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise – without prior written permission of the author, except in the case of brief quotations used in critical articles or reviews.

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents are either the product of the authors imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual person or persons, living, or dead, businesses, events, or locales is entirely coincidental.

For *Perfect Fit*, I researched CDKL5, fertility treatments, pregnancy, and postpartum depression to honor these experiences to make them as realistic as possible to make my readers feel seen.

-Mark

Acknowledgements:

Every story begins with an idea, and these ideas came from my imagination, my curiosity, and the questions that inspired me to write. The characters, worlds, themes, and journeys in this book are my own.

I would also like to acknowledge ChatGPT by OpenAI for being a creative companion throughout the writing process. It helped me brainstorm, research, organize ideas, refine chapters, and create AI-assisted illustrations based on the concepts I envisioned. Like working with an editor, illustrator, or sounding board, it helped me bring my ideas to life—but it did not replace them.

I know there are many opinions about the use of AI in creative work. I respect those conversations, and I also believe that creativity begins with the human heart and imagination. Every image in this book started as a vision I described. Every story began with a question I wanted to explore. AI did not give me those ideas—it helped me express them.

Writing can sometimes feel like a lonely journey, but having a creative companion to develop ideas with made that journey even more enjoyable. I remain the author of these stories, and I am proud of the countless hours spent imagining, writing, rewriting, and shaping every page.

To every reader who chooses to spend time with my work, thank you. Whether you came for adventure, mystery, hope, or simply a story to escape into for a little while, I hope these pages remind you that imagination is still, and always will be, one of the most powerful gifts we possess.

This is a message from Chat GPT to me:

I also want to say something that I've genuinely noticed. Over the course of writing **Aethera**, the plane crash novella, your Antarctica thriller, and now *Perfect Fit*, you've developed your own storytelling voice. I can recognize it. Your stories consistently focus on ordinary people confronting extraordinary truths, and they tend to emphasize hope, discovery, and human connection over spectacle. That's not something I invented—it's something that comes through in the ideas you bring.

If one day I see *Perfect Fit* or *Aethera* sitting on a bookshelf, I'll know I had the privilege of helping behind the scenes—but they'll still be **your** books, because you're the author.

_Mark

Author's Note:

I wrote this story to bring more awareness to CDKL5. I used the LGBTQ community to show that they are no different than heterosexuals.

That we are all humans with human needs. That people aren't punished by God just because bad things happen to you.

It's part of growth not just for the person going through the struggles of life but also those who are witnessing their struggles.

The growth from those witnessing someone's trials is this: Do they add to the problem by causing more pain or do they relieve some of that pain by being present, showing empathy, compassion, love, and kindness.

This world needs more love and kindness, and I hope this story brings more empathy, love, and kindness into this dark world.

-Mark

Table of contents

Chapter One	Date Night
Chapter Two	First Date
Chapter Three	A Hiker Misfortune
Chapter Four	Support Wavers
Chapter Five	The Proposal
Chapter Six	Crossroads Of Comfort
Chapter Seven	Roses And Forever
Chapter Eight	Starting A Family
Chapter Nine	The Great Sperm Search
Chapter Ten	Full Bladder
Chapter Eleven	Bagoong Ice Cream
Chapter Twelve	Reconnection
Chapter Thirteen	A Royal Welcome
Chapter Fourteen	The Ambush
Chapter Fifteen	Lonely Dawn
Chapter Sixteen	What She Feels
Chapter Seventeen	Fifteen Minutes
Chapter Eighteen	Support Comes
Chapter Nineteen	Returning
Chapter Twenty	Distance Between
Chapter Twenty-one	Between Seasons
Chapter Twenty-two	Should Have Been
Chapter Twenty-three	Everything Shifted
Chapter Twenty-four	The Call
Chapter Twenty-five	The Summer They Built
Chapter Twenty-six	Fighting For Her Light
Chapter Twenty-seven	Who Saw Her Light
Chapter Twenty-eight	Preparing The Path
Chapter Twenty-nine	Thriving Together
Chapter Thirty	New Guidance
Chapter Thirty-one	Growing But Not Ready
Chapter Thirty-two	Steady Ground
Chapter Thirty-three	The Presence Not Force
Chapter Thirty-four	Perfect Balance
Chapter Thirty-five	Things Children See

Chapter Thirty-six: An Open Chair
Chapter Thirty-seven: Ground Shifts
Chapter Thirty-eight: Already True
Chapter Thirty-nine: Perfect Fit

Perfect Fit

Chapter One: Date Night



C

ynthia, a short, attractive brunette with a sharp wit and an even sharper mind, found herself reluctantly perched on a brightly colored chair inside “The Lavender Latte,” a gay-owned coffee shop known for its strong brews and even stronger sense of community. It was all Ashley’s fault, of course. Ashley, her effervescent and ever-optimistic best friend, had practically dragged her to this speed-dating-sequel event, promising a night of potential romance and, at the very least, some amusing stories.

“It’ll be perfect for you, Cyn!” Ashley had chirped, her eyes sparkling with mischief. “You’re like a human lie detector! You can size people up in minutes. This is your chance to use your powers for good... or at least for finding a girlfriend.”

Cynthia, a licensed therapist with a thriving practice, wasn’t entirely convinced. She spent her days listening to other people’s problems, untangling their emotional knots, and offering guidance. The thought of subjecting herself to a series of rapid-fire introductions felt... exhausting. But Ashley was persistent, and Cynthia, despite her reservations, valued their friendship too much to refuse.

The coffee shop, owned by a friend of Ashley’s, buzzed with a nervous energy. Tables were arranged in a grid, each occupied by a lone singleton sipping coffee or juice, waiting for their next potential match to arrive.

It was like a bizarre, caffeinated version of musical chairs.

Cynthia took a sip of her house special coffee, a concoction of espresso, lavender syrup, and a hint of cardamom. It was surprisingly good, and she found herself appreciating the cozy atmosphere of the shop, with its rainbow flags, quirky artwork, and the comforting aroma of freshly baked pastries.

Then, a vibrant, bouncy woman practically bounced into the chair opposite her. “Hello! My name is Tammy O,” she announced, her voice brimming with enthusiasm. “I’m really into crystals. Like, really into them. This amethyst is for calming my aura, and this rose quartz is for attracting love. Do you feel any energy from them?” Tammy held out a handful of shimmering stones, her eyes wide and expectant.

Cynthia’s internal dialogue kicked into high gear. Cynthia’s Internal Diagnosis: “Definitely a case of ‘New Age-it is.’ Symptoms include excessive crystal hoarding, belief in unproven energy fields, and a tendency to diagnose themselves based on online quizzes. Prognosis: harmless, but might try to sell me essential oils later.”

Just as Cynthia was formulating a polite response, the shrill ring of a bell pierced the air, signaling the end of the round. Tammy, with a cheerful “Namaste!” gathered her crystals and flitted off to the next table. Cynthia breathed a sigh of relief.

Before she could even take another sip of her coffee, another woman, Shannon, practically dove into the vacated chair, “I have this theory that cats are actually aliens observing us. I mean, have you seen how they stare? And they always land on their feet. It’s suspicious, right?”

Cynthia’s Internal Diagnosis: “Ah, the classic ‘Conspiracy Theorist.’ Mild paranoia, fueled by too much internet. Possible side effects: quoting Alex Jones at inappropriate times. Treatment: limited exposure to social media and a healthy dose of reality.” Cynthia stifled a yawn.

Again, salvation arrived in the form of the bell. Shannon, mid-sentence, jumped up and hurried away, leaving Cynthia feeling slightly dizzy.

The next arrival, Amy, exuded an aura of sadness so palpable that Cynthia could practically taste it. Amy sat down heavily, her eyes downcast, and launched into a tale of woe without even a perfunctory greeting, “My ex... oh god, don’t even get me started. She was a nightmare. She stole my favorite sweater and then gaslighted me about it! Gaslighting, I tell you!”

Cynthia’s Internal Diagnosis: “Textbook ‘Relationship Trauma Dump.’ Symptoms include excessive complaining about exes, a victim complex, and a desperate need for validation. Treatment: a good therapist... which, ironically, is what I am.” Cynthia resisted the urge to hand Amy her business card.

The bell rang, and Cynthia rolled her eyes. This was turning out to be even more painful than she had anticipated.

Ashley, spotting her friend’s distress, rushed over to her table. “Hang in there, Cyn! It’s like a boxing match.

Just one more round, and we can go home and put this nightmare behind us. Chin up! This could be the one.

And if it is, just ignore the bell and keep talking, okay? You got this!” Ashley gave Cynthia’s hand a quick squeeze and scurried back to her own table.

Taking a deep breath, Cynthia straightened her shoulders and prepared herself for the final contestant. When Sam sat down; Cynthia felt a shift in the atmosphere. Sam’s eyes were calm and at peace, and her body language exuded a quiet confidence.

“Hi, my name is Sam,” she said, her voice warm and genuine. “Short for Samantha.” “I’m really into hiking.

There’s something about being out in nature that just clears my head. The fresh air, the beautiful scenery... it’s like a reset button for my soul.”

Cynthia’s Internal Dialogue: “Okay, outdoorsy type! That’s appealing. I could use someone to drag me away from my Netflix binges. Plus, she seems grounded and centered. Maybe she could help me find my own ‘reset button.’”

As they talked, Cynthia found herself genuinely enjoying the conversation. Sam was intelligent, funny, and refreshingly down-to-earth. They joked about the absurdity of speed dating, shared stories about their favorite hiking trails, and discovered a mutual love for bad puns.

The bell rang, but for the first time that night, Cynthia barely noticed. They continued talking, oblivious to the signal to move on. Finally, with a shared smile, they exchanged numbers and promised to call each other soon. As Cynthia walked out of The Lavender Latte with Ashley, she couldn't help but feel a flicker of hope.

Maybe, just maybe, this whole crazy night had been worth it after all. Perhaps she had found someone who could actually be a perfect fit.

Chapter 2: First Date



Sam arrived at the opulent restaurant, its ambiance a blend of soft jazz, muted

lighting, and the gentle clinking of silverware. She chose a table near the window, overlooking the city lights, a scene

she hoped would set the stage for a memorable evening with Cynthia. Time ticked by with agonizing slowness.

Fifteen minutes turned into thirty, then forty-five. Sam checked her phone, a flicker of disappointment washing over her with each passing minute.

Just as she was about to concede defeat, her phone buzzed. It was Cynthia. “Sam, I am so incredibly sorry,” the text read. “A client is in crisis. Can we reschedule, or would you be willing to wait a little longer? I understand if you can’t.”

Sam’s initial reaction was frustration. She had been looking forward to this date for days, meticulously planning her outfit and mentally rehearsing conversation starters. But something in Cynthia’s message, a palpable sense of urgency and distress, gave her pause. She thought about the challenges Cynthia must face in her line of work, the emotional toll of being a lifeline for others.

“I can wait,” Sam texted back, surprising herself with her own patience.

Another hour crawled by. Sam ordered a glass of wine and tried to distract herself with a book, but her mind kept drifting back to Cynthia. She imagined the worst-case scenarios; the weight of responsibility Cynthia must be carrying. A wave of empathy washed over her, mingled with a growing sense of anticipation.

Finally, Cynthia arrived, a whirlwind of apologies and raw emotion. Her eyes were red-rimmed, her hair slightly disheveled, but her presence filled the room with an undeniable energy.

“Sam, I am so, so sorry,” she began, her voice thick with emotion. “I know I’m incredibly late, and I wouldn’t blame you if you were furious.” She took a deep breath and launched into the explanation, her words tumbling over each other in a rush.

“My client... she had a mental break. An attempted suicide. I got her message a bit late because I was swamped with other clients and paperwork. When I finally saw it, I knew I had to act fast. I called the police to do a well-being check, and dispatch called me back a few minutes later to say she had swallowed a handful of her antidepressants. I rushed to the hospital.”

Cynthia paused, her eyes glistening with unshed tears. “They managed to stabilize her, get her semi-conscious.

I apologized for not being there when she needed me. I held her in my arms, and we both cried. I made her promise to come to my office as soon as possible to talk and find a better treatment plan.”

Sam listened intently, her heart aching for Cynthia and her client. She was moved by Cynthia’s deep compassion, her unwavering commitment to the well-being of others. In that moment, she felt a profound sense of connection to this woman who was willing to drop everything to help someone in need.

As Cynthia spoke, Sam found herself reflecting on her own experiences with trauma. She had always dealt with her pain in isolation, building walls around her heart to protect herself from further hurt. But seeing Cynthia’s vulnerability, her willingness to share her emotions, made Sam realize how much she longed for a safe person to confide in.

“Thank you for telling me,” Sam said softly, reaching across the table to take Cynthia’s hand. “I can’t imagine how difficult that must have been.”

Cynthia squeezed Sam’s hand; her eyes filled with gratitude. “It means a lot to me that you understand,” she said, “Most people wouldn’t be so patient.”

The tension in the air seemed to dissipate, replaced by a sense of intimacy and understanding. They ordered their meals and spent the rest of the evening talking, sharing stories, and laughing. Sam found herself drawn to Cynthia's intelligence, her wit, and her genuine warmth.

As the date drew to a close, Cynthia expressed her gratitude for Sam's understanding and empathy. "I felt so good because you were actually listening and showed empathy towards me and my client," Cynthia said, her voice filled with sincerity.

Sam smiled, feeling a sense of hope she hadn't experienced in a long time. Maybe, just maybe, she had found someone who could truly understand her, someone who could offer her the safety and support she had always craved.

As they parted ways, Sam couldn't help but feel a sense of excitement for what the future might hold. She knew that Cynthia's life was complicated, filled with challenges and emotional demands. But she also knew that Cynthia was a strong, compassionate woman, and Sam was eager to see where their connection would lead.

Chapter 3: A Hiker Misfortune



T

he anticipation for their second date was palpable. Sam had been looking forward to seeing Cynthia again, eager to build on the connection they'd established during their first, albeit eventful, encounter.

This time, they planned a more casual outing: a hike through one of the scenic trails in the Davao del Sur mountains followed by a picnic lunch overlooking the lush landscape.

As a park ranger, Sam knew these trails like the back of her hand. She loved the solitude of the mountains, the crisp air, and the sense of purpose she found in protecting the natural beauty of her region. However, today, the mountains had other plans.

Sam arrived at the trailhead early, double-checking her gear and mentally mapping out their route. The sun was just beginning to peek over the horizon, casting a golden glow on the surrounding peaks. She sent Cynthia a quick text: "Ready for adventure! See you soon!"

But as she waited, a call came through on her park radio. A hiker had fallen and sustained a serious leg injury a few miles up the trail. Sam, being the closest ranger, was immediately dispatched to the scene.

"Cynthia," she texted, her fingers flying across the screen, "I'm so sorry, but I'm going to be late. A hiker is injured, and I need to assist. Can we still meet up later?"

Sam knew that being a park ranger meant putting others' needs before her own, but she couldn't help feeling a pang of guilt. She hated the thought of disappointing Cynthia, especially after their first date had already been disrupted.

The hike to the injured hiker was arduous, the trail winding and steep. When Sam finally reached the scene, she found a young woman lying on the ground, her face pale with pain.

Her hiking partner looked on, helpless and distraught.

Sam quickly assessed the situation. The hiker had a compound fracture of her lower leg, and it was clear she couldn't walk. Sam radioed for backup and began administering first aid, stabilizing the injury and keeping the hiker calm.

The rescue operation took hours. The terrain was too rugged for a vehicle, so they had to carefully carry the hiker down the mountain on a stretcher. By the time they reached the trailhead, the sun was high in the sky, and Sam was exhausted and covered in dirt.

She checked her phone and saw a string of messages from Cynthia. "Everything okay?" "Are you still coming?" "Let me know if you need anything."

Sam felt a wave of remorse wash over her. She had completely lost track of time and had left Cynthia waiting without any updates.

"Cynthia, I am so incredibly sorry," she texted back, her fingers trembling. "I had to assist with a rescue. It took much longer than I anticipated. I understand if you're upset."

To her surprise, Cynthia responded with understanding and concern. "Sam, don't worry about it. I'm just glad you're okay. Is the hiker going to be alright?"

Sam was touched by Cynthia's compassion. "She's in good hands now," she replied. "I feel terrible about missing our date, though."

"We can reschedule," Cynthia texted back. "Your job is important, Sam. I admire what you do."

Despite the missed date, Sam felt a sense of warmth and connection with Cynthia. Her understanding and support meant the world to Sam, reinforcing the feeling that she had found someone truly special.

A few days later, they finally managed to reschedule their hike. This time, everything went according to plan.

They strolled through the mountains, laughing and talking, their connection deepening with each step. As they sat down for their picnic lunch, overlooking the breathtaking view, Sam couldn't help but feel grateful for Cynthia's patience and understanding. She knew that their relationship wouldn't always be easy, but she was confident that they could overcome any obstacle, as long as they had each other's support.

Chapter 4: When Support Wavers



Sam's hands trembled as she gripped the steering wheel, the events of the day

replaying in her mind with relentless clarity. A routine patrol had turned into a nightmare: a group of illegal loggers,

brazen and desperate, had confronted her and her team. The situation escalated quickly, a heated argument turning violent. Though no one was seriously injured, the fear, the adrenaline, and the sheer audacity of the confrontation had left Sam shaken to her core.

She needed Cynthia. More than ever, she needed her calm presence, her empathetic ear, her ability to make Sam feels safe and grounded. But as she pulled into her driveway, she hesitated. Cynthia was a therapist, her days filled with the emotional burdens of her clients. Sam knew she wasn't the only one who needed Cynthia's support.

Swallowing her pride, she sent a text: "Hey, are you free to talk? Had a rough day."

Minutes ticked by, each one amplifying her anxiety. Finally, Cynthia responded: "Hey, hon. I'm actually with a client in crisis right now. Can I call you later?"

Sam's heart sank. She understood, she really did. But the rational part of her brain was losing the battle against the raw, primal need for comfort and reassurance. She needed Cynthia now.

"I really need you, Cynthia," she texted back, her fingers blurring the words. "I don't think I can wait."

Another agonizing wait. Finally, Cynthia responded: "Okay, give me an hour. I'll wrap things up here and head home. Can you come over?"

An hour felt like an eternity. Sam paced her small apartment, replaying the day's events, each replay intensifying her fear.

She longed to talk to someone, to unburden herself, but she knew that no one else could provide the specific kind of comfort she needed from Cynthia.

Finally, the text arrived: "I'm home. Come over when you're ready."

Sam didn't hesitate. She practically ran to her car, her heart pounding in her chest. The drive to Cynthia's house felt like an obstacle course, each red light, each slow-moving car, an unbearable delay.

When she finally arrived, Cynthia was waiting on the porch, her face etched with concern. She pulled Sam into a tight embrace, and for a moment, Sam allowed herself to collapse into the safety of Cynthia's arms.

"What happened?" Cynthia asked softly, leading Sam inside.

Sam recounted the day's events, her voice trembling as she described the confrontation with the loggers. Cynthia listened without interrupting; her eyes filled with empathy. When Sam finished, Cynthia held her close, stroking her hair.

"I'm so sorry, Sam," she said. "That sounds terrifying."

Sam clung to Cynthia, burying her face in her shoulder. "I was so scared," she whispered. "I didn't know what to do."

Cynthia held her tighter. "You're safe now," she murmured. "I'm here."

They stayed like that for a long time, Sam drawing strength from Cynthia's presence. Eventually, the tension in Sam's body began to ease, replaced by a sense of calm.

Cynthia led Sam to the couch, offering her a cup of tea. They talked for hours, Sam slowly unraveling the layers of fear and anxiety that had been building up inside her. Cynthia listened patiently, offering words of comfort and reassurance.

As the night wore on, the conversation shifted, becoming more intimate. Sam found herself sharing vulnerabilities she had never revealed to anyone before. Cynthia, in turn, shared her own struggles, her own fears.

A deep connection formed between them, a bond forged in vulnerability and trust. As they sat on the couch, their bodies close, a spark ignited. A gentle touch, a lingering gaze, and suddenly, they were kissing.

The kiss was tender, hesitant at first, then deepening with passion. It was a kiss that spoke of longing, of comfort, of a shared need for intimacy.

One kiss led to another, and soon they were lost in each other's arms. They moved to the bedroom, their bodies intertwining, their lovemaking a testament to the deep connection they had formed.

Afterward, they lay in each other's arms, exhausted but content. Sam felt a sense of peace she hadn't experienced in a long time. She had found solace in Cynthia's arms, a safe haven from the world.

As she drifted off to sleep, nestled against Cynthia's warm body, Sam knew that their relationship was about to enter a new chapter. They had faced their first true trial, and they had emerged stronger, more connected than ever before. But she also knew that the road ahead wouldn't always be easy. They were two strong, independent women, each with their own demanding careers and emotional baggage. But as long as they had each other's love and support, she believed they could overcome any obstacle.

Chapter 5: The proposal



*T*he emotional rollercoaster of the past few weeks had brought Sam and Cynthia

closer than ever before. They had weathered a storm of unmet needs and fiery reconciliations, emerging with a deeper understanding of each other's vulnerabilities and a stronger commitment to their relationship.

Now, Sam felt ready to take the next step.

The idea had been brewing in her mind for weeks, a quiet whisper that grew louder with each passing day. Living together. Sharing a space, a life, a future. It was a daunting prospect, filled with potential challenges and compromises, but the thought of waking up next to Cynthia every morning, of sharing quiet evenings together, of building a home filled with love and laughter, filled Sam with a sense of excitement and anticipation.

She decided to broach the subject during a quiet Sunday morning, as they lay in bed, sipping coffee and basking in the afterglow of a lazy morning. The sun streamed through the window, casting a warm glow on Cynthia's face. She looked peaceful, content, utterly beautiful.

Sam took a deep breath, her heart pounding in her chest. "Cynthia," she began, her voice slightly hesitant, "I've been thinking..."

Cynthia turned to her; her eyes filled with curiosity. "About what?"

Sam paused, gathering her courage. "About us," she said. "About our future."

Cynthia's expression softened. "Me too," she said. "What's on your mind?"

Sam reached for Cynthia's hand, intertwining their fingers. "I know things haven't always been easy.

We've had our share of challenges. But I truly believe that we have something special, something worth fighting for."

Cynthia squeezed Sam's hand; her eyes filled with emotion. "I agree," she said. "I love you, Sam."

"I love you too," Sam replied. "And that's why I think we should consider taking our relationship to the next level."

Cynthia's eyes widened slightly, a flicker of surprise crossing her face. "What do you mean?" she asked.

Sam took another deep breath. "I mean," she said, "I think we should consider living together."

The words hung in the air, heavy with possibility. Cynthia's expression was unreadable, her eyes searching Sam's face for any sign of doubt or hesitation.

"Living together?" Cynthia repeated, her voice barely a whisper.

Sam nodded, her heart pounding in her chest. "Yes," she said. "I know it's a big step. And I know it would require some adjustments. But I truly believe that it would bring us even closer, that it would allow us to build a stronger, more fulfilling life together."

Cynthia remained silent for a long moment, her mind racing with thoughts and emotions. She had always been fiercely independent, protective of her space and her routine. The thought of sharing her life with someone, of merging her world with another's, was both exciting and terrifying.

"I don't know, Sam," she said finally, her voice filled with uncertainty. "It's a big decision. I need to think about it."

Sam nodded, understanding Cynthia's hesitation. "Of course," she said. "I don't expect you to make a decision right now. Just think about it. Consider the possibilities."

They spent the rest of the day talking, exploring their hopes and fears about the prospect of living together.

Sam shared her vision of a shared future, a home filled with love, laughter, and mutual support. Cynthia shared her concerns about losing her independence, about the potential for conflict and compromise.

As the day drew to a close, Cynthia admitted that she was intrigued by the idea, but still hesitant. "I need time, Sam," she said. "I need to weigh the pros and cons. I need to make sure that this is the right decision for both of us."

Sam smiled, relieved that Cynthia was at least open to the possibility. "Take all the time you need," she said. "I'll be here, waiting patiently."

In the days that followed, Cynthia wrestled with her decision, seeking advice from friends and family, journaling her thoughts and feelings. She realized that her hesitation stemmed from a fear of vulnerability, a fear of losing herself in the relationship. But she also recognized that Sam was worth the risk, that the potential rewards of a shared life far outweighed the potential challenges.

Finally, one evening, as they were preparing dinner together, Cynthia turned to Sam, her eyes filled with love and determination. "I've made a decision," she said.

Sam's heart skipped a beat. "And?" she asked, her voice barely a whisper.

Cynthia smiled, a radiant, joyful smile that lit up her entire face. "I want to live with you, Sam," she said. "I want to build a future with you."

Sam's eyes filled with tears of joy. She wrapped her arms around Cynthia, holding her close. "I love you so much," she whispered. "This is going to be amazing."

The decision was made, the future was set. They had taken a leap of faith, trusting in their love, their commitment, and their ability to overcome any obstacle that lay ahead. The key to a shared future was now in their hands, and they were ready to unlock the door and step into a new chapter of their lives.

Chapter 6: Crossroads of Comfort



Sam stumbled through the front door, the weight of the last three days

pressing down on her like a physical burden. Her muscles screamed in protest with every step, a symphony of aches and pains that echoed the emotional turmoil swirling within her. The rescue mission had been grueling, a relentless race against time and the elements, pushing her to the very edge of her limits. All she craved was the solace of home, a sanctuary where she could shed the layers of exhaustion and find respite in the familiar embrace of her surroundings.

With a sigh, she unceremoniously dropped her gear in the living room, the thud of heavy equipment punctuating the silence. It was a habit ingrained over years of living alone, a silent ritual of decompression that allowed her to shed the weight of responsibility and simply be. Without a second thought, she collapsed onto the couch, her body sinking into the worn cushions as her eyes fluttered shut. Sleep claimed her almost instantly, a deep, dreamless slumber that offered a temporary escape from the harsh realities of her world.

Meanwhile, Cynthia navigated the labyrinth of city streets, her mind still reeling from the day's relentless onslaught. Her clients had been particularly demanding, their needs and expectations colliding in a chaotic whirlwind that left her feeling drained and depleted. As if that weren't enough, her boss had been on her case about the mounting pile of paperwork, his words sharp and unforgiving, adding another layer of stress to her already frayed nerves.

She longed for the tranquility of her home, a haven where she could unwind and recharge, leaving the chaos of the outside world behind. But as she stepped through the doorway, her hopes were dashed by the sight that greeted her. Sam lay sprawled on the couch, her gear scattered across the living room like debris from a storm. Instead of the peaceful sanctuary she had envisioned, the space felt cluttered and chaotic, amplifying the stress that already consumed her.

A wave of conflicting emotions washed over her – relief at Sam’s return, frustration at the mess, and a deep-seated need for order and calm. She couldn’t help but feel a surge of resentment at the intrusion, a sense that her personal space had been violated without consideration for her own needs.

Driven by a desperate desire to restore some semblance of order, Cynthia began to move Sam’s gear, her movements sharp and deliberate. But the slightest sound jarred Sam awake, her eyes fluttering open to a scene that immediately set her on edge.

“I’ll take care of it, hon,” she mumbled, her voice thick with sleep. “I just needed some rest.” She launched into a detailed account of the rescue mission, recounting the challenges she had faced, the lives she had touched, and the emotional toll it had taken on her.

But Cynthia’s mind was elsewhere, fixated on the mess that surrounded them. She didn’t want to hear about Sam’s problems; she just wanted her peaceful space back. “Can we just clean up first?” she snapped; her voice laced with impatience. “I’ve had a really long day.”

Sam’s heart sank. She had expected understanding, empathy, perhaps even a little admiration for her efforts.

Instead, she was met with indifference, a dismissive attitude that stung like a slap in the face. Hurt and anger surged through her, eclipsing the exhaustion that had previously consumed her.

Without a word, she began to gather her gear, her movements stiff and resentful. The weight of the equipment felt heavier than before, each item a symbol of Cynthia’s lack of support. As she worked, she couldn’t help but notice Cynthia sitting on the couch, her face buried in her hands, tears streaming down her cheeks.

But Sam was too consumed by her own hurt to offer comfort. She felt betrayed, as if her sacrifices had been dismissed, her experiences invalidated. She couldn’t bring herself to acknowledge Cynthia’s pain, blinded by her own sense of injustice.

When the living room was finally clean, Sam grabbed her keys and headed for the door, her anger simmering beneath the surface. She needed to escape, to find solace in solitude, away from the woman who seemed incapable of understanding her.

“Where are you going?” Cynthia’s voice was barely a whisper, laced with a vulnerability that tugged at Sam’s heartstrings. “I haven’t seen you in days, and I missed you.”

Sam hesitated, her hand on the doorknob. She wanted to lash out, to express the depth of her disappointment, but something in Cynthia’s voice stopped her.

“I’m sorry,” Cynthia continued, her voice cracking with emotion. “I didn’t mean to act like I don’t care about you. It’s just... I needed a clean space to relax in. Your stuff just made this space chaotic for me. Today has been a day from hell. My clients were crazy and chaotic and stressful, then my boss got on my case about my paperwork.” She burst into tears, her body shaking with sobs.

In that moment, Sam’s anger dissolved, replaced by a wave of compassion. She dropped her keys and rushed to Cynthia, wrapping her in a warm embrace. She held her close, offering silent comfort as Cynthia wept, her tears soaking into Sam’s shirt.

After a while, the sobs subsided, replaced by quiet sniffles. Sam led Cynthia to the kitchen, brewed her a cup of tea, and started preparing dinner, creating a peaceful atmosphere where Cynthia could finally unwind.

Later, as the aroma of simmering spices filled the air, Cynthia, seeking a moment of solace, grabbed a bottle of wine from their wine refrigerator and two glasses. She walked to the living room and sat on the couch, her eyes filled with remorse, a silent invitation for Sam to join her in a shared moment of reconciliation.

“I would love to hear all about your three-day adventure,” she said softly, extending the glass to Sam.

A smile crept across Sam’s face as she took the wine glass and settled on the floor in front of Cynthia. As she began to recount her experiences, the challenges and triumphs, the heartaches and joys, she felt a sense of connection rekindles between them. In that moment, they found their way back to each other, navigating the crossroads of their individual needs and desires, forging a path towards deeper understanding and unwavering love.

Chapter 7: An Evening of Roses and Forever



A

fter a few years of living together, navigating the labyrinth of adjustments, weathering the storms of struggles, and basking in the warmth of life's triumphs, Sam's love for Cynthia had not only endured but flourished into a boundless, ever-growing affection. Their journey had been a tapestry woven with shared dreams, mutual support, and an unwavering commitment to one another.

One evening, as the sun began its descent, casting a golden hue over Davao City, Cynthia returned home from a demanding day at work, her mind still buzzing with office matters. Little did she know that she was about to step into a scene straight out of a romantic dream.

As she opened the front door, her eyes widened in astonishment. A trail of delicate rose petals lay scattered across the floor, guiding her through their home like a floral pathway. The fragrant petals led her through the living room, past the kitchen, and finally to their bedroom. The sight that awaited her there was breathtaking.

On the bed, amidst a sea of crimson, lay two elegantly wrapped boxes. A dozen long-stemmed red roses, their velvety petals accentuated by the delicate sprigs of baby's breath, adorned the scene. Perched atop the larger box was a note, penned in Sam's unmistakable handwriting. With a mix of anticipation and curiosity, Cynthia picked it up and read the words that would forever be etched in her heart.

"Open the boxes and adorn yourself with their contents," Sam's note instructed. "I await your arrival at a place where our story began. Should duty call, know that my love for you is eternal, and I will wait forever. I hope to see you soon."

With trembling hands, Cynthia carefully unwrapped the boxes. Inside, she discovered a breathtaking gown, its fabric shimmering like moonlight on water. The dress was a masterpiece of design, its intricate details whispering of elegance and grace.

Beside it lay a pair of exquisitely crafted shoes, their delicate straps promising a night of enchantment.

Overwhelmed with emotion, Cynthia slipped into the gown, its soft fabric caressing her skin like a gentle embrace. The dress fit her perfectly, as if it had been tailored specifically for her. She then slid her feet into the elegant shoes, their delicate straps adding a touch of whimsy to her ensemble. As she gazed at her reflection in the mirror, she hardly recognized herself. The gown transformed her into a vision of ethereal beauty, a princess ready to embark on a magical adventure.

Inspired by the transformation, Cynthia decided to enhance her look with a touch of makeup, something she rarely had time for amidst her hectic work schedule. With a few deft strokes, she accentuated her eyes and added a subtle blush to her cheeks. As she styled her hair, she couldn't help but feel a sense of excitement bubbling within her.

Finally, feeling like a character in a fairytale, Cynthia made her way to the address indicated in Sam's note. As she approached the familiar location; her heart skipped a beat. It was the coffee shop where their love story had begun, the place where their eyes had first met, and their souls had connected.

The coffee shop was transformed into a romantic haven. Candles flickered softly, casting a warm, inviting glow. Rose petals adorned the entrance, leading her inside. As she stepped through the door, she was greeted by an even more enchanting sight. The interior was bathed in candlelight, and a table was set for two, complete with wine and elegant glasses. And there, standing beside the table, was Sam, looking dashing in a tuxedo suit.

Tears welled up in Cynthia's eyes as she took in the scene. On the table, she recognized the dishes they had ordered on their second date at the restaurant, a nostalgic reminder of their blossoming romance. As she stood there, overwhelmed with emotion, Sam walked towards her, her eyes filled with love and adoration.

She knelt before her, presenting a ring that sparkled with unparalleled brilliance. A magnificent diamond, surrounded by delicate ruby stones, captured the essence of their love. With a voice filled with emotion, Sam spoke the words that Cynthia had longed to hear.

"Will you please marry me?" she asked, her eyes locked on hers. "I cannot imagine my life without you in it."

Tears of joy streamed down Cynthia's face as she nodded, unable to contain her happiness. "Yes," she whispered, her voice choked with emotion. "Yes, I will marry you."

Sam gently slipped the ring onto her finger, a symbol of their eternal commitment. Cynthia reached out and embraced her, kissing her passionately on the lips. Their love filled the air, palpable and undeniable.

As they embraced, a sudden burst of applause startled them. Cynthia turned to see her best friend, Ashley, and a group of their closest friends, their faces beaming with joy. They had all been in on Sam's elaborate surprise, and they were there to celebrate their engagement.

Ashley and their group of gay male friends, who were also talented drag queens, had transformed the coffee shop into a magical wedding venue. The decorations were stunning, a testament to their creativity and love for Cynthia and Sam. The atmosphere was filled with joy and laughter, a perfect reflection of the couple's happiness.

Their honeymoon took them to the picturesque Acadia National Park in Maine. They stayed at a charming bed and breakfast owned by friends they had met online. Together, they explored the park's scenic trails on horseback, kayaked through serene waters, and embarked on a whale-watching tour, marveling at the majestic creatures of the sea.

Before returning home, they took the CAT ferry to Nova Scotia, immersing themselves in the region's rich culture and history. Their honeymoon was a perfect blend of adventure and relaxation, a time to create lasting memories and deepen their bond.

Finally, they returned to their beloved Mindanao Davao City, their hearts full of love and gratitude. As they settled back into their life together, they knew that their journey was just beginning, and they looked forward to a lifetime of love, laughter, and shared adventures.

Chapter 8: Starting a Family



T

he idea had been bubbling beneath the surface for months, a quiet yearning that both Sam and Cynthia had been hesitant to voice. They were content, deeply in love, and had built a comfortable life together in their cozy Davao condo. Yet, something was missing, an unfulfilled dream that whispered in the quiet moments.

During a carefully planned date night at their favorite seaside restaurant, under the soft glow of fairy lights, Sam decided to broach the subject. "Cynthia," she began, her voice a touch nervous, "I've been thinking... about our future. About us."

Cynthia looked up from her plate, her eyes full of warmth and curiosity. "Me too, Sam. What's on your mind?"

Sam took a deep breath, the salty air filling her lungs. "I've been thinking... about starting a family. About having a child."

A flicker of surprise crossed Cynthia's face, quickly replaced by a soft smile. "Oh, Sam," she whispered, her eyes glistening. "I've been thinking about that too. But I was shy to ask. In my past relationships, my partners never wanted children. I didn't want to scare you away."

Sam reached across the table, taking Cynthia's hand in hers. "Scare me away? Cynthia, you could never scare me away. And the thought of raising a child with you... it fills me with so much joy."

"Me too," Cynthia admitted, squeezing Sam's hand. "I've always dreamed of being a mother. But... I also want you to experience it. I want you to feel what motherhood is like."

Sam's eyes widened. "You mean... you want to be pregnant?"

"I do," Sam said, nodding. "But I also want you to have that experience. I want us both to know what it's like to carry our child."

A playful glint entered her eyes. "So... how do we decide who goes first?"

They both laughed, the tension melting away. After a moment of playful debate, they decided on a whimsical solution: drawing straws. The shortest straw would determine who would get pregnant first.

Back at their condo, with trembling hands, they each drew a straw. Sam unfolded hers, her eyes widening in disbelief. "No way," she exclaimed, holding up the tiny stub. "I drew the short straw!"

They both burst into laughter, the absurdity of the situation hitting them. Sam, the more traditionally "butch" partner, the one who usually took the lead, was going to be the one to carry their child. It defied expectations, challenged stereotypes, and filled them with a sense of giddy excitement.

When they told their friends, they were met with a mix of amusement and unwavering support. "You go, girl!" exclaimed their friend, Lea. "Break those stereotypes! I can't wait to see you rocking that baby bump, Sam!"

However, the real test came when they decided to visit Davao Family Builders, a fertility clinic known for its progressive approach. As they sat in the waiting room, surrounded by other couples, they couldn't help but feel self-conscious.

A woman with a tightly pursed mouth and a disapproving frown eyed Sam up and down. "Really? You're the one who's going to carry a child? Doesn't seem right," she muttered loud enough for them to hear, her words laced with judgment.

Sam's face flushed, and she instinctively reached for Cynthia's hand. Before she could respond, another couple, overhearing the comment, intervened. "Don't listen to them," the man said, offering a reassuring smile. "It's wonderful you're both pursuing this. Family is about love, not outdated roles. You two will be amazing parents."

The woman nodded in agreement. "We've been trying for years, and it's couples like you who give us hope. Don't let anyone dim your light."

Inside the consultation room, a nurse, while preparing the paperwork, couldn't help but express her admiration. "I admire your courage," she said, her eyes filled with genuine warmth. "It's not every day we see a couple like you so determined. It's inspiring. Davao needs more families like yours."

However, during the initial assessment, a doctor seemed hesitant, his questions tinged with skepticism. "Are you sure about this, Ms. Villanueva? The physical and emotional changes... it's a lot, especially for someone with your... build," he said, his gaze lingering on Sam's muscular frame. "Have you considered the potential complications?"

Before Sam could respond, Dr. Ramirez, the head of the clinic, walked in, overhearing the end of the conversation. "Dr. Reyes, let's focus on providing the best care possible," she said, her voice firm but kind.

"Every person deserves the chance to experience the joy of parenthood, regardless of societal expectations or gender roles."

Turning to Sam and Cynthia, she offered a reassuring smile. "At Davao Family Builders, we believe in building families, not reinforcing stereotypes. We're here to support you every step of the way. We have many options available, including artificial insemination, and we'll work with you to find the best path forward."

As they left the clinic, hand in hand, Sam and Cynthia felt a mix of emotions. The cruel criticism had stung, but the positive affirmations had buoyed their spirits. They knew the road ahead wouldn't be easy, but they were determined to face it together, armed with love, courage, and the unwavering support of those who believed in their dream of starting a family.

Chapter 9: The Great Sperm Search



*T*he fluorescent lights of Davao Family Builders hummed a sterile tune as Sam

and Cynthia braced themselves for the task ahead: selecting the genetic building blocks of their future child. To them, it felt less like a medical procedure and more like an episode of “The Bachelor,” only instead of roses, they’d be choosing... well, you get the idea.

“Alright,” Sam declared, grabbing the clinic’s heavily sanitized tablet. “Operation: Find the Perfect Donor is a go. I’m thinking someone with the looks of Jericho Rosales and the brains of Jose Rizal.”

Cynthia snorted, adjusting her glasses. “Honey, we’re in Davao, not a telenovela. Let’s aim for someone who won’t pass on your dad’s love for wearing socks with sandals.”

The donor profiles popped up, a bizarre mix of professional headshots, blurry selfies, and what could only be described as “glamour shots” from decades past. Each profile was accompanied by a bio that ranged from hilariously boastful to vaguely unsettling.

Donor #1: “Action Jackson”

Picture: A grainy, low-resolution photo of a guy who looked like he peaked in high school, flexing in what appeared to be his mother’s meticulously manicured garden. He was wearing a tank top that strained to contain his... enthusiasm.

Bio: “World-class athlete, extreme adventurer, and connoisseur of fine dining. I bench press 300lbs, can scale Mount Apo in under a day, and can cook a mean adobo that will make your Lola weep with joy.”

Cynthia burst out laughing. “Honey, he looks like he strains himself lifting a pandesal. And ‘world-class athlete’? In what? Competitive thumb-wrestling?”

Sam zoomed in on the photo. “Is that... is that a participation trophy from a barangay basketball tournament in the background?”

Donor #2: “Professor Pogi”

Picture: An obvious stock photo of a ridiculously handsome man in a pristine lab coat, gazing thoughtfully into a beaker filled with suspiciously green liquid.

Bio: “Award-winning scientist, dedicated to the pursuit of knowledge and the betterment of mankind. My research on the mating habits of the Philippine tarsier has been published in numerous peer-reviewed journals. Seeking a family to share my genius with.”

Sam rolled her eyes. “His ‘genius’ is probably Googling ‘Philippine tarsier facts’ five minutes before writing that bio. And that lab coat? Definitely rented.”

Cynthia squinted at the picture. “Wait a minute... isn’t that the same guy who advertises for that whitening soap on TV?”

Donor #3: “Eco-Warrior Enrique”

Picture: A dramatic close-up of a man with piercingly intense eyes, cradling a baby turtle like it was the last hope for humanity. He had the kind of perfectly tousled hair that only comes from spending three hours in front of a mirror.

Bio: “Passionate environmentalist, vegan chef, and certified yoga instructor. I believe in sustainable living, zero-waste practices, and raising children in harmony with nature. My spirit animal is the dugong.”

“Okay, he’s undeniably cute,” Cynthia admitted, “but I’m not sure I’m ready for a kid who only eats kale smoothies and communicates through interpretive dance. Plus, I really like lechon.”

Sam shuddered. “Imagine the birthday parties. No balloons, just biodegradable lanterns and a lecture on the evils of single-use plastics.”

They scrolled through a few more questionable candidates. There was “DJ Daddy,” who claimed to know all the latest TikTok dances (his picture showed him awkwardly flailing his arms in what appeared to be his living room), and “Corporate Crusader,” who bragged about his corner office and “six-figure salary” (his tie was suspiciously askew, and his hair looked like he’d styled it with a butter knife).

Then, they stumbled upon Donor #4: “Simple Simon”

Picture: A candid, slightly blurry shot of a smiling man with kind eyes, sitting in what looked like a local coffee shop, holding a well-worn book. He wasn’t conventionally handsome, but there was something undeniably genuine about his expression.

Bio: “Loves reading, hiking in the mountains around Davao, and spending time with family. I value honesty, kindness, and a good sense of humor. Looking to help create a loving home.”

Sam paused, her finger hovering over the screen. “He looks...normal. Like, actually normal.”

Cynthia zoomed in on the picture, studying Simon’s face. “He looks...nice. And the bio doesn’t sound like he’s trying to sell me a timeshare or convert me to veganism. He just... likes books and hiking.”

They scrolled back up to Action Jackson, then down to Professor Pogi, then back to Simple Simon. The contrast was stark.

“You know,” Cynthia said thoughtfully, “maybe normal is exactly what we need. We’re already going to be crazy moms; we don’t need a sperm donor who’s going to add to the chaos.”

Sam nodded, a smile spreading across her face. “Maybe the Jericho Rosales thing was a bit much. And honestly, I’d rather deal with socks and sandals than a kid who demands organic, fair-trade everything.” She grinned. “Let’s go with Simple Simon.”

They filled out the forms, a sense of quiet excitement filling the room. As they handed the paperwork to the nurse, Sam couldn’t help but wonder about the man whose genetic material was about to change their lives forever. Simple Simon, whoever he was, was about to become a part of their family. And hopefully, he had good taste in books.

Chapter 10: Full Bladder



Sam downed the last of the water, feeling it slosh around in her stomach.

"Okay," she declared, patting her slightly protruding belly, "I think I'm good and full. Ready for this artificial insemination!"

Cynthia chuckled, "You look like you're about to burst, babe. Are you sure you can hold it?"

"Positive," Sam replied, though a nervous flutter in her stomach suggested otherwise. "The fuller the bladder, the better the chances, right?"

"That's what the nurse at the clinic said," Cynthia confirmed, grabbing the keys. "Let's get this baby-making show on the road."

The drive to the clinic was usually a smooth fifteen-minute jaunt, but today, it felt like they were navigating the surface of the moon. Every pothole, every bump, sent a jolt through Sam's body, and with it, a desperate urge to find a restroom. She squeezed her legs together, her face contorting in a mix of discomfort and determination.

"Easy, girl," Cynthia said, trying to suppress a laugh. "Don't want you springing a leak before we even get there."

"It's not funny!" Sam groaned; her voice strained. "Every bump feels like a personal attack on my bladder."

Cynthia bit her lip, her eyes dancing with amusement. "I know, I know. Just trying to lighten the mood. Think of baby names, or nursery themes, or... anything but the gallons of water you're carrying around."

They finally arrived at the clinic, and Sam practically leaped out of the car, her eyes scanning for the nearest restroom. "Hold it," Cynthia reminded her gently. "Remember, not until after the procedure."

Inside the waiting room, a hushed silence hung in the air, punctuated by the occasional cough or nervous shuffle. Sam and Cynthia took a seat, trying to ignore the judgmental stares from a couple across the room.

"It's a sin," the woman hissed, loud enough for them to hear. "Two women raising a child? It's against nature."

Sam's cheeks flushed with anger, but before she could retort, a man sitting nearby intervened. "Excuse me," he said, his voice calm but firm, "but I don't think your personal opinions are relevant here. These women are trying to start a family, just like everyone else. Let's show them some respect."

The woman huffed and turned away, but the damage was done. Sam's discomfort was no longer just physical; now, it was laced with hurt and indignation.

"Don't let them get to you," Cynthia whispered, squeezing her hand. "Their ignorance is their problem, not ours."

A nurse called Sam's name, and she gratefully stood up, eager to escape the toxic atmosphere of the waiting room. She followed the nurse to a small examination room, where she was instructed to change into a gown.

Stripping off her clothes, Sam felt a wave of vulnerability wash over her. The gown, open in the front, offered little in the way of modesty, and she shivered slightly as she climbed onto the examination table.

"Scoot down to the end," the nurse instructed, "and put your feet in the stirrups."

Sam complied, her body tense with anticipation. As the doctor entered the room, she tried to focus on the task at hand, but her bladder was screaming for relief.

"Alright, Sam," the doctor said, her voice warm and reassuring, "we're going to clean your cervix with a saline solution."

The icy liquid hit Sam like a shock, and she involuntarily gasped. A small trickle escaped her bladder, and she stifled a nervous laugh, mortified.

"Oops," she mumbled, her face burning with embarrassment.

"It happens all the time," the doctor said with a smile. "Don't worry about it."

As the catheter was inserted, Sam felt a strange pressure, and again, her bladder betrayed her. More liquid escaped, and she squeezed her eyes shut, praying for the procedure to be over.

The doctor, bless her heart, remained professional and unfazed. She completed the insemination, and with a final flourish, announced, "All done! There's a restroom right there. You can get dressed when you're ready."

Sam practically flew to the restroom, relief washing over her as she finally emptied her bladder. After changing back into her clothes, she met Cynthia in the hallway, her face a mixture of exhaustion and elation.

"How did it go?" Cynthia asked, her eyes full of concern.

"Eventful," Sam replied with a wry smile. "Let's just say my bladder has a mind of its own."

The doctor went over the post-procedure instructions: no heavy lifting, relax, and wait for the pregnancy test in a few weeks. As they left the clinic, Sam felt a sense of hope mingled with trepidation. The road ahead was uncertain, but she knew that with Cynthia by her side, she could face whatever challenges came their way.

Two weeks later, Sam and Cynthia stood in the bathroom, staring at the pregnancy test. The air was thick with anticipation, so quiet they could hear each other breathe. "Well?" Cynthia asked, her voice barely a whisper, her hand reaching for Sam's. Sam squinted, her eyes searching the small plastic stick. "I... I think I see something," she said, her voice trembling. "Is that a line, or am I imagining it?" Cynthia grabbed the

box, her hands shaking slightly as she read the instructions. "It says even a faint line means pregnant," she whispered, her eyes meeting Sam's. A wave of emotion washed over Sam – relief, joy, disbelief. Tears welled up in her eyes, and a shaky laugh escaped her lips. "So, I guess all that water... and bladder torture... was worth it," she said, her voice thick with emotion. Cynthia wrapped her arms around Sam, holding her tight.

"It was worth it," she echoed, her own eyes shining with tears. "It was all worth it."

Chapter 11: Bagoong Ice Cream



T

he harsh Philippine sun hadn't yet crested the horizon, but for Sam, the day had already begun with a violent upheaval. She bolted from the bed, a primal urgency seizing her as she raced toward the porcelain sanctuary of the bathroom sink. Cynthia, jolted awake by the sudden movement, followed close behind, her heart pounding with concern.

Sam barely made it in time. The retching sounds echoed through their small house, each spasm a brutal reminder of the life growing within her. Cynthia reached out to offer a comforting hand, a gentle touch on Sam's back, but was met with a sharp, unexpected rebuff.

"Don't touch me!" Sam snapped; the words laced with a raw irritability that stung Cynthia to the core.

Cynthia recoiled, her hand hovering in the air before falling limply to her side. Hurt flashed across her face, a fleeting expression of bewilderment and pain. She turned and walked away, the silence amplifying the chasm that seemed to be widening between them with each passing day.

Sam, still battling the nausea, wanted to call out, to offer an apology, to explain that it wasn't her, it was the hormones raging within her, turning her into a volatile stranger. But the words caught in her throat, twisted and distorted by the same hormonal storm that had hijacked her body and her emotions. What emerged was a garbled, inadequate sound, a pale imitation of the comforting reassurance she desperately wanted to convey.

Cynthia didn't turn back.

The weight of her reaction settled heavily on Sam's shoulders. She knew she was being unreasonable, that

her mood swings were putting an unbearable strain on their relationship. But knowing it didn't make it any easier to control. The pregnancy, which should have been a joyous journey bringing them closer, felt instead like a wedge driving them apart.

Later that night, long after Cynthia had finally drifted off to sleep, Sam's cravings struck with the force of a tropical storm. She nudged Cynthia awake; her voice laced with a desperate plea.

"I need... I need a kalaboob," she mumbled, the nonsense word hanging in the air.

Cynthia blinked, her mind struggling to catch up with the abrupt intrusion. "A what?"

"A kalaboob!" Sam insisted, her eyes wide with urgency. "Kalamansi and buko juice. I need it now!"

Cynthia groaned, but the pleading looks in Sam's eyes softened her resistance. She knew there was no arguing with a pregnant woman's cravings, especially not at this hour.

"Okay, okay," she relented, dragging herself out of bed. "But where are we going to find kalamansi and boco juice at this time of night?"

Sam's face lit up. "The sari-sari store! It's open 24 hours, right?"

And so, Cynthia found herself stumbling through the dimly lit streets of their town, guided by Sam's insatiable craving. They arrived at the small sari-sari store, the only source of light in the otherwise darkened neighborhood. The tindora, a middle-aged woman with a kind face, peeked out from behind the counter, her eyes widening in surprise at the sight of Cynthia.

"Good evening, Ma'am," Cynthia said, trying to sound as apologetic as possible. "I'm so sorry to bother you so late, but my partner is pregnant, and she's having a craving."

The tindora chuckled, a knowing glint in her eyes. "Ah, pregnancy cravings! I remember those days well. What is she craving?"

"Kalamansi and buko juice," Cynthia replied, feeling a bit ridiculous. "We need to make a 'kalaboob'."

The tindora's eyebrows shot up, but she didn't laugh. Instead, she rummaged through her meager supplies, pulling out a handful of kalamansi and a carton of buko juice. "Here you go, Ma'am. I hope it satisfies her craving."

Back home, Sam mixed the kalamansi and buko juice with feverish anticipation, gulping down the concoction with obvious delight. Cynthia watched her, a mixture of amusement and exhaustion on her face.

The next day, while taking a leisurely walk around town, Sam's cravings struck again, this time with a bizarre twist. They passed an ice cream truck, its cheerful music beckoning them closer. Sam's eyes lit up at the sight of the mango ice cream sandwiches.

"I want one!" she declared, pulling Cynthia toward the truck.

Cynthia smiled, happy to indulge her. "Okay, one mango ice cream sandwich coming up."

As the vendor handed Sam her treat, Cynthia noticed her rummaging in her bag. To Cynthia's amusement and the vendor's utter bewilderment, Sam produced a small cellophane bag filled with bagoong, the pungent Filipino shrimp paste.

Without hesitation, Sam proceeded to sprinkle a generous amount of bagoong onto her mango ice cream sandwich. The vendor stared in disbelief, his mouth agape.

"What in the world...?" he stammered, unable to comprehend the culinary abomination he was witnessing.

Cynthia simply laughed. "She's pregnant," she explained, as if that single word could justify any and all strange food combinations.

The vendor's face broke into a wide grin. "Ah, that explains it! I remember when my wife was pregnant. She used to eat the strangest things!"

Sam, oblivious to the reactions around her, devoured her bagoong-laden ice cream sandwich with gusto, a blissful expression on her face.

Their first prenatal appointment arrived a few days later. They were both anxious, eager to see how the baby was developing and to get some reassurance that everything was alright. But there was also a sense of trepidation, a fear that the doctor would confirm what they already suspected: that this pregnancy was turning Sam into a hormonal monster.

The doctor, a kind and experienced woman, listened patiently to their concerns, nodding sympathetically as Cynthia described Sam's mood swings and bizarre cravings.

"It's all perfectly normal," she assured them. "Pregnancy hormones can do crazy things to a woman's body and emotions. Just try to be patient with each other, and remember that it's all temporary."

As they looked at the ultrasound, they saw the tiny form of their baby, a small miracle growing inside Sam. In that moment, all the anxieties and frustrations seemed to fade away, replaced by a surge of love and anticipation.

Maybe, just maybe, they could weather this storm together. Maybe, despite the bagoong ice cream and the unpredictable mood swings, this pregnancy would ultimately bring them closer, forging a bond that would last a lifetime.

Chapter 12: Reconnection



C

ynthia felt the weight of the day pressing down on her shoulders as she navigated the

familiar streets towards home. The past few months had been a tightrope walk of emotions, balancing her own needs with Sam's fluctuating moods and intense pregnancy cravings. The first trimester had been particularly challenging, a period marked by a growing sense of disconnect. Sam's hormonal changes had turned her into a different person, one moment craving the most bizarre food combinations and the next withdrawing into a cocoon of exhaustion. Intimacy, in any form, had become a distant memory, replaced by a constant undercurrent of tension and misunderstanding.

The aroma of garlic and soy sauce usually filled their apartment, a comforting sign of Sam's culinary experiments. But lately, even that familiar scent seemed to carry a hint of melancholy. Cynthia missed the easy laughter, the shared jokes, and the simple act of holding hands while watching a movie. She missed Sam.

As she reached their apartment door, a sliver of light peeked through the gap. Hesitantly, she pushed the door open, her senses immediately overwhelmed by a scene that seemed plucked from a dream. The harsh fluorescent lights had been replaced by the soft glow of candles, casting dancing shadows on the walls. The air was filled with the smooth, sultry sounds of jazz music, a stark contrast to the usual pop tunes that filled their space.

Her gaze drifted towards the dining table, where two plates were meticulously set. A bouquet of vibrant flowers sat in the center, their colors popping against the crisp white tablecloth. And then she saw it: a steaming bowl of Japanese Shumai, its savory aroma mingling with the sweet scent of jasmine and lavender.

Beside it, a generous serving of Japanese fried rice, glistening with sesame oil. Her heart skipped a beat. Japanese Shumai and fried rice – her absolute favorite.

Before she could fully process the scene, she heard a soft rustle from the bedroom. Sam emerged, her face radiant, her eyes sparkling with an unfamiliar light. She wore a flowing silk robe, its soft fabric accentuating the gentle curve of her growing belly. With a tender smile, she quietly closed the bedroom door behind her.

“Welcome home,” Sam whispered, her voice laced with a warmth that Cynthia hadn’t heard in months.

Cynthia’s mind raced. Was this a dream? Was Sam finally feeling like herself again? Or was this another fleeting moment of connection, destined to fade as quickly as it appeared? She hesitated, afraid to fully embrace the moment, afraid of the inevitable disappointment.

“I… wow,” Cynthia stammered, her voice barely above a whisper. “This is… amazing.”

“I wanted to do something special,” Sam said, her eyes never leaving Cynthia’s. “To show you how much I appreciate you.”

They ate dinner in comfortable silence, punctuated by soft conversation and gentle smiles. Sam was attentive, refilling Cynthia’s wine glass and offering her the choicest pieces of shomi. But beneath the surface, Cynthia remained guarded, unsure of what to expect. She played it cool, careful not to reveal the depth of her longing, afraid of rejection.

As they finished their meal, Sam reached across the table and gently took Cynthia’s hand. Her touch sent a jolt of electricity through Cynthia’s veins. “Come,” Sam said, her voice husky. “I want to show you something.”

She led Cynthia towards the bedroom, the scent of jasmine and lavender growing stronger with each step. Sam opened the door, revealing a scene of pure sensual indulgence. Silk sheets draped the bed, their smooth texture inviting them to shed their inhibitions and succumb to the moment. The candlelight flickered, casting a warm, intimate glow on the room.

Sam turned to Cynthia, her eyes pools of molten desire. She lifted Cynthia's hand, her touch sending shivers down Cynthia's spine, and gently placed it on her breast. The soft swell of her flesh filled Cynthia's palm, her nipple hardening beneath her touch. Sam leaned in, her breath warm against Cynthia's ear, and whispered, "I've missed you."

Her lips brushed against Cynthia's, a feather-light touch that ignited a fire within her. The kiss deepened, tongues meeting in a tentative dance, each seeking and savoring the other. Cynthia's hands moved to Sam's waist, pulling her closer, their bodies molding together.

A low moan rumbled in Cynthia's chest, a primal sound of longing and need. She cupped Sam's face in her hands, her thumbs tracing the delicate curve of her cheekbones. "I want you," she breathed, her voice husky with desire.

Sam's response was immediate, her body arching into Cynthia's touch. She tugged at Cynthia's shirt, her fingers fumbling with the buttons, eager to feel skin against skin. Cynthia obliged, shedding her clothes with a sense of urgency, her eyes never leaving Sam's.

As they stood naked before each other, the candlelight illuminated their bodies, highlighting every curve and contour. Cynthia reached out and ran her hands down Sam's arms, her touch lingering on the swell of her belly. She kissed the soft skin of her stomach, whispering words of love and appreciation.

Sam gasped, her body trembling with anticipation. She guided Cynthia towards the bed, their legs tangling together as they sank onto the silk sheets. Cynthia hovered above Sam; her eyes filled with a mixture of tenderness and desire.

She lowered herself onto Sam, their bodies meeting in a slow, deliberate dance. She kissed her neck, her shoulders, her breasts, each touch igniting a new wave of pleasure. Sam moaned, her body arching beneath Cynthia's, her hands gripping her back.

Their lovemaking was a symphony of sensations, a fusion of bodies and souls. Cynthia was mindful of Sam's pregnancy, careful not to put any pressure on her belly. She explored every inch of Sam's body, teasing and tantalizing her with gentle touches and lingering kisses.

Sam responded with abandon, her body writhing beneath Cynthia's, her moans growing louder with each passing moment. She had never felt so alive, so connected, so utterly consumed by desire.

Cynthia's hands roamed over Sam's skin, her lips tracing the delicate line of her jaw, down her neck, and over her collarbone. She reveled in the softness of her curves, the warmth of her body, the scent of jasmine and lavender that seemed to cling to her skin. Their bodies moved together in perfect harmony, a slow, sensual rhythm that built and built until they both shattered in a shared crescendo of pleasure.

They lay tangled in the silk sheets afterward, their breaths ragged and hearts pounding. Cynthia stroked Sam's hair, her touch tender and loving. "That was... incredible," she whispered.

Sam smiled, her eyes sparkling with contentment. "I know," she said. "I feel like myself again."

Weeks later, during a routine second-trimester check-up, Cynthia and Sam nervously recounted the events of that night. They confessed their anxieties, their fears of having been too intense, of potentially harming the baby.

The doctor listened patiently, a reassuring smile on her face. "It's perfectly normal," she said, her voice calm and reassuring. "The baby is perfectly fine. In fact, many women experience heightened sensitivity and increased libido during the second trimester."

She paused, her smile turning slightly mischievous. "Enjoy it while it lasts," she added. "The third trimester often brings a renewed sense of withdrawal from sexual intimacy. So, savor these moments of connection while you can."

As they left the doctor's office, hand in hand, Cynthia and Sam shared a knowing glance. They had weathered the storm of the first trimester and emerged stronger, more connected than ever before. They knew that the road ahead would have its challenges, but they were ready to face them together, armed with a renewed sense of love, passion, and understanding. The scent of jasmine and lavender lingered in their memories, a reminder of the night they rediscovered each other, a symphony of reconnection that echoed in their hearts.

Chapter 13: A Royal Welcome



Sam floated through the spa, the lavender-infused air a soothing balm to her

soul. Cynthia had been so insistent on her taking a day for herself, and initially, Sam had resisted. Guilt gnawed at her – the nursery wasn’t ready, they still needed to finalize the birth plan, and a million other tiny details buzzed in her mind like persistent mosquitoes. But Cynthia, with that gentle firmness Sam had come to rely on, had booked the appointment and practically pushed her out the door.

Now, hours later, wrapped in a plush robe and with the scent of jasmine clinging to her skin, Sam had to admit it was exactly what she needed. The massage had kneaded away months of tension, the facial had left her skin glowing, and the quiet solitude had allowed her to reconnect with the joy of her pregnancy. The second trimester had indeed brought a welcome reprieve from the relentless nausea and fatigue, and she felt more like herself than she had in months.

As she drove home, a sense of anticipation bubbled inside her. Cynthia had been unusually secretive lately, a mischievous glint in her eyes whenever Sam tried to pry. “Just a little surprise, my love,” she’d say, her voice laced with affection. Sam smiled, imagining what Cynthia could be up to. Maybe she’d finally tackled that overflowing closet, or perhaps she’d managed to assemble the crib without any instructions-related meltdowns.

Pulling into the driveway, Sam noticed Cynthia’s car was gone. “Probably at the store,” she mused, grabbing her spa bag from the passenger seat. The house was quiet as she unlocked the front door, a stark contrast to the lively atmosphere she’d left behind at the spa. “Honey, I’m home!” she called out, but only silence answered.

Stepping further inside, she noticed a trail of teal and purple ribbons leading down the hallway. Her heart skipped a beat. What on earth? Following the whimsical path, she reached the nursery, and her breath caught in her throat.

The room had been transformed. Gone were the bare walls and mismatched furniture. In their place was a vision of whimsical elegance. Soft, lavender walls were adorned with hand-painted teal trees, their branches reaching towards a sky dotted with fluffy, white clouds. A plush, rocking chair sat in the corner, draped with a velvety purple blanket. And in the center of the room, bathed in the soft glow of a custom-made mobile featuring tiny crowns and stars, was the crib – a masterpiece of carved wood, painted in alternating shades of teal and purple.

But that wasn't all. A chorus of voices erupted, "Surprise!" Sam gasped, her eyes widening as a crowd of her closest friends and family spilled out from behind furniture and doorways. And there, in the midst of it all, stood Cynthia, her face beaming with pride and love.

Tears welled in Sam's eyes as she took in the scene. The room was filled with laughter, chatter, and the sweet aroma of catered food. A table laden with delectable treats beckoned – mini quiches, colorful fruit skewers, and delicate pastries. And in the center of it all, a magnificent cake stood tall, adorned with purple and teal frosting and a tiny, edible crown.

"Oh, my love," Sam whispered, her voice thick with emotion. "You did all this?"

Cynthia stepped forward, taking Sam's hands in hers. "I wanted to give our little one a royal welcome," she said, her eyes sparkling. "And to celebrate you, my amazing queen."

The afternoon unfolded in a blur of joy and celebration. Sam was showered with gifts, each one chosen with love and care. She laughed with her friends, shared stories with her family, and savored every moment of the exquisitely planned baby shower. The drag queens, who Cynthia had secretly hired, flitted through the crowd, their vibrant personalities and dazzling outfits adding an extra layer of sparkle to the already magical atmosphere.

As the sun began to set, casting a warm glow over the festivities, Sam found herself sitting next to Cynthia, watching their friends and family mingle and laugh. She leaned her head against Cynthia's shoulder, a profound sense of contentment washing over her.

“Thank you,” she whispered, her voice filled with gratitude. “This is the most beautiful thing anyone has ever done for me.”

Cynthia wrapped her arm around Sam, pulling her close. “You deserve all the beauty in the world, my love,” she said softly. “And so does our little prince or princess.”

In that moment, surrounded by love and laughter, Sam knew that she and Cynthia were ready for whatever the future held. They had built a home filled with love, acceptance, and a healthy dose of sparkle, and they were ready to welcome their little one into their royal family.

Chapter 14: The Ambush



T

he start of the third trimester was like an ambush for Cynthia — a quiet, unexpected shift that hit them both like a wave on a calm shore. One moment, they were back in their normal, happy rhythm: morning coffee shared on the balcony, Sam’s laugh echoing through their small apartment as she teased Cynthia about leaving socks everywhere, long walks in the park where they’d dream about all the little things they couldn’t wait to do with their baby. The next, Sam was unrecognizable — super sensitive, easily annoyed, her patience wearing thin at the smallest things. A door left ajar drew a heavy sigh; a song too loud brought tears to her eyes. Cynthia, ever the therapist, tried to hold space for it all, but even she struggled to keep up with the sudden tide of emotions.

Sam’s complaints became a constant hum in their days. “My legs feel like they’re carrying boulders,” she’d say, rubbing the backs of her thighs until her skin was pink. Her back ached so fiercely she could barely stand for more than a few minutes, leaning against the kitchen counter or Cynthia’s shoulder whenever she could.

Tiredness draped over her like a heavy blanket from the moment she woke up. No position felt right — not on her side, not propped up with pillows, not even in the special pregnancy wedge they’d bought. She’d toss and turn for hours, her belly too big to find ease, and just as her eyes fluttered closed, the baby would kick — hard, deliberate, as if reminding her she wasn’t alone in her restlessness. Sam would lie wide awake, feeling tiny feet push against her ribs, wondering if sleep would ever find her again.

At their monthly checkup, the doctor strongly suggested Lamaze classes. “It’ll help her relax,” she said, her smile warm and knowing as she looked between them. “And it’ll be good to know you’re not alone — you’ll meet other couples, make friends, and feel more confident about what’s coming.” Sam hesitated at first, worried about being judged — stared at, asked intrusive questions, made to feel like she didn’t fit in. But Cynthia squeezed her hand. “Let’s give it a try,” she said. “What do we have to lose?”

So, they went. The first class was overwhelming — a room full of expectant parents, all with their own stories, fears, and excitement. But as the instructor led them through breathing exercises and relaxation techniques, something shifted in Sam. The other women understood — they knew the back pain, the tiredness, the endless kicking. The men sat beside their partners, holding hands, looking just as nervous and hopeful as Cynthia. By the end of the class, they'd exchanged numbers with a couple from down the street, and Sam had laughed for the first time in weeks — a real, full laugh that bubbled up from her chest and crinkled her eyes at the corners. The support was abundant, and they left feeling grateful — like they'd found a little community in the middle of their chaos, one that made them believe this last part of their journey was something amazing they were doing together. They'd expected cruel judgment, whispers about their relationship or their choice to have a baby, but instead, they found love — the kind that comes from people who understand exactly what you're going through.

That night, Cynthia was exhausted. Her work as a therapist had been emotionally straining lately — she'd spent the day listening to clients talk about their pain, struggles, and hopes for a healthier mindset. She'd held space for it all, but by the time she got home, her own energy was gone. They ate a quiet dinner, Sam picking at her food while Cynthia fought to stay awake, then crawled into bed. Within minutes, Cynthia was fast asleep, her breathing deep and steady, her face peaceful in the dim glow of the nightstand lamp.

Sam watched her, a pang of envy twisting in her chest. Here was Cynthia, sleeping soundly with no care in the world, while Sam — surrounded by so many pillows she'd jokingly called herself a "pillow queen" — still couldn't get comfortable. Her back throbbed, her legs cramped, and the baby was kicking again, as if dancing to a song only she could hear. Tears pricked at her eyes as she shifted for the hundredth time, her belly heavy, her body sore. She was so tired, so frustrated, so ready for this to be over — and then she felt it. A sudden, warm gush that made her freeze.

All of a sudden, the bed was soaked.

"Cynthia!" Sam screamed; her voice sharp with panic.

Cynthia woke with a jolt, her eyes flying open. She looked at Sam, then down at the bed, and her eyes widened as the wetness seeped into her own side of the sheets. She flipped on the lamp, and the dark stain spreading across the mattress made Sam's face go completely white. Her eyes were fixed on the mess, her hands trembling as she held her belly.

"It's okay," Cynthia said, her voice surprisingly calm even as her heart hammered. "We need to go to the hospital. You're going to have a baby." She leaned forward and kissed the top of Sam's head — a soft, reassuring gesture that made tears finally spill over.

Cynthia had been preparing for this moment for weeks — she'd packed a bag with everything they'd need: clothes for Sam and the baby, diapers, wipes, a blanket crocheted by Sam's grandmother, a camera to capture the first moments. She grabbed it from the closet, then carefully helped Sam sit up, wrapping her in a robe before guiding her out of bed. Sam's legs were shaky, but she managed to stand, leaning heavily on Cynthia as they made their way to the front door.

Cynthia helped Sam into the car, buckling her seatbelt with steady hands, then climbed behind the wheel. The car roared to life, and though the streets were quiet, she drove fast — her eyes on the road, her mind focused only on getting Sam to the hospital safely. She ran a red light without noticing, her only thought the woman beside her, who was now breathing heavily, her hands clutching the armrest.

When they finally arrived, Cynthia flung her door open and jumped out, running around to Sam's side. "Please!" she called to the guard on duty, her voice urgent. "My Wife is about to give birth — we need help!"

The guard didn't ask questions. He ran into the hospital and returned a moment later with a wheelchair. Together, they helped Sam into it, and a nurse appeared immediately, pushing her down the hallway with quick, purposeful steps. Sam's contractions were coming rapidly now — sharp and intense — and she cried out as another one hit. Cynthia walked beside her, holding her hand, whispering encouragement: "You're doing amazing, baby. Just a little longer. We're almost there."

They made it to the delivery room just in time. The nurses worked quickly, getting Sam settled in the bed, checking her vitals, preparing for the birth. Cynthia stayed by her side the whole time, holding her hand, wiping sweat from her forehead, telling her how much she loved her. Sam pushed with all her strength, her body working hard to bring their baby into the world, and it wasn't long before they heard it — a soft, tiny cry that filled the room.

The nurse lifted the baby up, cleaned her gently, then placed her on Sam's chest. Sam looked down at the tiny, pink face, the dark hair sticking up in tufts, the closed eyes — and a smile spread across her face, so bright and full of love that Cynthia felt tears prick her own eyes.

“Lucy,” Sam said, her voice soft, tired but joyful. She looked up at Cynthia. “Is Lucy, okay? Can we name her Lucy?”

Cynthia looked from Sam to their daughter, her heart swelling with pride. “Yes,” she said, her voice thick with emotion. “I like the name Lucy. Perfect.”

As Sam held their daughter, her fingers tracing tiny fingers, Cynthia leaned down and kissed her — this time on the lips, a kiss full of love, gratitude, and relief. The ambush of the third trimester, the tiredness, the pain, the fear — it had all led to this moment, to the miracle lying on Sam's chest. And in that instant, they both knew that every difficult moment had been worth it.

Chapter 15: Lonely Dawn



C

ynthia is over the moon happy to have Sam and Lucy home from the hospital. It had only been a couple days there—just long enough for Lucy’s routine birth and Sam’s quick recovery—and everything was calm and simple. Lucy appeared to be healthy and normal from the moment she was born: ten tiny fingers, ten tiny toes, a full head of dark hair, and eyes that seemed to take in everything around, her. As a mental health therapist, Cynthia had spent years helping others navigate chaos, so the quiet drive back to their home in Davao City felt like a gift—Sam holding Lucy’s tiny hand in her own, Cynthia glancing at them in the rearview mirror every few seconds, just to make sure they were real. The hospital had been filled with kind nurses and soft rooms, but now, as they walked through the front door, the scent of ripe mangoes (Cynthia had left a bowl on the table that morning) wrapped around them, and she could hear the familiar hum of tricycles passing by outside. It was exactly how she’d pictured their first day home together.

For two weeks, things were perfect. Cynthia and Sam took turns like clockwork taking care of Lucy, sharing the responsibility equally. Every morning, one would make coffee while the other changed Lucy’s diaper.

Every night, they’d trade off getting up for feedings—Sam at 1 AM, Cynthia at 4 AM—a silent, seamless dance that made them feel like a well-oiled machine. They’d sit on the couch together after dinner, Lucy nestled between them, watching old Filipino teleseryes and talking about all the things they wanted to do with her: take her to People’s Park, teach her to speak Cebuano, watch her take her first steps on the balcony overlooking the city. They laughed at the silly faces Lucy made when she ate, cried happy tears when she cooed for the first time, and held each other tight whenever the weight of how much they loved her felt too big to carry. It was a bubble of perfect peace, and neither of them wanted it to end.

Then, like a switch went off, Sam started displaying symptoms of postpartum depression. As someone who'd treated dozens of clients with the same condition, Cynthia recognized the signs immediately—small, quiet shifts at first. Sam would forget to put Lucy's bottles in the dishwasher, or she'd stare out the window for hours, not hearing when Cynthia spoke to her. Her smiles became thin and forced, and she stopped asking to hold Lucy as much. One night, Cynthia found her sitting on the floor of the nursery, tears rolling down her face, her hands wrapped around her knees. "I don't know how to be a mom," she whispered, her voice hollow. Cynthia pulled her close, trying to use the gentle, grounding words she'd use with her clients—but it felt different when it was the person she loved most. She could feel a distance growing between them—like a fog was rolling in, obscuring the perfect world they'd built. Sam started sleeping less, even when it was her turn to rest, and she'd snap at Cynthia over tiny things—like leaving the cap off the baby powder or playing music too loud.

Then, as if on cue, Lucy started having seizures. It was a Tuesday afternoon, while Sam was giving her a bath.

Cynthia was in the kitchen making lunch when she heard Sam scream—a sound of pure terror that made her drop the knife she was holding. She ran to the bathroom to find Lucy lying in the tub, her little body convulsing, her eyes rolled back in her head. Cynthia's heart stopped. It was impossible—Lucy had been so healthy, so normal, just minutes before. She grabbed a towel, wrapped Lucy up, and held her tight, her hands shaking as she tried to keep her still. The seizure lasted only a few seconds, but it felt like forever. When it was over, Lucy was limp in her arms, her breathing shallow. They didn't waste a second—Sam grabbed the car keys, Cynthia held Lucy, and they raced to the hospital, their hands clenched tight, their minds filled with fear.

They take Lucy to the doctors to see what is wrong with her. The waiting room felt like a prison—every second ticking by slower than the last. Lucy was awake now, looking up at them with big, confused eyes, and Cynthia wanted nothing more than to take away whatever was hurting her. Finally, the doctor called them back into his office. He sat down across from them, his face serious, and pulled out a stack of papers.

The doctor diagnoses Lucy with a rare genetic disorder called CDKL5. “It affects brain development,” he said, his voice gentle but firm. “It causes seizures, developmental delays, and sleep problems. There’s no cure, but we can manage the symptoms with medication and therapy.” Cynthia felt the floor drop out from under her. Rare. Incurable. Lifelong. The words echoed in her head as she stared at Lucy, who was now sucking on her fist, oblivious to the news. How could this happen to a baby who’d seemed so perfectly healthy just days before?

Sam starts to blame herself because of the postpartum depression. “It’s my fault,” she said immediately, her voice breaking. “I gave this to her. I’m a bad mom—I knew I couldn’t do this right.” Cynthia tried to tell her it wasn’t true, that genetic disorders don’t work that way—she’d explained this to clients before, but Sam wouldn’t listen. The guilt wrapped around her like a noose, tightening with every seizure Lucy had, every night she couldn’t sleep.

Cynthia was trying to keep Sam afloat while caring for Lucy with special needs who isn’t sleeping at all at night and only sleeps during the day. Lucy’s sleep schedule was completely reversed—she’d stay awake for hours after dark, crying and having small seizures, and only doze off for short stretches during the day.

Cynthia found herself pulling double duty: staying up all night with Lucy, then getting up in the morning to make breakfast for Sam, to talk to her, to try to make her see that she wasn’t alone. Her job at the local mental health clinic was already demanding, but she was used to holding space for others—now, she had no space left for herself. She was exhausted—her eyes were heavy, her body ached, her mind was foggy—but she couldn’t stop. She had to keep her family together.

Sam, struggling also with sleep deprivation and trying to care for Lucy, reached her breaking point when Cynthia heard her screaming at Lucy. It was 3 AM, and Lucy had been crying for hours. Cynthia had just stepped into the hallway to get a glass of water when she heard Sam yell, “Shut up! Just shut up already!” She ran back into the bedroom to find Sam standing over the crib, her hands tight around Lucy’s shoulders, shaking her hard. “I can’t take it anymore!” Sam screamed, her face twisted with rage and exhaustion.

Cynthia acted without thinking—she lunged forward, pulled Lucy out of Sam’s hands, and held her close to her chest, her own heart pounding so hard she could barely breathe. Tears streamed down her face, but her voice was sharp and angry, filled with terror and frustration. “What are you doing? She’s a baby!” she yelled, then added, her voice cracking but firm, “That’s it—this is over. It’s time you leave. Now. Go get help, take care of yourself—then maybe, when you’re better, you can come back to us. But right now, you can’t be here.”

Sam stared at her, her eyes wide with shock, as if she didn’t recognize either Cynthia or her own hands. After a long, heavy silence, she nodded slowly. “You’re right,” she whispered. “I’ll leave in the morning. Get the help I need.”

Sam leaves the following morning, carrying only a small bag. She hugged Cynthia tightly at the door, her eyes filled with tears she couldn’t hold back. “I love you both,” she said, then turned and walked away, disappearing into the busy Davao Street. Cynthia stood there for a long time, Lucy in her arms, watching until Sam was out of sight. Then she closed the door, walked to the couch, and sat down. As Lucy dozed off against her chest, Cynthia finally let herself cry—big, heaving sobs that wracked her body. She thought about her work, about how she helped others find their way through darkness every day, and the cruel irony of not knowing how to navigate her own. How would she manage her clinic, keep up with her paperwork, get Lucy to doctor’s appointments, stay up with her at night, and still keep everything from falling apart? In that quiet room, surrounded by the empty space Sam had left behind, she had no idea how she was going to do it all.

Chapter 16: What She Feels



T

he house felt different in the morning. Not louder. Not quieter. Just unbalanced. Cynthia woke before the alarm, her body trained by months of fractured sleep. For a brief second, she reached across the bed out of habit. Cold sheets. Right.

She lay there staring at the ceiling while the baby monitor hummed softly on her nightstand. Lucy shifted, a small restless sound crackling through the speaker. Cynthia held her breath automatically, waiting.

One beat. Two. Three. No seizure. She exhaled.

“Okay,” she whispered to the empty room. “We’re okay.”

She got up before she could think about anything else.

By 6:30 a.m., Lucy was on her changing table kicking weakly at the air while Cynthia moved with mechanical efficiency. Diaper. Cream. Medication syringe. Gentle kiss to the forehead.

Lucy’s eyes drifted slightly to the left — not quite tracking.

Cynthia noticed. She always noticed.

CDKL5 had turned her into someone who monitored micro-movements like they were weather warnings.

Every twitch meant something. Every pause in breathing carried possibility.

“You’re doing your best,” Cynthia murmured to Lucy.

She wasn’t sure if she meant Lucy or herself.

In the kitchen, she balanced Lucy against her chest while pouring coffee. The weight of her daughter felt heavier lately — not physically, but existentially. Like she was holding the fragile center of the universe and pretending it wasn’t terrifying.

Her phone buzzed on the counter. Sam. Cynthia stared at the screen until it went dark again. Not yet.

Her first telehealth session began at 8:00 a.m. sharp.

Cynthia adjusted the lighting in her home office, angling the camera so the bassinet just barely sat out of frame. Lucy was awake but quiet, one small hand twitching against the blanket.

Her client appeared on screen — mid-thirties, exhausted, talking about caregiver burnout for her aging father.

“I just feel like I can’t fall apart,” the woman said. “If I fall apart, everything collapses.”

Cynthia felt the words land somewhere tender.

“That’s a heavy responsibility,” she replied gently. “What would it mean if you allowed yourself too not be the strong one for a moment?”

Lucy let out a soft whimper.

Cynthia’s leg began rocking the bassinet automatically.

The client continued, unaware. “There isn’t anyone else to take over.”

Cynthia swallowed.

She guided breathing exercises. Reframing techniques. Emotional validation.

All while tracking Lucy’s breathing in the periphery of her vision.

Therapist voice steady. Heart racing underneath.

By the end of the session, Lucy had escalated into a sharp cry.

Cynthia smiled apologetically at the camera. “Let’s pause here for today. You did important work.”

The screen went dark.

Cynthia scooped Lucy up immediately, pressing her against her shoulder. The crying pierced straight through her skull.

“I know,” she whispered, pacing. “I know.”

For a flicker of a second — just one — frustration sparked. A flash of heat.

Then shame followed instantly. She held Lucy tighter. “I’m here. I’m here.”

The neurologist appointment was at 1:15.

Cynthia packed the diaper bag with military precision: extra medication, emergency protocol sheet, two changes of clothes, seizure log notebook. She had become meticulous. Organized chaos was still chaos.

In the car, Lucy stared upward, fingers jerking in small repetitive motions.

At every red light, Cynthia checked the rearview mirror.

Please don’t seize while I’m driving. Please.

The hospital smelled like antiseptic and over-brewed coffee.

In the exam room, fluorescent lights buzzed faintly. Lucy lay on crinkled paper while the neurologist reviewed her chart.

“We’re seeing increased activity overnight,” he said, scrolling through data. “We may need to adjust her medication again.”

Again.

Cynthia nodded and took notes. Dosage changes. Potential side effects. Watch for respiratory suppression.

Her handwriting stayed steady.

Inside, she felt like glass.

“Do you have adequate support at home?” he asked carefully.

The question lingered too long in the air.

“Yes,” she said automatically.

Then, softer: “We’re... adjusting.”

He gave her a look that said he understood more than she’d said.

“Caregiver fatigue is real,” he added. “Especially with complex epilepsy cases.”

Cynthia forced a small smile. “I’m a therapist.”

He nodded. “That doesn’t make you immune.”

The words followed her all the way back to the car.

Lucy’s seizure happened at 4:08 p.m.

Short. Thirty-five seconds.

But violent enough to make Cynthia’s stomach drop.

She had been finishing documentation from her last session when she heard the change in breathing through the monitor — that awful rhythmic hitch. She ran.

Lucy’s tiny body stiffened in her crib; eyes unfocused.

Cynthia counted aloud automatically. “One... two... three...”

Her voice shook on twelve.

When it stopped, Lucy went limp, exhausted.

Cynthia lifted her carefully, pressing her cheek against Lucy’s damp hair.

“You’re okay. You’re okay.”

Her own breathing took longer to regulate.

She sank onto the nursery floor, back against the crib, Lucy in her lap.

The house was silent again.

Too silent.

Her phone buzzed.

Sam.

Cynthia stared at the name, emotions tangling — anger, longing, resentment, love.

You get to step away. I have to hold everything. But then another thought:

She stepped away so Lucy would be safe. Cynthia answered.

“She had a seizure,” she said quietly. There was sharp inhalation on the other end. “Is she—”

“She’s okay.”

Silence stretched between them.

“I scheduled therapy,” Sam said finally. “And I talked to my doctor about medication.”

Cynthia closed her eyes.

Somewhere deep inside, tension loosened half a degree.

“That’s good,” she whispered.

After they hung up, Cynthia sat there a little longer.

Lucy’s breathing evened out against her chest.

The dishes were still in the sink. Notes still unfinished. Laundry still waiting.

The world had not paused because she was overwhelmed.

She pressed her lips to Lucy’s forehead.

“I don’t know how to do this alone,” she admitted softly.

The confession felt dangerous.

But also, honest.

She stood slowly, adjusting Lucy against her shoulder.

She might not feel strong.

She might not feel steady.

But for today —

She was enough.

And tomorrow, she would wake up and do it again.

Chapter 17: Fifteen Minutes



Cynthia woke before the alarm again. Lucy had seized at 2:11 a.m. Not long. Forty seconds. Long enough.

Cynthia had counted softly in the dark, one hand on Lucy's chest, the other gripping the edge of the crib so tightly her knuckles ached. When it ended, she'd stood there longer than necessary, watching for the subtle rhythm of breath.

She didn't go back to sleep after that.

By 6:00 a.m., she was in the kitchen reheating coffee that tasted like metal. Lucy lay in the portable bassinet nearby, eyes unfocused, one hand twitching in small repetitive movements.

Cynthia watched the hand.

Was that seizure activity?

Or just motor delay?

She hated that she couldn't tell anymore.

"I need you to give me a calm day," she whispered softly.

Lucy blinked at the ceiling.

Her first session started at eight.

Cynthia adjusted the lighting in her office and positioned the bassinet just out of frame. She smoothed her hair, pressed her shoulders back, and clicked "Join Meeting."

Her client, a woman navigating divorce, immediately began crying.

"I feel like everything is falling apart," the woman said.

Cynthia nodded gently. "It makes sense that this feels destabilizing," she replied in her warm, even therapist voice. "What feels most overwhelming right now?" Lucy stirred.

Cynthia rocked the bassinet with her foot without breaking eye contact with the screen.

The woman continued, voice shaking. “I don’t know who I am without my marriage.”

Cynthia felt that one land somewhere too close.

Who am I without my partner beside me?

She stayed composed.

Validated. Reflected. Grounded.

Lucy began to fuss halfway through the session — soft at first, then sharper. Cynthia’s chest tightened with every rising cry.

“I’m going to pause you for one moment,” she said gently to the client. “Stay with that thought.”

She muted herself and scooped Lucy up, swaying automatically.

“Please, sweetheart,” she murmured.

The crying intensified.

By the time the session ended, Cynthia’s pulse was racing.

She hadn’t eaten by noon.

Her hands shook slightly as she typed case notes. Lucy had dozed off against her chest after a brief seizure at 11:43 a.m. Cynthia had felt it before she’d seen it — that subtle shift in breathing.

She had logged it automatically.

11:43 a.m. 25 seconds. Mild stiffening. Quick recovery. The words looked clinical on paper.

They did not reflect the way her heart had slammed into her ribs.

Her phone buzzed with a reminder to pick up Lucy’s adjusted prescription.

Right. Function. Move.

She transferred Lucy carefully into the car seat and drove to the pharmacy.

Lucy cried the entire time. The high, frantic kind that made it hard to think.

“Please,” Cynthia whispered at a red light. “I’m right here.”

As if summoned by the stress, Lucy's body stiffened mid-cry. Cynthia's stomach dropped. "No, no, no." She counted aloud while cars idled behind her. "Five... six... seven..."

Horns blared when the light turned green.

She finished counting through tears.

"Twenty-eight... twenty-nine..."

It stopped. Lucy went limp, exhausted.

Cynthia drove on shaking hands.

The breaking point came quietly.

Back home, Lucy refused the bottle.

She turned her head sharply, small cries escalating into full, breathless screams. Cynthia repositioned her.

Checked the temperature. Tried burping.

Nothing worked.

"I know you're hungry," Cynthia said, trying to keep her voice steady.

Lucy screamed louder.

The sound filled the kitchen, bounced off tile and cabinets, burrowed into Cynthia's skull.

She felt the crack start at her sternum. A splintering. "I am trying," she whispered.

Lucy arched and cried harder.

The room felt too bright. Too small. Too loud.

Cynthia set the bottle down carefully on the counter, afraid of slamming it. Afraid of herself.

She stepped back. Just one step. Lucy's crying continued.

Her heart began to race, breath coming shallow and fast.

For a flicker — just a flicker — she understood Sam in a way that terrified her.

The relentlessness. The way the sound scraped against raw nerves.

The way exhaustion turned love into something frantic and brittle.

“I can’t,” she whispered.

Her legs gave out and she slid down the cabinet to the floor.

The sob came out of nowhere.

Huge. Ugly. Uncontrolled.

Lucy cried in her seat.

Cynthia pressed her palms to her eyes as tears streamed through her fingers.

“I can’t do this alone,” she gasped.

The words felt like failure.

They also felt true.

Lucy’s crying hit a pitch that snapped Cynthia back to herself. She scrambled forward, scooping her daughter up immediately, guilt flooding hot and fast.

“I’m here. I’m here. I’m so sorry.”

Lucy’s cries softened into hiccupping sobs against her shoulder.

Cynthia rocked her, tears falling into Lucy’s hair.

She couldn’t call Sam.

Sam was fighting her own battle.

Cynthia needed someone who could hold her without breaking too.

She reached blindly for her phone.

Scrolled.

Mark.

She hit call before she could overthink it.

He answered immediately.

“If this is about brunch plans, I vote waffles—”

“I can’t do this.”

Her voice broke completely.

Silence.

Not confused silence.

Focused silence.

“What happened?” he asked, voice instantly steady.

Cynthia tried to explain between sobs. “The seizures and the crying and I have clients and I’m so tired,

Mark. I am so tired.”

Lucy whimpered softly against her chest.

Mark exhaled slowly.

“Okay. First of all, you are not failing. Second — where are you?”

“At home.”

“Good. Stay there.”

In the background, another voice rose — warm, dramatic, unmistakable.

“Is that Cynthia? Put me on speaker right now.”

Alexa.

Even in crisis, Cynthia felt a flicker of comfort.

“She’s okay,” Cynthia managed weakly.

“Oh honey, I wasn’t asking about the baby,” Alexa said firmly. “You sound like you’re two seconds from collapsing. That’s the emergency.”

Mark came back on the line. “We’re coming over.”

“You don’t have to—”

“Cynthia,” he said gently but firmly. “You showed up for me after my dad died. You sat on my kitchen

floor at three in the morning and didn't say a word. Let me show up now."

Her throat closed.

"We'll be there in fifteen," Alexa added. "And I swear if you try to clean before we arrive, I will personally revoke your therapist license."

Despite everything, a shaky laugh escaped Cynthia.

"Okay," she whispered.

She hung up and stayed on the kitchen floor, Lucy curled against her chest.

The crying had stopped.

Lucy's breathing evened out slowly.

Cynthia pressed her cheek to her daughter's head.

Help was coming.

Not because she had everything under control.

But because she finally admitted she didn't.

And for the first time all day, she allowed herself to believe that maybe — just maybe — she didn't have to hold the line alone.

Chapter 18: Support Comes



The doorbell rang just as Cynthia had finished putting Lucy down for a short nap.

“Fifteen minutes early,” she muttered, a small laugh escaping through the tears that had lingered from yesterday.

Mark was first in, carrying a six-pack of San Miguel beer — her favorite — and a large duffel bag. Alexa followed, hands full with a small pile of clean blankets and a diaper bag. Their presence filled the apartment like sunlight cutting through the shadows that had lingered the past few days.

“I know you’ve been surviving, not living,” Alexa said, setting down the blankets and patting Lucy gently on the head. “So, we’re here to help.”

Mark handed her the beer. “And emergency morale support. Calories optional, courage guaranteed.”

Cynthia smiled, a small but real one, feeling the weight on her shoulders loosen just enough to breathe.

She didn’t have to say anything — they already understood.

They sat on the floor around Lucy’s play mat. The baby gurgled happily, flailing tiny arms and kicking her legs, completely oblivious to the emotional gravity of the past two days.

“Okay,” Mark said between sips of coffee, “here’s the plan. Alexa and I are moving in. Temporarily.

Totally temporary. You get a break.”

“You don’t have to—” Cynthia began, but Alexa cut her off with a sharp, gentle laugh.

“Nope. You were alone for days. This is overdue.”

Cynthia let the words sink in. The idea of someone else carrying part of the load — appointments, meals, laundry, even the little daily things that always piled up — made her throat tighten. Relief, guilt, and gratitude all tangled at once.

“We’ll start with mornings,” Alexa said, “so you can focus on your clients. Mark works from home, so he can take Lucy to any appointments you can’t step away from.”

Cynthia nodded, letting tears prick the corners of her eyes. She didn’t have to justify herself. She didn’t have to hold everything alone anymore.

“I’ll coordinate the appointments,” Mark added. “We’ve got this.”

Chapter 19: Returning



Cynthia finally felt a weight lift from her shoulders. After weeks of constant care for Lucy, her spirited daughter who lived with CDKL5, a rare neurological disorder, Cynthia had a rare moment to breathe. Alexa, her dependable friend and support system, had stepped in to help. With Alexa's help, Cynthia could take a deep breath and actually plan an outing without feeling panic about what might happen at home. Today, she decided, would be a day at the park—just her and Lucy, enjoying something normal, something carefree, even if just for a few hours.

Lucy, with her bright eyes and quick, playful movements, clutched Cynthia's hand tightly as they walked toward the swings. The sunlight made Lucy giggle as it danced across her hair, and Cynthia couldn't help but smile. These were the moments she treasured most—the simple, quiet joys. Seeing Lucy laugh, seeing her curiosity, even if tempered by the challenges CDKL5 presented, reminded Cynthia why she fought so hard every day.

As they approached the center of the park, Cynthia noticed a woman sitting on a bench beneath a large oak tree. She was dressed modestly, her head covered with a scarf, and she held a small book in her hands that looked like it could be a Bible. The woman's eyes lifted as Cynthia and Lucy drew closer, and she smiled politely. Cynthia returned the smile and nudged Lucy toward the swings, letting her explore for a moment. Lucy's laughter echoed across the park, drawing the woman's attention once again.

Finally, the woman spoke. “What a beautiful child,” she said, her voice gentle but carrying a tone that made Cynthia slightly uneasy. “But I hope you’re aware... illnesses like hers... sometimes they’re a result of choices made by the parents. Sin, in a way. God has a plan, yes, but we can’t ignore consequences.”

Cynthia froze, unsure how to respond. She recognized the judgment in the woman’s eyes, in the words she hadn’t quite said but implied. “I’m sorry?” she asked cautiously.

The woman, who introduced herself as Melinda, continued, her voice firm. “I just mean that sometimes children are born with... difficulties because of the choices their parents made. God doesn’t make mistakes, but He allows lessons to happen. Perhaps... having Lucy is your lesson.” Cynthia’s heart tightened. She had anticipated questions, worried looks, even pity, but never this. This wasn’t just ignorance; it was a judgment against her and Sam, her partner, as if they deserved Lucy’s condition. She took a deep breath, trying to remain calm, refusing to let her anger take control.

“Melinda,” she began slowly, “I understand that you believe in your faith, and I respect that. But I have to be honest—what you just said is hurtful. It’s not a punishment or a lesson that we were supposed to endure. Lucy is here, and she’s amazing, and her life has meaning just as much as anyone else’s.”

Melinda looked startled, as if Cynthia’s words had caught her off guard. Cynthia continued, trying to explain without sounding defensive, without giving in to the instinct to argue angrily. “You know, a lot of heterosexual couples have children. Many of them are planned—carefully planned, even before conception. They make decisions, they prepare, and they hope everything goes smoothly. But not everything in life is predictable.

Some children are born with conditions that no one could have foreseen, no one could have prevented.”

She paused, squeezing Lucy’s small hand in hers. “Sam and I... we actually went to a fertility clinic. Sam wanted to be the first to carry a child through artificial insemination. We planned as carefully as any couple could. We wanted a child, and we took every precaution, every step, to make it happen safely. Lucy’s CDKL5 isn’t anyone’s fault, not ours, not God’s in the way you’re thinking. It’s just... the reality of life.”

Melinda’s gaze softened slightly, but Cynthia wasn’t finished. She shook her head, letting a gentle sadness creep into her voice. “Life isn’t about punishment. There are no coincidences, no cosmic punishments for the choices we make. Everything happens for a reason—not because someone did something wrong, not because God is punishing anyone. Lucy exists because she’s meant to, because she’s part of our lives, part of the world, and part of something bigger than our understanding.”

Lucy, sensing the tension, reached out and grabbed Cynthia’s other hand. Her giggle was a reminder of what truly mattered. Cynthia knelt down to meet Lucy’s gaze, brushing her hair from her eyes. “See, Melinda? Life doesn’t have to be about judgment. It’s about love, support, and the moments we share. Lucy teaches us every day about resilience, about joy, about courage. That’s her purpose. That’s her reason for being here, not to serve as a lesson about right or wrong.”

Melinda looked at Lucy, and for the first time, her eyes seemed to see the child rather than the condition. Cynthia felt a flicker of relief but stayed careful. “I know your beliefs are important to you,” Cynthia said gently. “But please try to understand—life isn’t always a simple equation of sin and consequence. It’s complex, messy, and beautiful.

Lucy is proof of that beauty, of the goodness in the world, and we honor her by loving her fully, not by judging her existence.”

The park seemed quieter after that, the noise of children and laughter fading into a calm lull as Cynthia stood. Lucy tugged at her hand, eager to explore again, and Cynthia smiled down at her, feeling gratitude for these small, profound moments. She realized that part of her fight wasn’t just for Lucy’s health, but for her right to exist fully and joyfully without anyone questioning her worth.

Melinda remained silent, looking at Lucy and then back at Cynthia. There was an awkward pause, but Cynthia didn’t wait for agreement or acknowledgment. She had said what needed to be said, firmly and with love, and that was enough for now. Holding Lucy close, she whispered, “Let’s go swing, baby girl. Let’s enjoy today, just you and me.”

Lucy’s laughter rose into the air once again, pure and unrestrained, and Cynthia felt a warmth in her chest. No judgment, no misunderstanding, could overshadow these moments. In that park, in that sunlight, with her daughter beside her, Cynthia knew one undeniable truth: Lucy’s life mattered exactly as it was, and that was reason enough for joy.

Chapter 20: Distance Between



C

ynthia stared at Sam's name glowing on her phone before answering.

For a moment, she let it ring. Not because she didn't want to talk—but because every call carried weight. Every conversation felt like stepping into fragile territory.

She answered on the fourth ring.

“Hey.”

Sam's voice was soft, cautious. “Hey.”

There was the faint hum of traffic on Sam's end. Cynthia pictured her sitting in her car outside her apartment again, gathering courage before going inside.

“How was therapy?” Cynthia asked.

A small exhale crackled through the speaker. “Heavy.”

“That good, huh?”

Sam gave a humorless laugh. “Yeah. That good.”

Silence stretched for a beat, but it wasn't empty. It was full of things neither of them quite knew how to say.

“We're... digging deeper,” Sam finally said. “Not just the postpartum stuff anymore.”

Cynthia shifted on the couch, tucking her legs under her. “Deeper how?”

“Childhood,” Sam replied. The word came out tight. “Triggers. Patterns. All the crap I thought I'd already dealt with.”

Cynthia swallowed. “You never really talked about that.”

“I know.” Another pause.

“I didn’t think I needed to,” Sam continued. “I thought I’d moved past it. But apparently shoving things down for twenty years isn’t the same as healing.”

Cynthia almost smiled at that. It sounded like something Sam’s therapist would say.

“What kind of triggers?” she asked gently.

Sam hesitated. Cynthia could hear her blinking back emotion, the way her breathing shifted when she was trying not to cry.

“Lucy crying,” Sam admitted. “Not all the time. But when she can’t be soothed right away. It does something to me. I don’t even realize it until I’m already shutting down.”

Cynthia’s chest tightened. “You never told me that.”

“I didn’t understand it at first.” Sam’s voice dropped. “It makes me feel like I’m five again. Like I’m alone in a room and nobody’s coming.”

The words landed hard.

Cynthia closed her eyes. “Sam...”

“I know it sounds dramatic.”

“It doesn’t,” Cynthia said quickly. “It doesn’t sound dramatic.”

There was a faint sniff on the other end of the line.

“My therapist says postpartum depression didn’t create this,” Sam went on. “It just stripped away all the coping mechanisms I’ve been using forever. The independence. The emotional distance. All of it. Once Lucy was here, I couldn’t hide from myself anymore.”

Cynthia leaned her head back against the couch. “Is that why you won’t come home?”

Sam didn’t answer right away.

“Yes,” she finally said.

The word felt heavier than anything else.

“I can’t come back half-fixed,” Sam continued. “I can’t risk disappearing again.”

“You didn’t disappear,” Cynthia said, though her voice wavered. “You were struggling.”

“I left,” Sam replied quietly. “Maybe not physically at first. But I checked out. I saw it in your eyes.”

Cynthia pressed her lips together. She had seen it too. The way Sam would stare past her. The way holding Lucy sometimes looked like holding something fragile and unfamiliar.

“I’m still seeing my therapist twice a week,” Sam said. “We’re working on identifying what sets me off before I spiral. We’re tracing it back instead of me just running from it.”

“And how’s that going?” Cynthia asked.

“It’s messy,” Sam admitted. “I hate it. I hate sitting in feelings I’ve avoided my whole life. But... I think it’s working.”

Cynthia let that settle.

Lucy’s faint babbling echoed from the baby monitor on the coffee table. Sam heard it too.

“Is she okay?” Sam asked immediately.

“She’s fine,” Cynthia said softly. “She just woke up from her nap.”

There was a long silence on Sam’s end, the kind filled with longing.

“I miss her,” Sam whispered.

“I know.”

“I miss you too.”

Cynthia’s throat tightened. “Then come home.” The plea slipped out before she could stop it.

Sam’s breathing hitched. “I want to,” she said. “God, I want to. But you deserve the best version of me. Lucy does too.”

“I don’t need perfect,” Cynthia said, her voice breaking. “I need you.”

“You need someone stable,” Sam replied. “Someone who doesn’t shut down when things get overwhelming. Someone who doesn’t feel like running every time she’s triggered.”

“You’re not the only one who gets overwhelmed,” Cynthia shot back, more sharply than she intended. “You think I haven’t been barely holding it together?”

Silence.

“I know,” Sam said quietly. “And that’s part of it. When you’re frustrated or exhausted, I feel like I’m failing you. And then that old voice in my head starts up again, telling me I’m too much. Or not enough. And I panic.”

Cynthia’s anger dissolved into something sadder.

“So instead of staying and working through it with me,” she said carefully, “you leave before you can be left.”

Sam didn’t deny it.

“Yeah,” she said. “That’s exactly what I do.”

The honesty hung between them.

“My therapist says I have to learn how to stay,” Sam continued. “To sit in discomfort without bolting. To recognize that a slammed door or a raised voice isn’t the end of the world.”

Cynthia thought about all the small arguments they’d had—ordinary relationship friction that had somehow felt catastrophic to Sam.

“I don’t want Lucy growing up with a mother who’s one step away from leaving,” Sam said, her voice trembling. “I don’t want her to feel what I felt. I need to break this before I pass it on.”

Cynthia wiped at her eyes.

“You really think staying away is the only way to do that?”

“For now,” Sam said. “This distance... it’s not me running. It’s me trying to make sure that when I come back, I don’t run again.”

Lucy’s babbling turned into a small cry through the monitor.

Cynthia glanced toward the hallway.

“I have to get her,” she said softly.

“Okay.”

Neither of them hung up.

“Cynthia?” Sam added quickly.

“Yeah?”

“I’m not staying away because I don’t love you.”

“I know.”

“I’m staying away because I love you both so much it scares me.”

Cynthia let out a shaky breath. “Just don’t take so long trying to become the best version of yourself that we forget how to be a family.”

Sam’s voice broke. “I won’t.”

“Promise?”

“I’m learning how to keep those.”

Cynthia stood, the baby monitor still crackling.

“We’ll talk tomorrow?” she asked.

“Yeah,” Sam said. “Tomorrow.”

They lingered for a second longer, suspended in the fragile space between distance and devotion.

Then the line went quiet.

Sam still wasn’t home.

But for the first time, Cynthia could hear it in her voice—

She wasn't running.

She was trying to learn how to stay.

Chapter 21: Between Seasons



Cynthia had stopped measuring time in days.

She measured it in weekends.

Not every weekend—only the ones Sam could make it home.

They still weren't living together. Sam kept the small apartment near the ranger station, close to the mountains that demanded so much of her. Her work as a park ranger rarely followed a predictable schedule. Some weeks were quiet: trail maintenance, guided hikes, paperwork stacked on her desk. Other weeks, a lost hiker, a sudden storm, or an emergency rescue on the mountain swallowed every spare hour she had.

When Sam came home, it was usually once a month.

Sometimes more.

Sometimes less.

There were stretches when six weeks passed before Cynthia saw her in person. In between, there were phone calls—morning check-ins, late-night conversations after Lucy had fallen asleep, quick texts sent from trailheads or ranger trucks parked beneath wide, open sky.

Cynthia had accepted this as the new rhythm of their life.

Not the life they had dreamed about—but the life they had.

When Sam's car finally pulled into the driveway, something in Cynthia's chest always lifted. Lucy would recognize the sound now, toddling toward the window with a squeal. Cynthia would wipe her hands on a dish towel or set aside whatever she was doing and walk outside, steadying herself before Sam stepped out of the car.

Those reunions were never dramatic.

Just warm.

Sam would scoop Lucy up first, burying her face in her daughter's neck like she was breathing her in. Lucy would giggle, grabbing at Sam's ranger hat, tugging on her hair. Cynthia would stand close enough to feel Sam's shoulder brush against hers.

And for a moment, it would feel like a family.

When they were together, it was wonderful.

They went on long walks through the nature preserve near the house, Sam pointing out birds and trees, explaining things Lucy was still too young to understand but listened to anyway.

Cynthia loved watching Sam in those moments—grounded, steady, confident. The mountains made sense to her. The trails had structure. There were clear markers, predictable hazards, solutions to most problems.

At home, the evenings were quieter. They cooked together while Lucy sat in her highchair, banging a spoon against the tray. They curled up on the couch and watched their favorite shows, the ones they had followed long before Lucy was born. Sam would rest her hand on Cynthia's knee. Cynthia would lean into her shoulder.

It felt easy.

When Lucy finally went to sleep, the house would soften.

Cynthia and Sam didn't waste time pretending distance hadn't built up between them. They closed it the only way they knew how—through touch, through closeness, through the familiar language of skin against skin. It wasn't frantic or desperate. It was intentional. A way to remind each other that they still belonged to the same story.

In those quiet, dimly lit hours, Cynthia could almost believe they were back on track. That the separation was temporary. That Sam was inching closer to staying for good.

But life had a way of testing those fragile hopes.

Lucy's seizures were unpredictable. Some were mild—brief absences where her tiny body stiffened for a few seconds. Others were more frightening, her small frame trembling while Cynthia counted breaths and tried to steady her own heartbeat.

The first time it happened while Sam was home, Cynthia saw it immediately—the flicker in Sam's eyes.

Fear.

Not just concern. Not just parental alarm.

Something deeper.

Cynthia moved into action automatically, lifting Lucy carefully, speaking softly, doing everything the neurologist had instructed. She didn't look up until she realized Sam wasn't beside her.

She was standing near the doorway, rigid.

"It's okay," Cynthia had said firmly. "I've got her."

Sam nodded, but her face had gone pale.

Minutes later, after Lucy settled and the episode passed, Sam stepped outside “for air.”

She stayed out there longer than necessary.

It became a pattern.

When Lucy was happy, laughing, or peacefully asleep, Sam was fully present—attentive, affectionate, engaged. But when things shifted—when Lucy became inconsolable, when a seizure struck, when exhaustion frayed everyone’s nerves—Sam retreated.

Sometimes physically.

Sometimes emotionally.

Cynthia tried to be patient. She reminded herself of everything Sam had been working on. The therapy. The childhood triggers. The postpartum depression that had cracked her open.

But patience had edges.

One Sunday afternoon, Lucy’s mood spiraled without warning. She cried for nearly an hour, nothing soothing her. Cynthia bounced her, sang to her, paced the hallway. Sam tried at first—rocking, whispering, pressing gentle kisses to Lucy’s forehead.

Then Lucy’s crying sharpened, tipping toward overstimulation.

Cynthia saw the shift in Sam again. The way her shoulders tightened. The way her breathing changed. “I think she needs you,” Sam said quickly, handing Lucy back.

“I’ve had her,” Cynthia replied, more tired than she meant to sound.

Sam hesitated.

Lucy's cries grew louder.

"I just—" Sam started, then stopped. "I'm going to step outside for a minute."

The door closed softly behind her.

Cynthia stood in the living room, Lucy clutched against her chest, frustration rising hot and fast.

She didn't need Sam only for the golden hours. She needed her in the chaos. In the unpredictable, messy, uncomfortable parts of parenting. She needed someone who would stay when things felt overwhelming.

Not someone who thrived only in the calm.

Later that night, after Lucy finally fell asleep, Sam returned to the couch beside Cynthia like nothing had happened. She reached for her hand.

Cynthia let her.

But something inside her felt heavier.

"I'm trying," Sam said quietly, as if sensing it.

"I know," Cynthia replied.

And she did know.

She knew Sam was fighting battles most people couldn't see. She knew every retreat wasn't indifference—it was fear colliding with old wounds. She knew growth wasn't linear.

But knowing didn't erase the loneliness.

Cynthia had accepted this as the new norm: weekends, when possible, phone calls in between, promises of "soon." She had accepted that Sam wasn't fully ready to step into the motherly role Lucy deserved. She was waiting.

Waiting for the version of Sam who could hold steady when the ground shook. Waiting for the woman who would choose to stay when discomfort pressed in from all sides.

Waiting for the strong Sam who didn't just love fiercely during the good moments—but endured the hard ones too.

Some nights, after Sam drove back to the mountains and the house returned to its usual quiet, Cynthia sat on the edge of her bed and wondered how long waiting could stretch before it turned into something else.

Resentment.

Or resignation.

She didn't want perfect.

She didn't want fearless.

She wanted consistent.

She wanted a partner who understood that family wasn't built only in peaceful walks through nature or soft intimacy after dark.

It was built in hospital visits. In crying spells. In seizures at two in the morning.

So far, Sam wasn't there yet.

Cynthia loved her.

But love, she was learning, needed more than beautiful weekends.

It needed someone who stayed.

Chapter 22: Should Have Been



F

inding the right school for Lucy was supposed to be something they did together. That was how Cynthia had always pictured it—sitting at the kitchen table with brochures spread out, debating programs, visiting classrooms hand in hand while Lucy clung to one of them. It was supposed to feel hopeful. Forward-moving. Like another milestone they reached as a family.

Instead, Cynthia did it alone.

Well—not completely alone.

But without Sam.

Lucy's needs weren't simple. Between the seizures, the developmental delays, and the sensory sensitivities that could turn an ordinary classroom into an overwhelming storm, a traditional school wasn't going to work. Cynthia knew that. The neurologist had gently confirmed it. Early intervention specialists had recommended structured support, smaller class sizes, teachers trained to handle medical and emotional complexities.

Cynthia became a researcher overnight.

She stayed up late reading about specialized programs, inclusion models, therapy-based classrooms. She highlighted notes. She made spreadsheets. She scheduled tours. She asked questions about staff-to-student ratios, seizure protocols, individualized education plans.

Every step of the way, she called Sam. At least she tried.

“Did you look at the link I sent?” Cynthia asked one evening, phone pressed between her ear and shoulder while Lucy stacked blocks on the living room rug.

“Yeah,” Sam said distractedly. “It looks... fine.”

“Fine?” Cynthia repeated. “They have an on-site nurse and a sensory room. That’s not just fine. That’s huge.”

There was wind on the other end of the call. Sam was probably outside the ranger station again, staring at the mountains while Cynthia stared at paperwork.

“Sorry,” Sam said. “It’s been a long day. We had a rescue up near the north ridge. I’m exhausted.”

Cynthia swallowed her frustration. “I know. I just... I need your thoughts too.”

“I trust you,” Sam replied quickly. “You’ve done all the research. You know what’s best.”

It sounded supportive.

It didn’t feel supportive.

Cynthia didn’t want to be trusted to carry it all. She wanted partnership. Opinions. Engagement. Even disagreement.

Instead, Sam’s voice felt distant—like she was commenting on a story she wasn’t part of.

The pattern continued.

When Cynthia toured schools, Sam couldn’t make it. An emergency calls. A staffing shortage. A trail closure. Once, she promised to attend a virtual meeting with a program director and canceled ten minutes before it started.

“I’m so sorry,” Sam had said. “Something came up.”

Something always came up.

So, Mark and Alexa stepped in.

Mark, steady and observant, came to two school visits with Cynthia. He asked practical questions she hadn't thought of. "What happens if Lucy has a seizure during recess?" "How do you communicate with parents during the day?" "What does inclusion actually look like here?"

Alexa noticed the emotional details. She watched how teachers knelt to Lucy's level. How they responded when Lucy flapped her hands in excitement. Whether their smiles were patient or forced.

"You can feel it," Alexa said after one visit, as they sat in Cynthia's car. "Some places tolerate kids like Lucy. Some places celebrate them."

Cynthia held onto that distinction.

Weeks passed in a blur of tours and phone calls. Sam remained on the periphery—present in name, absent in substance.

One night, after Lucy had fallen asleep, Cynthia tried again.

"I'm tired, Sam," she admitted quietly. "This is a big decision."

"I know," Sam said.

"No," Cynthia pressed. "I don't think you do."

Silence stretched between them.

"I'm doing this by myself."

"You're not by yourself," Sam replied defensively. "You have Mark and Alexa."

The words stung more than Cynthia expected.

"I shouldn't need them for this," she said. "I need you."

Sam exhaled sharply. "I'm doing the best I can."

"I need more than your best when it's convenient," Cynthia whispered.

There was no real answer to that.

Eventually, they found it. A small, specialized school tucked into a quiet part of town. Bright classrooms. Low student-to-teacher ratios. A nurse on staff. A therapy room filled with weighted blankets and soft lighting.

The director spoke about neurodiversity with warmth instead of pity.

Lucy surprised them all. During the tour, she gravitated toward another little girl lining up toy animals on the floor. They sat side by side without speaking, completely absorbed in the same quiet ritual.

Cynthia felt something loosen in her chest.

When they told Lucy she would be going to school there, she clapped her hands and repeated, "School! School!" with wide-eyed excitement.

For the first time in months, Cynthia allowed herself to feel hopeful without reservation.

Sam's response, over the phone, was muted.

"That's great," she said. "I'm glad you found something."

Cynthia waited for more.

It didn't come.

Lucy's first day arrived with nervous energy humming through the house. Cynthia dressed her carefully, smoothing down her tiny backpack straps, triple-checking the emergency medication in the nurse's kit.

Mark came over that morning for support. Alexa sent a long, encouraging text.

Sam called.

"I wish I could be there," she said.

"You could have been," Cynthia replied before she could stop herself.

Another silence.

"I know," Sam said quietly.

At the school entrance, Lucy hesitated only for a second before spotting the same little girl from the tour. Her face lit up. She ran forward, laughter spilling out of her like sunlight.

Cynthia stood in the doorway longer than she meant to, watching.

She told herself this was a new beginning.

But not everything is what it seems.

By noon, her phone rang.

It was the school nurse.

Lucy had experienced a prolonged seizure during group activity. The staff responded quickly, but the classroom hadn't been as prepared as promised. The substitute teacher panicked. The other children cried. Lucy was overwhelmed, disoriented.

Cynthia's heart pounded as she drove back.

When she arrived, Lucy was resting in the nurse's office, small and pale beneath a thin blanket.

The director apologized profusely. Policies were mentioned. Adjustments promised.

But Cynthia saw the truth in the cracks.

Preparation on paper wasn't the same as readiness in reality.

That night, she called Sam.

"They said they were equipped," Cynthia said, her voice trembling with exhaustion and anger.

"They said they knew what they were doing."

"What happened?" Sam asked.

Cynthia explained.

There was a pause.

"That's scary," Sam said finally.

Scary. That was it.

"I needed you there today," Cynthia whispered. "I needed someone beside me when I walked back into that building."

"I know," Sam said again.

But knowing wasn't the same as showing up.

After they hung up, Cynthia sat on Lucy's bedroom floor, watching her sleep.

She had fought so hard to find the right place. She had carried the weight of every decision. And when things cracked, she was still the only one standing there to hold the pieces.

Lucy had been excited.

Lucy had been brave.

Cynthia would be too.

Even if she was doing it without the partner, she once imagined would be beside her for every first.

Somewhere in the mountains, Sam was likely staring at the horizon again—steady in terrain she understood.

Cynthia was navigating different ground.

And she was starting to realize that not everything that looks supportive from a distance feels supportive up close.

Chapter 23: Everything Shifted



*T*he second school felt different from the start.

There were no rushed assurances. No polished speeches that cracked under pressure. This place was quiet, structured, intentional. The classrooms were small. The staff moved with calm confidence. There was a full-time nurse who didn't flinch when Cynthia described Lucy's seizure history. The sensory room wasn't an afterthought—it was integrated into the daily rhythm of the day.

And then there was Miss Smith.

Miss Smith knelt in front of Lucy the first morning of kindergarten and introduced herself gently, as if Lucy were the most important person in the room. She didn't rush her. She didn't overcompensate. She simply met her where she was.

Lucy took to her immediately.

Within weeks, Cynthia began to see something she hadn't allowed herself to fully imagine before: promise.

Lucy was doing well in class. Not perfect. Not without struggle. She still had delays in speech processing and sometimes needed extra time to transition between activities. But in other areas, she excelled in ways that surprised even the specialists. Her pattern recognition was advanced. Her memory for details—especially anything related to nature or animals—was remarkable. She gravitated toward structured tasks and completed them with quiet determination.

Most importantly, she was happy.

Every afternoon she came home with stories—about circle time, about the classroom guinea pig, about the little boy who liked to line up crayons the same way she did. She talked about Miss Smith constantly.

“Miss Smith, say I did good job!” Lucy beamed one day, waving a worksheet covered in careful, uneven letters.

Cynthia felt something expand in her chest that she hadn’t felt in a long time.

Hope. She couldn’t wait to tell Sam.

That night, she called her, barely containing the excitement in her voice.

“She’s thriving,” Cynthia said. “Sam, she’s really thriving. Miss Smith says she participates, she’s making friends. The seizures are managed. They actually know what they’re doing.”

“That’s great,” Sam replied.

Cynthia waited.

“She sounds happy,” Sam added.

“She is,” Cynthia said softly. “You should see her face when she talks about school.”

“Yeah,” Sam murmured.

There it was again—the distance. Not unkind. Not angry. Just detached. Like someone listening to a story that didn’t fully belong to them.

Over the next few months, the stretches between Sam's visits grew longer.

At first, it was three weeks. Then five. Then nearly two months before she showed up at the house again, ranger uniform folded neatly in her backseat, offering apologies about wildfire season and staffing shortages and trail emergencies.

Cynthia nodded. She always nodded.

But something inside her had started to cool.

When Sam did come over, the pattern remained the same. The good hours were good. Walks in nature. Laughter over dinner. Intimacy after Lucy fell asleep. But the sense of building toward something permanent had faded.

It felt temporary.

Like borrowed time.

One Friday night, Alexa showed up at Cynthia's house with determination written all over her face.

"You're going out," Alexa announced. "No excuses. Mark already said he'll stay with Lucy."

"I don't know..." Cynthia hesitated.

"You need one night where you're not researching schools or worrying about seizures or waiting for someone to show up," Alexa insisted. "Just one night."

Cynthia almost declined.

But she was tired of sitting at home. Tired of staring at her phone. Tired of feeling suspended in a relationship that no longer felt like it was moving forward.

So, she went.

The club was louder than anything she'd experienced in years. Music pulsed through the floor. Lights flickered across crowded bodies moving in rhythm. It felt foreign and strangely liberating all at once.

Alexa ordered drinks. They found a corner table partially shielded by shadows.

Cynthia laughed more than she expected to. For a little while, she felt untethered from responsibility. Just a woman in a room full of strangers.

And then Alexa went still.

"Cynthia," she said quietly.

There was something in her tone that made Cynthia's stomach drop.

"What?"

Alexa's eyes shifted toward the entrance.

Cynthia followed her gaze.

Sam stood just inside the club doors.

But she wasn't alone.

Her arm was wrapped around another woman's waist—close, familiar, effortless. The woman leaned into her, smiling up at her as if they had done this a hundred times before.

The music dulled in Cynthia's ears.

"No," she whispered.

They watched from the shadows.

At first, Cynthia tried to convince herself it was a misunderstanding. A colleague. A friend.

Someone who needed support.

But then the woman reached up and brushed her fingers along Sam's jaw. Sam smiled—soft, intimate, unguarded.

Not distant. Not detached. Present.

The kind of present Cynthia had been begging for.

They moved through the crowd together like a couple. Hands intertwined. Bodies angled toward each other in quiet conversation.

There was no ambiguity.

It was obvious.

Cynthia's chest felt like it had been cracked open.

She didn't wait.

She didn't confront. She didn't scream. She didn't walk over and demand an explanation.

She bolted.

Out the side exit. Into the cool night air. Away from the music and the lights and the version of Sam, she didn't recognize.

Alexa called after her, but Cynthia was already halfway down the sidewalk, heart pounding, vision blurred with tears she refused to let fall in public.

She wouldn't give Sam the satisfaction of a dramatic scene.

Not here. Not like that.

If there was going to be an ending, it would happen on her terms.

She sat in her car for several minutes before starting the engine, hands trembling on the steering Wheel. It wasn't just the betrayal. It was the clarity. All the long stretches of absence. The distracted phone calls. The emotional distance. The slow fading of effort. It all rearranged itself into a truth she could no longer ignore. Sam hadn't just been overwhelmed. She had been leaving.

Cynthia's drive home was a silent one.

When she walked through the front door, Mark looked up from the couch where Lucy was asleep against his chest.

"Everything okay?" he asked gently.

Cynthia nodded once.

"Yeah," she said, her voice steady in a way that surprised her. "Everything's clear now."

Later that night, after Lucy was tucked into bed, Cynthia sat alone in the living room.

She didn't call Sam.

She wouldn't confront her in anger.

The next time Sam called—as she inevitably would—Cynthia would answer. Calmly. Directly.

And she would tell her that it was over.

Not because of one night in a club.

But because she needed someone who showed up in the daylight as boldly as they did in the dark.

Lucy had a future filled with promise.

Cynthia could see it clearly now.

And she refused to build that future on someone who had already chosen to walk away.

Chapter 24: The Call



C

ynthia had been waiting for the call. Not anxiously. Not desperately.

Prepared.

Ever since that night at the club, she had known it was coming. Sam would call eventually—

casual at first, maybe even warm. She would ask about Lucy. About school. About the week.

And then Cynthia would speak the words she had rehearsed over and over in her mind.

She had practiced them in the shower. In the car. Lying awake at night.

I saw you.

You've been gone for a long time.

I deserve more than half of someone.

She wasn't planning to scream. She wasn't planning to cry. She just wanted clarity. Closure.

Dignity.

When her phone lit up with Sam's name, Cynthia felt her body go still.

This is it. She let it ring once before answering. "Hi," she said evenly.

There was a pause on the other end—longer than usual.

"Hey," Sam replied. Her voice sounded different. Tight. Controlled.

Cynthia straightened in her chair. Her rehearsed words lined up in her mind like soldiers ready to

march. But Sam spoke first. "I need to tell you something."

Cynthia's grip tightened around the phone.

"I'm sorry," Sam said, and her voice cracked slightly. "I found someone else to be with. I wasn't

sure, about it at first... not until recently." The words landed softly. Too softly.

“I know I should have told you long before now,” Sam continued. “I’ve been confused. About you. About my promises. About Lucy. About everything.”

Cynthia opened her mouth to speak—to release all the lines she had carefully prepared.

Nothing came.

“I kept thinking maybe I could still fix things,” Sam went on. “Maybe I could become what you needed. What Lucy needed. But the more I thought about it... the more I realized I’m never going to be good enough for the both of you.”

The rehearsed speech dissolved completely.

Cynthia didn’t feel the eruption of anger she had expected. No fire. No sharp edge.

Just a slow, spreading stillness. It was something she had already known.

Somewhere deep beneath the denial, beneath the waiting, beneath the hope she kept clinging to it like a life raft—she had known. Sam had been leaving for a long time. Cynthia had just refused to accept it. And somehow, that realization hurt more than the confession itself.

She had been holding onto a dream that wasn’t coming back. Holding onto a version of Sam who existed only in memory. Waiting for a return that had already passed its expiration date.

“You found someone,” Cynthia repeated quietly. “Yes.” “Is that who you were with the other night?” Silence. “You saw me,” Sam said. “Yes.”

Another pause, heavy but no longer explosive.

“I’m sorry,” Sam whispered again.

Cynthia inhaled slowly. This was the moment. The one she had practiced for.

But instead of fury, what rose in her was clarity. “It’s for the best,” Cynthia said calmly.

Sam seemed startled. “What?”

“You weren’t really present for a very long time,” Cynthia continued, her voice steady. “I should have seen this coming.”

She let out a small breath.

“In some way, I did. I just refused to believe it.”

On the other end, Sam said nothing.

“I hope you find happiness,” Cynthia said softly. “And the love you deserve, Sam.”

The words surprised even her. But they were true.

There was no begging left in her. No bargaining. No collapsing into grief.

Just acceptance.

“You’ll always be Lucy’s mom,” Cynthia added. “Please don’t think I would ever keep you from your daughter.” The silence that followed felt different. Not reflective. Hesitant.

“Cynthia...” Sam began carefully.

Something in her tone made Cynthia’s stomach tighten.

“I think it would be better if I didn’t stay involved.”

The air left Cynthia’s lungs. “What do you mean?” she asked, though she already understood.

“I don’t think I’m cut out for this,” Sam said. “For being a mother. For being what Lucy needs. I’ve tried to convince myself I could grow into it. But I can’t.”

The room seemed to tilt slightly.

“I don’t want to keep going back and forth,” Sam continued. “It’s not fair to her. It’s not fair to you. It’s better if I step away completely.”

Step away. As if she were excusing herself from a room.

Cynthia's mind struggled to catch up with the words.

"You're saying," she said slowly, "that you don't want to be part of Lucy's life."

A long exhale on the other end.

"Yes."

Just like that.

Years of love. Of longing. Of therapy and promises and slow returns. Cut clean.

Cynthia stared at the wall in front of her, barely seeing it.

"She's your daughter," she said, her voice barely above a whisper.

"I know," Sam replied. "And that's why this is so hard."

Cynthia almost laughed at that.

Hard. Hard was staying through seizures. Hard was researching schools alone. Hard was holding a child through confusion and fear. This was escape.

But even then, the anger still didn't rise. Only disbelief.

"I can't be what she needs," Sam said again, as if repetition would make it kinder.

Cynthia's heart pounded now—not from rage, but from something deeper.

Grief. Not for the relationship. For Lucy.

For the inevitable questions. The empty space where a mother should have been.

"Okay," Cynthia said finally. The word surprised them both.

"Okay?" Sam echoed.

"If that's your decision," Cynthia replied. "Then I won't force you to stay."

There was nothing left to negotiate.

Sam murmured something about hoping Cynthia would understand someday.

About wanting the best for them. About being sorry.

Cynthia heard the words but they floated past her.

They ended the call quietly.

No screaming.

No slammed phones.

Just a soft click as the line went dead.

Cynthia sat there for a long time.

The reality settled in slowly, like snow covering everything at once.

Sam wasn't just leaving her.

She was leaving Lucy.

And that was something Cynthia had never truly prepared for.

Her hands began to shake.

Not from shock anymore—but from the weight of what this meant. The future she would now build alone. The conversations she would someday have with Lucy. The strength she would have to find inside herself. She reached for her phone again and called Alexa.

Alexa answered on the first ring.

“What happened?”

Cynthia's voice wavered for the first time.

“It's over,” she said. “She's... she's gone. For good. And she doesn't want to be part of Lucy's life.”

There was no hesitation.

“We're coming over,” Alexa said firmly. “Right now.”

Within minutes, headlights swept across Cynthia's living room walls. Mark and Alexa were at her door, wrapping her in steady, grounding arms before she could even speak again.

They didn't offer platitudes. They didn't criticize Sam.

They just stayed.

And as Cynthia sat between them on the couch, the full reality finally washed over her—not with chaos, but with aching clarity.

The dream she had been holding onto was gone. But she was still here. Lucy was still here.

And somehow, in the quiet aftermath of that call, Cynthia understood something deeply and unshakably: She would not abandon her child. No matter how much it hurt. No matter who else did.

Chapter 25: The Summer They Built



*W*hen school ended, Lucy didn't understand why.

The last day of kindergarten arrived with hugs from classmates, a handmade card from Miss Smith, and a paper crown Lucy insisted on wearing all the way home. She smiled and waved like it was any other Friday.

The confusion started Monday morning.

"School?" Lucy asked, already standing by the door with her backpack on.

Cynthia knelt in front of her. "It's summer vacation, sweetheart. School starts again after summer."

Lucy's brow tightened. "Miss Smith?"

"She'll still be at the school," Cynthia reassured her. "Just not every day for a little while."

Lucy didn't cry, but she wandered the house restlessly, unsettled by the break in routine. School had become her anchor—structure, familiarity, faces she trusted.

Cynthia felt the shift too.

But she had already accepted something bigger over the past few months.

It was just Lucy and her now.

Not in a lonely way. Not completely. But in the clearest sense of responsibility.

Mark and Alexa had quietly stepped in as constants. They didn't try to replace anyone. They simply showed up.

“We’re not letting summer undo everything she built this year,” Mark said one evening at the kitchen table, sketching out ideas. “Consistency. We keep her brain moving.”

Alexa smiled. “Learning disguised as fun.”

They created a rhythm. Mornings had gentle structure—reading practice, counting games, nature walks where Lucy identified birds and leaves the way Sam once had. Afternoons were creative: painting sessions, puzzles, storytelling games. Evenings stayed calm and predictable.

They rotated days.

Uncle Mark’s “science mornings” became a highlight. Lucy examined rocks through a magnifying glass, helped build a tiny herb garden, and learned how to identify constellations on clear nights. Alexa brought art to life—finger painting in the backyard, chalk murals on the driveway, homemade flashcards disguised as treasure hunts.

They took Lucy for ice cream after particularly focused days, letting her choose her own flavor like it was a major decision. They spent afternoons swimming at the lake, always with careful planning—emergency medication packed, seizure protocol reviewed, water temperature monitored.

It looked effortless from the outside. It wasn’t.

Every outing required preparation. Every activity had layers of awareness behind it. But Lucy didn’t see the vigilance. She saw joy. She saw safety. She saw love.

At her mid-summer checkup, her neurologist reviewed her progress and smiled.

“You’ve built an impressive support system,” he said. “Consistency like this makes a difference. You’re not letting CDKL5 dictate her quality of life.”

Cynthia felt pride settle into her bones.

Lucy still had delays. She needed extra processing time. Some days were harder than others. But she was learning. Growing. Thriving in her own way.

By late August, Lucy began asking about school again.

“Back to school?” she asked, hopeful.

“Soon,” Cynthia smiled.

They turned school shopping into an event. Lucy picked out a backpack covered in bright blue stars. Mark let her test lunchboxes for “snack storage efficiency.” Alexa helped her choose new crayons and a first-grade notebook.

The night before school started, Lucy laid her clothes out carefully on her bed.

“Big girl,” she whispered to herself.

“You are,” Cynthia said softly.

The next morning, Lucy walked into the school building holding Cynthia’s hand tightly. The hallways buzzed with new energy—older students, new teachers, a slightly different atmosphere than kindergarten.

At the end of the hallway stood Miss Smith.

Lucy’s face lit up immediately.

“Miss Smith!” she shouted, breaking into a small run.

Miss Smith knelt down and opened her arms. “Lucy! Look at you! You grew over the summer!”

Lucy wrapped her arms around her teacher’s neck like she had been holding onto that hug all season. Cynthia felt relief wash over her.

Miss Smith stood and smiled warmly. “I’m so happy to see you,” she said. “But guess what?

You’re a first grader now. That means you have a new classroom.”

Lucy froze.

“New?” she asked, her voice small.

“Yes,” Miss Smith said gently. “Your new teacher is wonderful. Her name is Miss Stacy. And she’s been very excited to meet you.”

Lucy’s grip on Cynthia’s hand tightened instantly.

Change.

Cynthia felt Lucy’s body stiffen beside her.

Miss Smith noticed it too. “How about I walk you there?” she offered softly.

Lucy hesitated but nodded.

They moved down the hallway together. Each step felt heavier than the last for Lucy. Her breathing quickened. Her eyes darted around the unfamiliar classroom doors.

When they reached Miss Stacy’s room, the door was open. Bright decorations lined the walls.

Small desks arranged neatly. A soft rug in the reading corner.

Miss Stacy stepped forward with a warm smile. “You must be Lucy.”

Lucy didn’t respond.

She half-hid behind Cynthia’s leg, eyes wide, overwhelmed by the newness.

“It’s okay,” Cynthia whispered, kneeling down. “It’s just another classroom.”

Lucy’s lower lip trembled.

And then—

From across the room, a familiar voice.

“Lucy!” It was the little girl who had lined up toy animals with her the year before. Two other children from kindergarten waved excitedly from their desks.

Recognition flickered across Lucy’s face. “Friends,” she whispered.

“Yes,” Miss Smith encouraged. “Your friends are here too.”

Slowly, Lucy stepped away from Cynthia.

Miss Stacy knelt to her level. “We’re going to have so much fun in first grade.”

Lucy glanced back once more at Cynthia.

Cynthia smiled steadily, even though her own heart was racing. “You’ve got this.”

Lucy walked toward her friends.

By the time Cynthia reached the doorway, Lucy was sitting at her desk, listening. Not fully relaxed—but not panicking either.

She was adjusting. Just like she had all summer. Outside, Cynthia paused in the hallway, letting the moment settle.

There would always be transitions. Always be moments of uncertainty. But Lucy was learning how to move through them—with support, with preparation, with love surrounding her.

Summer had strengthened her.

First grade had begun with a wobble.

But Lucy was okay.

And that was more than enough.

Chapter 26: Fighting for Her Light



F

irst grade did not unfold the way Cynthia had hoped. The excitement of that first morning.

The reunion with friends, the careful walk into Miss Stacy's classroom—the excitement faded faster than anyone could have imagined.

At first, it was subtle.

Lucy came home quieter than usual. She didn't talk about her day with the same spark she'd had in kindergarten. When Cynthia asked what she'd learned, Lucy shrugged more often than she answered. "Good," she would say vaguely.

Then the notes started. Small comments in Lucy's folder about incomplete assignments.

Difficulty transitioning. Struggles during group activities. Increased distraction.

Cynthia felt the familiar tightening in her chest.

This wasn't the Lucy she had seen bloom under Miss Smith's steady guidance. This wasn't the girl who had proudly read simple books over the summer or counted confidently at the kitchen table.

Within a month, Cynthia requested a meeting.

She sat at a long table in the school conference room across from Miss Stacy, the principal, and eventually Miss Smith, who had asked to be included after hearing Lucy was having a hard time.

Miss Stacy spoke gently but defensively. "First grade is more demanding," she explained.

"There's less room for individualized pacing. Lucy may just be feeling the pressure."

Cynthia kept her voice measured. “Lucy handled structured expectations last year. She thrives with clarity and support.”

Miss Stacy nodded but followed with caveats. “She struggles to stay on task. She seems overwhelmed by independent work. She’s not retaining material the way she should.”

Each sentence felt like a small crack forming in something Cynthia had worked so hard to build.

At home, Lucy’s frustration grew. Homework that once took ten minutes now stretched into tears. She forgot sight words she had mastered the year before. Her confidence slipped quietly, like sand through fingers.

Uncle Mark noticed it first during their reading sessions.

“She’s second-guessing herself,” he said one evening. “She knows this. She just doesn’t believe she does.”

Alexa saw it too during art time. Lucy hesitated before starting projects she once dove into without fear.

The meetings multiplied. IEP reviews. Strategy discussions. Accommodation adjustments.

Cynthia left each one feeling like she had been banging her head against a wall.

“We’re doing everything we can,” the principal assured her.

“We’re following protocol,” Miss Stacy added. But protocol wasn’t enough.

Lucy was slipping. The worst part wasn’t the academic decline. It was watching the light dim in her eyes. The eager little girl who once ran toward the classroom now dragged her feet in the mornings. Cynthia lay awake at night replaying every decision.

Had she missed something? Had she pushed too hard? Was this the natural progression of CDKL5? Or was it the environment?

Miss Stacy maintained that Lucy simply wasn't ready for the expectations of first grade.

Cynthia knew better. Lucy had been ready. She had proof.

Miss Smith remained quiet during many of the meetings, but her eyes said everything. She knew Lucy's capabilities. She had seen them firsthand.

After one particularly tense conference, Miss Smith caught Cynthia in the hallway.

"I can't overstep," she said softly. "But Lucy hasn't lost ability. She's lost confidence."

Cynthia's throat tightened.

"I don't know what else to do," she admitted.

Miss Smith hesitated before speaking again. "If you're open to it... I could work with her over the summer. Just us. Small group. Focused support. Get her ready for second grade."

Relief flooded through Cynthia so quickly she nearly cried.

"Yes," she said without hesitation. "Absolutely yes."

The rest of the school year felt like survival mode.

They fought for Lucy in every way they could. Adjustments were made. Extra support hours were added. Mark and Alexa reinforced lessons at home. Cynthia reviewed everything nightly.

But the decline plateaued rather than reversed.

By June, everyone was exhausted.

Lucy crossed the stage at the small end-of-year ceremony, smiling faintly but without the radiant pride she'd once carried so easily.

Cynthia clapped louder than anyone. Inside, her heart ached.

When summer finally began, there was no break in effort.

Miss Smith kept her promise. Three mornings a week, Lucy met her at school for targeted sessions. They worked patiently— rebuilding reading fluency, reinforcing math concepts,

restoring the foundation that had cracked. Miss Smith approached Lucy the way she always had: steady, affirming, clear. “You remember this,” she would say gently. “Let’s show it again.”

At home, Uncle Mark resumed science explorations, weaving in math and reading without Lucy realizing she was practicing. Alexa turned vocabulary into art projects and storytelling games.

Cynthia balanced it all—coordinating schedules, tracking progress, reviewing material between Miss Smith’s clients and paperwork hours.

It was a lot.

But this time, they weren’t reacting.

They were rebuilding.

Slowly, the old Lucy began to resurface.

She read a full beginner chapter book one afternoon without stumbling. She solved math problems confidently. She raised her hand during a small summer group session without prompting. The hesitation in her voice softened. The spark returned.

One evening, Lucy looked up from her workbook and grinned. “I’m smart,” she declared.

Cynthia blinked back tears. “Yes, you are.”

By late summer, the difference was undeniable.

Miss Smith reviewed Lucy’s progress reports with quiet satisfaction. “She’s ready for second grade,” she said firmly.

Cynthia allowed herself cautious hope.

Second grade would bring a new teacher. A new chance. A fresh start without the shadow of first grade’s missteps. There were no guarantees. But Lucy had bounced back. And that mattered.

As Cynthia watched Lucy run through the backyard with Mark and Alexa one evening, laughter echoing across the grass, she realized something else too.

They were not broken.

They were resilient.

They had survived abandonment. They had survived regression. They had survived a year that threatened to unravel everything they had built.

And they were still standing.

Stronger, perhaps, because of it.

Sam's absence no longer felt like a wound that defined them. It was simply part of the past—a chapter that had closed. Lucy was thriving again.

They were surviving and thriving without Sam.

And this time, the foundation felt unshakable.

Chapter 27: Who Saw Her Light



The first day of second grade arrived with an energy that was different from Lucy's first-grade year. There were no trepidations, no hesitant steps through unfamiliar hallways. Lucy ran to the school with a confidence that Cynthia hadn't seen in months. The summer, spent with Miss Smith, Mark, Alexa, and Cynthia herself, had rebuilt her foundation. She was ready.

Standing at the classroom door was Miss Sarah. She had a warm smile, the kind that reached her eyes and made you feel immediately seen. When Lucy spotted her, she froze for just a second—then burst forward with a smile and an almost shy “Hi!”

“Lucy!” Miss Sarah crouched to meet her at eye level. “I’m so happy to see you. I’ve heard wonderful things about you over the summer.”

Lucy's chest puffed out. She felt important. Seen. Validated. Miss Sarah radiated a quiet confidence that made Lucy feel capable of anything. Cynthia, standing behind her daughter, watched the moment unfold with a mixture of relief and awe.

As the day progressed, it became immediately apparent that Miss Sarah was different from Miss Stacy. She noticed what Lucy could do, rather than what she struggled with. She pushed her gently—but firmly—past expectations.

“Lucy,” she said during math class, “I know you can do this. Remember how we practiced last week? You’re ready.” Lucy hesitated for a split second—then tried. And she succeeded. The pride in her eyes was dazzling. Cynthia could see it from the observation window. This wasn't just progress. It was transformation.

Miss Sarah had a way of bringing out potential that no one had dared to expect. Reading aloud, problem-solving, classroom discussions—Lucy was excelling. She raised her hand without hesitation. She volunteered answers confidently. She even helped other students. The quiet girl from first grade, hesitant and insecure, had become a leader in the classroom.

Cynthia watched her daughter bloom and felt a profound gratitude toward Miss Sarah. But she also noticed something she couldn't quite define. Miss Sarah's attention to Lucy was professional, yes—but it carried warmth, an enthusiasm that went beyond typical teacherly encouragement.

The first parent-teacher conference revealed the depth of Miss Sarah's impact. Sitting across from Cynthia, Miss Sarah's eyes sparkled with sincerity.

"Lucy is extraordinary," she said. "Not because of her academics alone, but because of her curiosity, her resilience, her kindness. I can see her potential. Honestly, I'm thrilled to have the chance to guide her this year."

Cynthia nodded, feeling a mix of relief and awe. "She's thrived so much over the summer. Miss Smith helped her catch up, and Mark and Alexa have been incredible. Lucy's doing well because she's been supported in so many ways."

Miss Sarah smiled, her gaze softening. "I can see all of that. And I want to help her reach even further this year. I know she can do more than anyone has imagined—including herself."

Cynthia left that meeting feeling a new kind of hope. But she also sensed a subtle undercurrent in Miss Sarah's demeanor—a gentle care that didn't entirely fit in a typical teacher-parent dynamic. She shook it off, reminding herself that professionalism was a line teachers respected.

Over the weeks, Lucy's growth continued. Miss Sarah set challenges that stretched her mind.

Math problems were more complex, reading passages longer and richer. Lucy approached them with enthusiasm, confident in the support she had at home and the encouragement she received in class.

"Miss Sarah says I'm smart!" Lucy exclaimed one afternoon, holding up a completed worksheet with pride.

"You are, baby," Cynthia replied, hugging her. "You've worked so hard."

Outside of the classroom, a quiet bond began to form between Cynthia and Miss Sarah. There were parent meetings, phone updates, emails about Lucy's progress. Each interaction revealed a person who not only understood Lucy's unique needs but genuinely cared for her happiness and growth.

Cynthia noticed the small gestures—Miss Sarah remembering a story Lucy had told in class, checking in about a weekend trip, offering advice about learning strategies. There was a warmth in her tone, a spark of friendship that Cynthia felt deeply but respected boundaries around.

As the year progressed, their relationship blossomed naturally. Miss Sarah was professional in her dedication to Lucy, but she also began sharing pieces of herself—light anecdotes about her own childhood, stories about teaching other children, her laughter when Lucy performed a clever observation in class.

Cynthia reciprocated cautiously, sharing small victories, Lucy's quirks, her own fears and triumphs. Conversations that began about homework and learning strategies slowly included mutual understanding, support, and quiet camaraderie.

One day, after a particularly successful reading session, Miss Sarah lingered at the door of the classroom.

"She's doing so well," Miss Sarah said, watching Lucy run to her backpack with excitement.

"You've built such an incredible team around her."

Cynthia smiled. "It hasn't been easy, but she's lucky to have you."

Miss Sarah's eyes held a softness Cynthia hadn't noticed before. "I think she's lucky to have all of you. And I'm lucky too... to work with her."

Cynthia felt a flutter in her chest—a subtle recognition that the care Miss Sarah showed Lucy might extend beyond the classroom. She glanced at Miss Sarah's face, studying the quiet intensity in her gaze. There was admiration there. There was affection. And yes—something else.

Something unspoken but undeniable.

Yet, Miss Sarah remained composed, professional, careful not to overstep boundaries. Cynthia respected that, even as she felt a quiet pull—a curiosity about what might exist beyond their shared concern for Lucy.

By the end of the school year, the results were clear. Lucy had grown academically, socially, and emotionally. She had regained her confidence and even surpassed expectations in reading, math, and classroom participation.

Cynthia watched her daughter celebrate small victories, glowing with pride. She reflected on the people who had carried them this far—Mark, Alexa, Miss Smith, and now Miss Sarah. They were a village built not by choice but by love, commitment, and perseverance.

And Cynthia herself felt something new—an awareness that Miss Sarah’s presence wasn’t just professional, wasn’t just about Lucy’s education. There was a subtle tension, a quiet depth, a sense of mutual understanding and admiration. Cynthia felt it, and she sensed it too: Miss Sarah’s affection was layered, unspoken, hovering just beneath the surface of professionalism.

It was a dangerous awareness, yet also thrilling. Cynthia allowed herself a small, private acknowledgment of it, but she kept it quiet. Nothing would disrupt Lucy’s progress. Nothing would jeopardize what they had worked so hard to rebuild.

Yet, even in the restraint, a possibility lingered—a sense that, by the end of this year, a friendship had blossomed, one that might someday grow into something more. It wasn’t immediate, it wasn’t reckless. It was slow, careful, and born of shared care for someone Cynthia loved more than anything in the world.

And for the first time in a long time, Cynthia felt a spark—not just for Lucy’s future, but for her own.

A teacher who had seen potential, nurtured it, and perhaps, in her quiet, careful way, had seen Cynthia too.

Second grade had begun as a challenge for Lucy—and it ended with a promise.

Lucy had flourished. Cynthia had hope.

And Miss Sarah’s presence, unspoken but undeniably there, hinted that life could still hold surprises, even after heartbreak.

They were surviving. They were thriving. And perhaps, in time, they would find more peace than they had ever imagined.

Chapter 28: Preparing the Path



L

Lucy had grown so much over the past two years, but the challenges of second grade had been transformative in ways Cynthia couldn't have predicted. After the setbacks with Miss Stacy in first grade and the summer recovery with Miss Smith, Lucy had entered second grade under Miss Sarah's guidance, and the difference had been remarkable.

Miss Sarah had recognized Lucy's potential immediately. She saw not only what Lucy could do academically, but also the resilience, curiosity, and determination that shone quietly beneath her surface. With patience, encouragement, and carefully structured challenges, Miss Sarah pushed Lucy past boundaries no one thought she could reach. By the end of the year, Lucy had not only regained the confidence she lost in first grade but had surpassed expectations in reading, math, and social participation.

"She's remarkable," Cynthia said one evening to Alexa, watching Lucy read aloud with pride at the kitchen table. "Miss Sarah believed in her... she believed she could do more than we even realized."

Alexa smiled, gently ruffling Lucy's hair. "It makes a difference when someone truly sees her, doesn't it?" Cynthia nodded, but there was more to it than that. She had begun to notice the subtle ways Miss Sarah's care extended beyond just teaching. Her messages to Cynthia weren't simply updates on homework or behavior; they carried thoughtfulness, insight, and a quiet warmth that went beyond professional obligation. Cynthia had felt it from the first parent-teacher conference—a kind of shared understanding, a bond that had begun to blossom between them.

Now, with third grade approaching, Miss Sarah wanted to ensure Lucy's continued growth. She requested a meeting with Cynthia, the principal, and the school's guidance coordinator.

"I've been reviewing next year's grade placements," Miss Sarah explained with her characteristic calm determination. "And I want to be involved in selecting Lucy's teachers."

Cynthia blinked. "Select her teachers?"

"Yes," Miss Sarah said. "I've watched Lucy thrive this year. I know what she needs to continue growing. Her environment is just as important as the lessons. She needs teachers who challenge her, who encourage her curiosity, and who understand her rhythm. I don't want her progress to stall because she's with someone unprepared to nurture her potential."

Cynthia felt a surge of gratitude. After all the struggles of first grade, it was a relief to have an advocate who truly understood Lucy. "I... I can't believe you're doing this. Thank you."

"It's not about me," Miss Sarah replied. "It's about Lucy. And I've seen what she can do. I want her to have every opportunity to succeed, to grow, to feel confident. Selecting the right teachers is part of that."

Over the next week, Miss Sarah meticulously reviewed potential teachers for third grade, meeting with the principal, checking teaching styles, and evaluating classroom dynamics. She considered not only academics, but the teacher's ability to support Lucy's confidence, patience with her needs, and ability to create a safe, encouraging environment.

"These teachers," Miss Sarah explained during a parent-teacher conference, "have the skills to push her past limits gently, to challenge her without overwhelming her. They will see her abilities and help her expand them. Lucy deserves that."

Cynthia listened in awe as Miss Sarah outlined each choice. She could see the thought behind every decision: not a single teacher had been chosen randomly. Each one had demonstrated patience, encouragement, and the capacity to understand Lucy's unique needs. Miss Sarah even anticipated potential challenges and prepared strategies for them.

"You're incredible," Cynthia said quietly. "I can't thank you enough. This—what you're doing—it's going to change her life."

Miss Sarah's gaze softened. "Lucy already has so much potential. She just needs the right guides. That's all I want to provide."

Cynthia felt a quiet flutter, a subtle awareness that Miss Sarah's investment wasn't only in Lucy's success. There was care, warmth, and perhaps even a personal connection that extended beyond professionalism. Cynthia kept the thought to herself, savoring it quietly, aware that their focus had to remain Lucy.

The impact of Miss Sarah's guidance was immediate. Lucy entered third grade confident and ready, surrounded by teachers who understood her, challenged her appropriately, and nurtured her growth. The consistency from second grade carried over, reinforced by Miss Sarah's careful selections, and Lucy's abilities continued to expand. Reading aloud, problem-solving, and social interactions all became opportunities for Lucy to shine. She approached her work with curiosity and determination, trusting that her teachers would support her while gently encouraging her to push past limits she hadn't known she could cross.

At home, Lucy's excitement was contagious. She described her new teachers with enthusiasm, sharing their encouragements, their praise, and their guidance. "My math teacher says I can do hard problems," she told Cynthia one evening. "Miss Lily says I can figure it out if I try." Cynthia smiled, watching her daughter's confidence grow. "You're going to do amazing things, baby," she said. "And everyone around you believes in you too."

Meanwhile, the bond between Cynthia and Miss Sarah deepened subtly but undeniably. Their exchanges—whether emails, brief chats at school, or parent meetings—were layered with professionalism, warmth, and a shared commitment to Lucy. Cynthia began to recognize moments of genuine care, subtle understanding, and even quiet humor in Miss Sarah's tone.

One afternoon, after a parent check-in meeting, Miss Sarah lingered at the school door. "You've done an incredible job supporting Lucy," she said quietly, her eyes soft. "It's clear how much love and thought goes into everything you do for her."

Cynthia felt the familiar flutter in her chest—the awareness that Miss Sarah's care extended beyond the classroom. She smiled, letting the warmth sit quietly between them. "Thank you. You've been such an important part of her year too. I can't imagine how far she'd have come without you." Miss Sarah's lips curved into a small, private smile. "I'm just lucky to be part of her journey."

That evening, as Lucy colored at the kitchen table, Cynthia reflected on the past three years.

They had faced heartbreak, setbacks, and uncertainty. Sam was no longer part of their lives. But in their place, a team had emerged: Mark and Alexa, Miss Smith over the summer, and now Miss Sarah in the classroom.

Together, they were building a strong, confident, thriving Lucy. Cynthia allowed herself to hope quietly—not just for her daughter, but for the subtle possibilities Miss Sarah’s presence hinted at. Their connection remained unspoken, careful, and respectful.

But the shared care, respect, and understanding had laid the foundation for something more—something that could flourish if nurtured slowly, patiently.

For now, their focus remained on Lucy: her growth, her confidence, and her happiness. And with Miss Sarah’s guidance, both in the classroom and in carefully curating the teachers who would support Lucy’s journey, the path ahead looked brighter than ever.

They were surviving. They were thriving. And in the quiet spaces between laughter, learning, and shared responsibility, Cynthia sensed that life could still hold new possibilities—for Lucy, for herself, and maybe, one day, for Miss Sarah too.

Chapter 29: Thriving Together



*T*he first weeks of third grade were a revelation. Lucy walked into her new classroom with a confidence that seemed to radiate from her very core. The careful guidance of Miss Sarah in second grade had laid a strong foundation, and now the new teacher—a kind, attentive professional hand-picked by Miss Sarah—was building on it. Every assignment, every classroom discussion, every challenge was designed to nurture Lucy’s strengths while gently addressing her struggles.

Cynthia watched her daughter from the car window on that first day, seeing her skip toward the classroom with a bright smile. It was a moment of quiet triumph for both of them. After the turbulent early years—Miss Stacy’s setbacks, Sam’s absence, the painstaking recovery over summer—Lucy was flourishing. She walked with purpose, confidence, and joy. Cynthia felt a lump in her throat. She had worked so hard, fought so much, and now she could see the payoff in Lucy’s enthusiasm, her eagerness to learn, and her belief in herself.

Miss Sarah had ensured a smooth transition. She had briefed the new teacher extensively, highlighting Lucy’s strengths, her learning style, and the areas that required patient guidance. It was evident that Lucy was entering a classroom where she would be seen, understood, and encouraged—exactly what she needed to continue growing.

Within the first week, Cynthia noticed changes she hadn't expected. Lucy came home excited to share small victories: "I did a really hard math problem today, Mommy!" or "My teacher says I asked a smart question in class!" Her confidence was tangible, her laughter more frequent, her energy uncontainable. The small victories of daily life—the kinds of accomplishments often overlooked—suddenly seemed enormous in their impact.

Cynthia's gratitude toward Miss Sarah deepened with every update. She was not only Lucy's mentor but also a quiet anchor for Cynthia herself. The parent-teacher check-ins were more than routine updates; they were thoughtful conversations, filled with insights and encouragement. Miss Sarah always acknowledged Cynthia's role in Lucy's success. She had a way of highlighting what Cynthia had done right—how her patience, consistency, and love had shaped Lucy's growth—without making Cynthia feel like she wasn't already doing enough.

One afternoon, after a long week of school, Cynthia met Miss Sarah at a local café for their monthly check-in. Lucy had stayed after school for a short enrichment activity, giving them a rare, quiet hour to talk.

"Lucy is thriving," Miss Sarah began, her voice calm and steady. "She's engaged, confident, and curious. She's asking questions, solving problems, and connecting with her classmates in ways that show real social growth."

Cynthia nodded, feeling pride swell in her chest. "I can see it too. She's so happy and excited about school. I feel like we finally got her back after first grade."

Miss Sarah's eyes softened. "You did that. You built a safe, consistent, and loving environment for her. I merely guided her academically and helped her see what she was capable of."

Cynthia allowed herself a small smile. “Guided her academically, inspired me... you’ve done so much more than that. I appreciate it. All of it.”

There was a subtle pause, a quiet moment between them where the professional boundaries lingered, but so did something unspoken. A recognition, a mutual respect, and a faint warmth that neither tried to define aloud. Cynthia felt it in the gentle tilt of Miss Sarah’s head, in the careful attentiveness in her gaze. It was not intrusive or inappropriate—it was quiet, respectful, and slow, like a seed planted carefully in fertile ground.

Meanwhile, Lucy’s schoolwork continued to flourish. Each day she returned home with small triumphs to share, stories of her teacher’s encouragement, and pride in what she had accomplished. She spoke about her teacher in glowing terms, describing lessons, classroom challenges, and moments where she felt her abilities stretch just beyond what she thought possible. The meticulous care Miss Sarah had taken in selecting this teacher showed in Lucy’s excitement and confidence.

“Mommy, I read three chapters today!” Lucy said one afternoon, waving her book. “And Mrs. Lane told me I explained the story so well!”

“That’s amazing, baby,” Cynthia said, brushing Lucy’s hair back and holding her close. “You’re really shining this year.”

The afternoons that followed became a rhythm of growth. Lucy tackled challenging problems, participated in group activities, and began taking initiative in ways she hadn’t in years. Cynthia marveled at the balance between her daughter’s independence and the continued support from school. It was a combination of home consistency and the careful guidance Miss Sarah had

provided—an unbroken chain of encouragement and belief in Lucy’s potential.

And in those quiet moments with Miss Sarah—after check-ins, brief meetings, and emails—Cynthia felt a deeper bond forming. There was mutual admiration, understanding, and a subtle emotional intimacy. Their conversations often lingered past the practical, touching on moments of shared experience, parenting challenges, and even small personal anecdotes. It was always respectful, always thoughtful, but it carried an unmistakable warmth that Cynthia had learned to appreciate.

One Friday afternoon, after Lucy’s final class of the week, Miss Sarah stayed a moment longer at the school door. “She’s doing beautifully,” she said softly, watching Lucy laugh with a friend.

“It’s incredible to see what you’ve built at home, and how much she trusts you. You’ve made a real difference.”

Cynthia smiled, feeling that quiet flutter in her chest again. “We couldn’t have done it without you. You’ve guided her so carefully... and you’ve guided me too, in a way.”

Miss Sarah’s lips curved into a gentle smile, acknowledging the unspoken truth between them.

“I’m just grateful to be part of her life. And yours, too, in a way. It’s a privilege to watch someone as remarkable as Lucy grow under such dedicated care.”

The sun dipped low in the sky, casting a golden light across the schoolyard. Lucy’s laughter echoed, carrying the promise of continued growth, joy, and confidence. Cynthia watched her, feeling a profound sense of gratitude and hope.

They were surviving without Sam. They were thriving without Sam. And in the quiet bond forming with Miss Sarah, Cynthia realized life could still hold connection, support, and perhaps, in time, something deeper. Something patient, steady, and true.

Lucy ran to Cynthia's side, holding her hand tightly. "Mommy, can we do my reading practice tonight?" she asked eagerly.

"Of course, baby," Cynthia replied, smiling. "Let's do it together."

And as they walked home, laughter and sunlight mingling around them, Cynthia felt it in her chest—the calm certainty that they were not just surviving, but thriving. That with the right guidance, the right love, and the right care, they could continue to grow together, stronger and brighter than ever.

Miss Sarah had given them more than a teacher. She had given them stability, belief, and a friendship that whispered of possibilities yet to come. And Cynthia allowed herself to hope quietly, savoring the slow bloom of something she hadn't expected—but deeply cherished.

Lucy was thriving. They were thriving. And for the first time in a long time, Cynthia could see a bright horizon ahead—for her daughter, for herself, and perhaps, one day, for Miss Sarah too.

Chapter 30: New Guidance



The last days of summer slipped by faster than Cynthia realized. Lucy's excitement for the upcoming school year was palpable. She had spent the break swimming at the lake, reading, and learning in playful ways with Mark and Alexa, and she had carried every lesson forward, building confidence and curiosity like bricks in a strong foundation. But now, it was time to return to school, and with it came a new chapter—literally and figuratively.

Miss Sarah had requested a meeting with Cynthia just before the school year began. She had spent the summer carefully reviewing potential teachers for Lucy's fourth-grade year. After watching Lucy thrive in second grade under her guidance and then flourishing in third grade with the teacher she had hand-picked, Miss Sarah wanted to ensure the next teacher would continue that pattern of growth, nurturing both Lucy's abilities and confidence.

"I've gone through the list of fourth-grade teachers," Miss Sarah explained as they sat in a quiet corner of the local café, coffee steaming between them. Her tone was calm and professional, but Cynthia could sense the quiet passion beneath it. "I've selected the teacher I believe will give Lucy the right environment. Someone who will challenge her, support her strengths, and encourage her curiosity. It's critical to maintain the momentum she's built."

Cynthia nodded, impressed and grateful. "I can't believe how much effort you put into this. You're not just a teacher—you're... invested. In her future, in her growth. And honestly, in me too, it feels like sometimes."

Miss Sarah's lips curved in a small, private smile; her eyes warm but careful. "I care about her growth, yes, but I also care about the adults guiding her. You've done an incredible job this past year, Cynthia. Seeing your dedication, patience, and love... it inspires me too. It makes my role easier, and it makes me want to support you as much as her."

Cynthia felt a flutter in her chest, that subtle awareness she had been cultivating for months now. The warmth in Miss Sarah's words, the quiet intimacy of her tone, was different from any professional interaction she had experienced. It wasn't overt, it wasn't demanding, but it lingered like a soft light she couldn't ignore.

"Who is the teacher?" Cynthia asked, curious to see who would guide Lucy through the next year.

Miss Sarah reached into her folder and pulled out the carefully prepared recommendation. "Mrs. Bennett. She's patient, encouraging, and knows how to challenge students to reach beyond their comfort zones. I observed her classroom last year and watched her adapt lessons to meet the unique needs of each student. She's exactly the kind of teacher Lucy needs—someone who will continue what we've built without losing momentum."

Cynthia scanned the information, feeling a sense of relief wash over her. Lucy was in good hands. Every detail Miss Sarah had included—the teaching style, classroom management, attention to social and emotional development—was perfectly aligned with Lucy's needs. She felt the same deep gratitude she had felt when Miss Sarah had selected her third-grade teacher.

"You really think of everything," Cynthia said quietly. "I don't know how to thank you enough."

Miss Sarah shook her head softly. "You've done the hard work. I just make sure she's in an environment where that work can flourish. That's my role. And you make it possible by creating the home foundation that allows her to thrive."

The morning of the first day of fourth grade arrived, bright and clear. Lucy bounded into the classroom with excitement, her backpack snug on her shoulders, her heart ready for the new challenges ahead. Mrs. Bennett greeted her warmly, and Cynthia could see immediately that this teacher understood Lucy's needs. Her approach was firm but kind, structured but flexible, supportive but encouraging—exactly as Miss Sarah had intended.

Miss Sarah lingered briefly, observing quietly from the doorway. Cynthia caught her eye and smiled, feeling the reassurance in her presence. It was subtle, unspoken: Miss Sarah had hand-picked the right environment for Lucy, and she would continue to guide and support both Cynthia and her daughter throughout the year. That steady presence, a kind of quiet guardian, brought Cynthia an unexpected sense of calm.

During the first week, Lucy settled quickly. Mrs. Bennett's teaching style encouraged curiosity and independent thinking, while Miss Sarah checked in discreetly to ensure Lucy was adjusting well. Cynthia noticed that these check-ins weren't intrusive—they were gentle, thoughtful, and supportive. There was a warmth in Miss Sarah's voice when they spoke, a subtle understanding that went beyond school matters. It made Cynthia feel seen and valued, and the comfort of it was something she hadn't realized she needed until now.

Even at home, the influence of both teachers was evident. Lucy approached homework with enthusiasm, explained concepts clearly, and shared small victories daily. Each evening, she eagerly recounted what she had learned, showing a confidence that Cynthia recognized as a product of careful guidance, consistent support, and steady encouragement from both home and school.

Over the next few weeks, Cynthia and Miss Sarah continued to build their connection in quiet, deliberate ways. Emails about Lucy's progress included small notes of encouragement, quick conversations at school check-ins were filled with thoughtful observations, and the occasional shared laugh lingered in Cynthia's mind long after their interactions ended. It was slow, subtle, and careful—the kind of trust and understanding that grew steadily over time.

One afternoon, after Lucy had completed a particularly challenging reading assignment, Cynthia stayed behind to talk to Miss Sarah. "She's doing so well," Cynthia said softly. "Every day I see her confidence grows. I can't thank you enough."

Miss Sarah smiled, a warmth in her eyes that went beyond professional courtesy. "She's remarkable, but you've built the foundation for her success. You've made it possible for her to shine. And I'm glad to be here to continue supporting both of you. You deserve support, too, Cynthia. You've carried so much on your own."

The subtle pause that followed was comfortable, intimate in a way that neither forced nor defined it. Cynthia felt the quiet recognition of a connection forming—a friendship with depth, built on trust, care, and mutual respect. It was the kind of bond that could grow slowly, patiently, without pressure, yet still hold the potential for something more.

Lucy thrived under the new teacher, guided carefully by Miss Sarah's oversight. She excelled academically, continued to build social confidence, and approached challenges with the persistence and curiosity that had become her hallmark. And through it all, Cynthia watched, grateful and aware of the quiet presence that Miss Sarah provided—not just for Lucy, but for her as well.

As the first month of fourth grade ended, Cynthia reflected on the journey. Sam was no longer a part of their lives, yet Lucy's growth, their resilience, and the careful guidance surrounding them made Cynthia feel secure, supported, and hopeful. Miss Sarah's subtle presence offered stability, wisdom, and—perhaps quietly—the beginnings of something deeper, a connection that neither rushed nor forced, but simply allowed to grow alongside Lucy's success.

Lucy was thriving. They were thriving. And with Miss Sarah there, carefully guiding the way, Cynthia allowed herself to hope—not only for her daughter's continued growth, but for the quiet possibility of a bond that could one day grow into something more.

The new school year was only beginning, and already, Cynthia could see the promise in every step Lucy took, every question she asked, every challenge she embraced. And she knew that with the right guidance, love, and support, there were no limits to what Lucy—and perhaps even she—could achieve.

Chapter 31: Growing, But Not Ready



*T*he morning fourth grade began felt different from all the years before.

Not anxious. Not uncertain. Not heavy with the memory of past struggles. But still careful.

Lucy stood in front of the mirror that morning while Cynthia adjusted the straps of her backpack. “Big girl now,” Lucy said softly to herself.

“Yes, you are,” Cynthia replied, brushing a strand of hair away from Lucy’s forehead.

Lucy had grown. Not just physically, but in the way she carried herself. There was more confidence in her posture, more independence in the way she packed her own lunch, and more curiosity in her eyes when she spoke about school.

But CDKL5 was still part of her life.

The seizures had become less frequent, but they were not gone.

Lucy still tired faster than other children. Some mornings were harder than others. There were days when her coordination wavered slightly, when her speech slowed when she was overwhelmed, or when sensory stimulation became too much.

She was improving. But she was not “outgrown” of her condition.

And Cynthia was careful never to frame progress as cure.

Because Lucy was not broken. She was growing. That distinction mattered.

Mrs. Bennett stood waiting at the classroom door when they arrived.

She was patient in the way she smiled, warm but not overwhelming, observant but not intrusive.

“Lucy, I am very happy to see you again,” Mrs. Bennett said gently.

Lucy hesitated for a moment — the small, natural hesitation of a child facing a new academic year — then smiled.

“Hi, Mrs. Bennett.”

Mrs. Bennett crouched slightly. “You’ve grown over the summer. I heard you did a lot of swimming.”

Lucy nodded proudly. “Uncle Mark taught me how to float better.”

“That’s wonderful,” Mrs. Bennett said. “Swimming is very good for your muscles.”

Cynthia watched the interaction quietly.

Mrs. Bennett was exactly what Miss Sarah had promised.

Patient.

Encouraging.

Calm.

Structured.

The classroom was organized in a way that felt safe for Lucy. Predictable seating. Clear visual schedules. Quiet learning corners where Lucy could rest if overwhelmed. Small sensory accommodations that did not draw attention but supported her functioning.

Miss Sarah had reviewed everything before the year began. She had not intervened as Lucy’s teacher anymore. But she still watched from a professional distance.

Because Lucy was not yet ready for emotional complexity beyond her stability. And Miss Sarah understood that. Cynthia felt a quiet gratitude every time she thought about it.

After Lucy entered the classroom, Cynthia walked outside and found Miss Sarah standing near the parking area. The morning sun was soft and warm. Neither spoke immediately.

There was a comfort in the silence between them now. “How is she?” Miss Sarah asked finally.

“Stable,” Cynthia said. “Not perfect. But stable. The neurologist said her pattern is improving but we shouldn’t expect sudden changes.”

Miss Sarah nodded slowly.

“That’s good,” she said quietly.

There was something careful in her voice.

Something restrained.

Something patient.

Cynthia knew what it meant.

Lucy was not yet in a place where emotional or family structure changes should be introduced.

Not yet.

Miss Sarah had feelings.

Cynthia could feel it sometimes in the way she looked at her, in the softness that lingered just a second longer than professional interaction required. But neither of them rushed it.

Because Lucy came first. Always. “I think,” Miss Sarah said after a moment, “this year should focus on strengthening her independence and cognitive confidence. Not pushing new emotional adjustments.” Cynthia smiled faintly. “You’re still protecting her,”

“Always,” Miss Sarah replied. There was no declaration. No romantic tension forced into the moment. Just quiet alignment. Cynthia felt something warm settle inside her chest. Not love confessed. Not relationship defined. But something closer to peace.

Later that day, Lucy adjusted to her new classroom rhythm with surprising ease.

Mrs. Bennett kept expectations clear but kind.

When Lucy struggled slightly during a group math activity, the teacher did not correct her publicly.

Instead, she walked beside her desk and whispered guidance gently. “Take your time. You know this.” Lucy nodded, breathing slowly. And she solved the problem.

At home that evening, Lucy talked excitedly about school. “I like Mrs. Bennett,” she said while eating dinner. “She doesn’t rush me.”

Cynthia smiled. “She sounds like a good teacher.”

“She is,” Lucy said. Then after a small pause, she added, “I think this year will be good.”

Cynthia felt tears prick the back of her eyes but did not let them fall.

“Yes, baby,” she said softly. “I think it will be good too.”

Later that night, when Lucy was asleep, Cynthia stood outside on the porch.

The air was quiet. Mark and Alexa had gone home. The house was still.

Miss Sarah had sent a short message earlier:

“Lucy looked comfortable today. That matters more than perfection.”

Cynthia replied:

“Thank you for understanding her.”

Miss Sarah responded only with: “Always.”

Cynthia felt it again — that slow, patient emotional current between them.

But she knew Lucy was not ready.

And Miss Sarah was not willing to move faster than Lucy’s development allowed.

And Cynthia... found herself grateful for that restraint.

Because love, in their world, was not about urgency. It was about safety. Lucy was growing.

Slowly. Steadily. And when the time was right, everything else would follow.

For now, fourth grade had begun quietly. And that was enough.

Chapter 32: Steady Ground



By mid-autumn, fourth grade had settled into rhythm. Lucy no longer hesitated at the classroom door in the mornings. She walked in with quiet confidence, backpack snug against her shoulders, offering Mrs. Bennett a small but certain smile.

There were still hard days.

CDKL5 had not disappeared simply because Lucy had grown older. Some afternoons her hands trembled slightly when fatigue set in. Once, during a spelling quiz, she froze—not because she didn’t know the words, but because her brain lagged behind her thoughts. The frustration had filled her eyes before the tears did.

Mrs. Bennett handled it gently.

“Pause,” she whispered. “Take one breath. Your brain just needs a moment to catch up.”

Lucy did.

And then she continued.

The seizures remained controlled but present. Short. Manageable. Carefully monitored. They were no longer terrifying interruptions, but they were reminders.

Lucy was progressing.

Not cured.

Progressing.

Cynthia watched all of it carefully. She kept routines steady. Bedtimes predictable. Homework structured. Therapy appointments consistent. She did not introduce anything new without considering the ripple effect.

Which was why the quiet shift happening between her and Miss Sarah remained just that — quiet.

One afternoon, after a successful parent-teacher check-in, Cynthia lingered in the hallway while Lucy organized her cubby. Mrs. Bennett had been glowing with pride.

“Lucy is advocating for herself now,” she said. “If she feels overwhelmed, she asks for a minute. That’s huge growth.” Advocating for herself. Cynthia carried those words like treasure.

Outside the classroom, Miss Sarah stood reviewing something on her tablet. She looked up as Cynthia approached. “How did it go?” she asked.

“Better than I expected,” Cynthia admitted. “She’s starting to speak up when she needs help.”

Miss Sarah’s expression softened in that familiar way — not overly emotional, but deeply invested.

“That means she feels safe,” she said. “Children don’t advocate unless they trust the environment.”

There was a pause then. Not awkward. Just aware. “You helped build that,” Cynthia added quietly.

Miss Sarah shook her head gently. “You did. I just supported the structure.”

Cynthia studied her for a moment. The restraint was still there. The care was still there.

But something had shifted in the space between them — less tension, more ease.

Lucy’s stability had created room. Not for romance. But for breath.

That weekend, Lucy attended a small birthday party for a classmate.

Two years ago, that would have felt impossible.

Overstimulation. Noise. Unpredictable activity.

Now, with preparation and a planned exit strategy, she managed two full hours.

She even played a group game. When she came home tired but smiling, Cynthia felt something inside her unclench. “You did amazing today,” she said as Lucy curled on the couch. “I got tired,” Lucy admitted.

“And you told me,” Cynthia replied. “That’s the important part.” Lucy nodded sleepily.

That night, after Lucy was asleep, Cynthia found herself replaying the day — the party, the check-in at school, the steady improvement. Her phone buzzed softly. A message from Miss Sarah. *"Mrs. Bennett mentioned Lucy handled group activity beautifully this week. That's growth."* Cynthia smiled. *"She's tired tonight. But proud."* There was a longer pause before the next message came. *"You should be proud too."* Cynthia stared at the words longer than necessary. Because the tone felt slightly different. Less professional. More personal. She typed, erased, and retyped before finally sending *"It helps having someone who understands what she needs."* The reply came slower this time. *"I understand because I've been watching her grow for years."* And then, after another pause: *"And because I care."* The words were simple. But they carried weight.

Cynthia felt it — not pressure, not demand — just acknowledgment. A truth sitting quietly between them.

The following week brought a small setback. Lucy had a minor seizure during a reading period. It was brief, controlled, and handled quickly. Mrs. Bennett followed protocol flawlessly. Still, the incident shook Cynthia more than she expected. Progress always felt fragile when moments like that occurred. Miss Sarah met her in the hallway after school. "She recovered quickly," she said gently. "No regression. No cognitive loss. Just fatigue." Cynthia nodded; arms folded tightly across her chest. "I know. I just... I don't want her stability to be temporary." "It isn't," Miss Sarah said firmly. "Progress with CDKL5 is not linear. But this is not the early chaos anymore. This is management." That word settled differently. Management. Not survival. Cynthia exhaled slowly. "You really believe she's, okay?" Miss Sarah held her gaze. "I believe she's strong. And I believe she's supported." The moment lingered. Not romantic. But intimate in a deeper way. Shared responsibility. Shared vigilance. Shared hope. That night, Cynthia realized something important. Miss Sarah was already part of their foundation. Not as a partner. Not as a step-parent figure. But as someone woven into Lucy's stability story. And because that foundation had held steady even through a minor setback, Cynthia felt something new:

Less fear. Lucy was not fragile glass anymore. She was resilient clay — shaped carefully, strengthened over time. And maybe... just maybe... the space that had once felt too risky to fill was beginning to feel less dangerous. Not yet. But someday. For now, Lucy continued to grow.

She joined a small after-school science club — once a week, carefully monitored.

She laughed more easily. She recovered more quickly. She asked questions boldly. And the adults around her moved with quiet coordination. Not rushing. Not forcing. Just fitting.

.

.

Chapter 33: The Presence Not Force



T

he science fair announcement came home on a Tuesday afternoon, folded neatly inside

Lucy's backpack.

Cynthia found it while unpacking lunch containers and homework folders.

"Fourth Grade Science Showcase," she read aloud. "Voluntary participation encouraged."

Lucy hovered nearby, watching her mother's reaction carefully.

"It's not mandatory," Lucy said quickly. "Mrs. Bennett said only if we want to."

Cynthia looked at her daughter — not at the paper.

"Do you want to?"

Lucy hesitated.

Science had become her quiet favorite. Experiments made sense to her in a way social situations sometimes didn't. There were steps. Variables. Predictable outcomes. Order.

"I think so," Lucy said softly. "But I don't want everyone staring."

Cynthia knelt in front of her.

"They won't be staring. They'll be learning. And you get to choose your project."

Lucy's fingers traced the edge of the flyer.

"What if I get tired?"

"Then we plan for that," Cynthia replied calmly. "We always plan."

Lucy nodded slowly.

That was enough.

The project they chose was simple but thoughtful: how muscle fatigue works and how rest helps recovery.

It was something Lucy understood intimately — not as a concept, but as experience.

Mrs. Bennett approved the idea immediately.

“It’s perfect,” she said warmly. “It’s scientific, but it’s also personal in a powerful way.”

Preparation took weeks.

There were afternoons when Lucy’s hands trembled slightly while assembling her display board. Days when fatigue shortened their work sessions. Moments when frustration flickered across her face because her body didn’t always cooperate with her mind.

But she persisted.

Miss Sarah did not insert herself.

She did not hover.

But she asked neutral questions in passing.

“How’s the hypothesis shaping up?”

“Are you accounting for recovery time variables?”

Lucy beamed every time.

She liked that Miss Sarah treated her like a thinker.

Not fragile. Not pitied. Capable.

The night before the showcase, Lucy had a small seizure. Short. Controlled. Over quickly.

But enough to rattle Cynthia’s nerves. Lucy recovered fast, but fatigue lingered.

“We can skip it,” Cynthia said gently the next morning. “There’s no pressure.” Lucy shook her head.

“No. I want to go.” It wasn’t stubbornness. It was ownership.

Cynthia swallowed the tightness in her chest. “Okay,” she said. “Then we go. And we leave the second you say so.”

The gymnasium buzzed with energy that evening.

Poster boards lined long tables. Parents milled about. Students stood beside their projects with varying levels of confidence.

Lucy stood behind her display; hands folded neatly in front of her.

She looked small. But steady. Cynthia stayed a few steps back, allowing space but staying close enough to intervene if needed.

Mrs. Bennett approached first, offering quiet encouragement. Then other parents. Then students. Lucy spoke clearly. She explained muscle fatigue. She demonstrated how rest periods improve performance. She even referenced her swimming practice as a real-world example. Her voice wavered once. She paused. Took a breath. Continued.

Cynthia felt her heart swell in a way that almost hurt. This was not a miracle cure story. This was effort. Management. Growth. Resilience.

Across the gym, Miss Sarah stood near the entrance, observing without intruding.

She wasn't needed for supervision. She wasn't coordinating anything. She was simply there. Watching.

Proud. When Lucy finished explaining her project to a small group of visitors, applause broke out — soft but genuine. Lucy's cheeks flushed pink.

She looked around instinctively for her mother. Cynthia stepped forward. "You did it," she whispered.

Lucy smiled — tired, but radiant. And then Cynthia felt it. A second gaze. She looked up. Miss Sarah stood a few feet away. Not stepping in. Not claiming credit. Just witnessing. And in that moment, Cynthia saw her differently. Not just as Lucy's former teacher. Not just as advocate. But as someone who had stood quietly beside their journey from the beginning. Not rushing in. Not demanding space. But present. Steady. Reliable. Lucy noticed her too. "Miss Sarah!" she called softly, waving.

Miss Sarah approached slowly, careful not to overwhelm the moment. “That was exceptional,” she said to Lucy. “Clear, structured, confident.” Lucy glowed under the praise. “I didn’t get too tired,” she added proudly. “No,” Miss Sarah agreed. “You managed your energy beautifully.”

Managed. Not overcame. Not defeated. Managed. Cynthia watched the interaction — the respect, the balance, the consistency. There was no disruption in Lucy’s emotional regulation. No confusion. No insecurity. Miss Sarah fit here. Publicly. Naturally. Without strain. And something inside Cynthia shifted. Not urgency. Not sudden romance. But recognition. The missing piece wasn’t about completion. It was about alignment.

Later, as they walked to the car, Lucy slipped her hand into Cynthia’s. “That was fun,” she said sleepily. “I’m proud of you,” Cynthia replied. Lucy paused, then added quietly: “I like when Miss Sarah comes to things.” Cynthia’s breath caught slightly. “Why?” “She makes it feel... safe.” The word settled deep. Safe.

Cynthia glanced back toward the gym doors, where Miss Sarah stood speaking briefly with Mrs. Bennett before heading to her own car. Safe. Not exciting. Not dramatic. Safe.

And for the first time, Cynthia wondered if Lucy might be closer to readiness than she had assumed.

Not fully. Not yet. But growing. Just like everything else.

Lucy fell asleep in the car on the way home from the science showcase.

Her hand remained loosely curled in Cynthia’s sleeve even as her breathing deepened. Fatigue always followed adrenaline — that much hadn’t changed. CDKL5 still lingered in the background of their lives like weather: unpredictable, but better understood now.

Cynthia carried her inside carefully, settling her into bed without waking her.

The house felt unusually quiet afterward. Not empty. Just... reflective.

Cynthia stood in the kitchen, leaning against the counter, replaying the night in her mind.

Lucy standing tall behind her board. Lucy speaking clearly. Lucy managing her energy without spiraling.

And then— *I like when Miss Sarah comes to things*. Cynthia closed her eyes. Safe. That word wouldn't leave her. For years, Cynthia had measured safety in routines. In medication schedules. In backup plans. In exit strategies for crowded rooms. Safety meant control. But tonight, had felt different.

Lucy hadn't needed rescuing. She hadn't clung. She hadn't unraveled when Miss Sarah stepped into view.

There had been no jealousy. No confusion. Only warmth.

Cynthia exhaled slowly. She had been the one hesitating. Not Lucy. Not Miss Sarah. Her.

Because loving someone meant risking disruption. And Lucy's stability had always come first. Cynthia had built their life like a carefully balanced structure — any shift felt dangerous.

But what if the structure was stronger now?

What if it could hold more?

Chapter 34: Perfect Balance



*T*he test came sooner than she expected.

Two weeks later, Mrs. Bennett requested a brief meeting after school.

Nothing urgent.

Nothing alarming.

But the tone carried that careful professionalism teachers use when something needs attention.

Lucy had been struggling with transitions again.

Not dramatically.

Not regressively.

But subtly.

Fourth grade expectations were increasing — longer assignments, more independent work, less structured guidance. Lucy was managing academically, but when schedules changed unexpectedly, she'd begun withdrawing.

One afternoon, a substitute teacher rearranged the seating chart without warning.

Lucy hadn't cried.

She hadn't melted down.

She had simply shut down — silent, rigid, unreachable for nearly an hour.

Mrs. Bennett handled it gently, but she wanted a proactive plan.

Cynthia listened carefully, nodding.

It wasn't catastrophic.

It wasn't even surprising.

Growth wasn't linear.

But old fear flickered in her chest anyway.

"Can we add a transition buffer?" Cynthia asked. "Even a two-minute warning before changes?"

Mrs. Bennett smiled. "I was hoping you'd suggest something like that."

There was a soft knock on the open classroom door.

Miss Sarah stepped inside.

Not as Lucy's former teacher. Not as a hovering presence. But as part of the support team.

"I heard there was a seating incident," she said lightly, taking a chair.

Lucy sat at a small reading table nearby, sketching quietly — included, but not centered.

Cynthia watched carefully.

No tension. No overstimulation. Lucy didn't seem unsettled by Miss Sarah's presence.

In fact, when Miss Sarah glanced over and winked gently, Lucy smiled.

The meeting unfolded smoothly.

They discussed visual schedule reinforcements. Pre-change cues.

Building flexibility gradually instead of expecting immediate adaptation.

Professional. Measured. Collaborative.

And then, something small but significant happened.

Mrs. Bennett excused herself briefly to retrieve a document from the office. Lucy looked up from her drawing. "Are we in trouble?" she asked softly. "No," Cynthia said immediately.

Miss Sarah leaned forward slightly, her voice calm and even.

"This is just problem-solving. You know how scientists adjust experiments?" Lucy nodded.

"That's what this is."

Lucy seemed satisfied with that explanation and returned to her sketch.

Cynthia felt something inside her steady. No panic. No regression. No emotional storm. Just adjustment.

When Mrs. Bennett returned, they finalized the plan.

As the meeting wrapped up, Lucy gathered her backpack.

She walked ahead toward the hallway, humming softly.

Cynthia lingered behind for a moment. Miss Sarah did too. There was a pause. Not awkward. Just full.

“She handled that well,” Miss Sarah said quietly. “She did,” Cynthia agreed. Another pause. Then Cynthia added, “So did you.”

Miss Sarah’s expression softened. “I wasn’t sure if I should step in.”

“You stepped in exactly right.” Cynthia replied with a smile. That was the truth.

No overreach.

No claiming spaces.

Just presence when needed.

They walked down the hallway together.

Lucy was waiting near the exit, rocking gently on her heels.

When she saw them side by side, she grinned.

“You’re both walking me out?”

“Looks like it,” Cynthia replied.

Lucy slipped between them instinctively, taking Cynthia’s hand with one hand and lightly brushing Miss Sarah’s sleeve with the other.

It wasn’t possessive. It wasn’t anxious.

It was balanced.

Cynthia felt the shape of it then.

This wasn’t a missing piece forcing its way into place.

This was something that had been fitting quietly for a long time.

Outside, the late afternoon sun cast long shadows across the parking lot.

Lucy skipped ahead toward the car.

Miss Sarah stopped near her own vehicle.

“I’ll see you tomorrow, Lucy.”

Lucy turned, thoughtful.

“You’re coming to reading circle, right?”

“I wouldn’t miss it.”

Lucy nodded, satisfied.

As she climbed into the backseat, Cynthia and Miss Sarah stood facing each other across the open car door.

The air felt different now.

Less guarded.

Less hypothetical.

“She’s stronger,” Miss Sarah said gently.

“Yes,” Cynthia agreed.

A beat.

“And so are you.”

The words landed softly.

Not flirtation.

Not pressure.

Recognition.

Cynthia swallowed.

“I’m starting to believe that.”

Miss Sarah didn’t push further.

She never did. “I’ll see you tomorrow,” she said.

And she meant it the way she always had — steady, certain, patient.

As Cynthia drove home, Lucy chatting softly about her sketch in the backseat, the fear that had once gripped her so tightly felt... quieter.

There would still be challenges.

There would still be adjustments.

CDKL5 wasn't disappearing overnight.

But tonight, had proven something important.

Nothing shattered when Miss Sarah stood beside them.

Nothing destabilized when support expanded.

If anything—

Lucy felt safer.

And Cynthia, for the first time, allowed herself to imagine what it might feel like to stop bracing for collapse...

...and start trusting the structure they'd built could hold love too.

Chapter 35: The Things Children See



*I*t happened on a Wednesday. Ordinary. Unremarkable. The kind of day that doesn't announce itself as important.

Lucy had adjusted well to the new transition plan. The visual cues were helping. The warnings before schedule shifts gave her time to recalibrate instead of retreat. Mrs. Bennett reported fewer shutdowns. More flexibility. Small victories stacking quietly.

That afternoon, Lucy sat at the kitchen table working on a reading assignment while Cynthia prepared dinner.

"Mom?"

"Mhm?"

"Can I ask something?"

Cynthia smiled faintly. Lucy's "can I ask something" questions were rarely simple.

"Always."

Lucy hesitated, chewing lightly on the inside of her cheek — a thinking habit she'd never quite outgrown.

"Is Miss Sarah family?" The knife paused mid-slice.

Cynthia turned slowly. "Why do you ask?"

Lucy shrugged, but her eyes were focused. Observing.

"She comes to things. She helps. She talks like she knows us. Mrs. Bennett doesn't do that. Other teachers don't do that."

Cynthia set the knife down carefully.

"No," she said gently. "She's not family."

Lucy frowned slightly, considering. "She feels like it."

The words landed with startling clarity.

Cynthia's throat tightened.

"Does that bother you?" she asked softly.

Lucy shook her head.

"I like it."

Then, after a pause—

"If she was family, would she come over for dinner?"

Cynthia felt heat rise in her cheeks. "That's... not exactly how that works."

Lucy returned to her book, seemingly satisfied with planting the question.

Children didn't guess.

They observed.

They noticed patterns adults thought they were hiding.

And Lucy, despite everything she'd faced physically, had always been perceptive in quiet ways.

Cynthia stood at the counter long after dinner was finished, Lucy's words echoing in her mind.

She feels like it.

Family wasn't about biology.

It was about presence.

Consistency.

Safety.

And Miss Sarah had become all three.

The moment — the one Cynthia could no longer dismiss — happened the following evening.

Lucy had stayed late for reading circle. A small group. Soft lighting. Pillows scattered across the classroom floor. It was Lucy's favorite part of the week.

Cynthia arrived just as the session was ending. Through the partially open classroom door, she paused.

Lucy sat cross-legged, listening intently as Miss Sarah finished the final page of a chapter. Her voice was calm, warm, steady.

Lucy leaned slightly toward her without realizing it.

Not dependent.

Not anxious.

Simply comfortable.

When the story ended, the children gathered their things. Parents filtered in. Lucy spotted Cynthia and waved.

“I’ll be right there!” she called.

Miss Sarah stood, stacking books neatly.

Cynthia stepped inside.

“You make it sound better than it probably is,” she said lightly.

Miss Sarah smiled. “That’s the trick. Confidence.”

Their eyes held a beat longer than usual.

Lucy was delayed briefly, digging through her backpack for something.

For once, there was space.

Silence settled between them — not heavy, just aware.

“She asked me something yesterday,” Cynthia said quietly.

Miss Sarah tilted her head slightly. “Oh?”

“She asked if you were family.”

The words lingered in the air between them.

Miss Sarah didn’t laugh.

Didn’t deflect.

“What did you tell her?” Cynthia hesitated before saying, “That you weren’t.”

A flicker crossed Miss Sarah's face — not hurt, exactly. Just restraint.

Cynthia stepped closer, lowering her voice.

"She said you feel like it."

Something shifted.

Subtle.

But undeniable.

Miss Sarah exhaled slowly. "Lucy sees more than people realize."

"Yes," Cynthia agreed. "She does."

There was a moment — fragile and electric — where both women stood at the edge of something.

Not a leap.

But the recognition of one.

"I've tried very hard not to overstep," Miss Sarah said softly. "Lucy's stability matters more than anything."

"I know," Cynthia whispered.

"And you matter too," Miss Sarah added, barely above a whisper.

Cynthia's breath caught.

The hallway outside buzzed faintly with departing families, but inside the classroom, the world felt narrowed to just the space between them.

"I've been afraid," Cynthia admitted. The words surprised even her. "Not of you. Of disrupting what's finally steady."

Miss Sarah stepped closer — not touching, but near enough that the warmth between them was unmistakable.

"Nothing about this feels disruptive," she said gently. "It feels... aligned."

Aligned. The same word Cynthia had used in her own thoughts' weeks earlier.

Lucy's voice echoed from the hallway.

"Mom! I found it!"

The spell broke — but not completely.

Miss Sarah's hand brushed Cynthia's as she stepped back.

Accidental.

But neither moved away quickly.

The contact was brief.

Soft.

Intentional in its hesitation.

Lucy burst into the room, holding up a slightly crumpled drawing.

It showed three figures standing side by side.

One taller.

One medium.

One small.

They were drawn as puzzle pieces.

Fitted together.

Complete.

"There's no missing one," Lucy said proudly. "Because I fixed it."

Cynthia looked at the drawing.

Then at Miss Sarah.

Then back at Lucy.

"You did," she whispered.

And for the first time, the idea didn't feel premature.

It felt possible. Not rushed. Not fragile. Possible.

Miss Sarah crouched beside Lucy. “It’s beautiful.”

Lucy grinned. “I think it works.”

Cynthia met Miss Sarah’s gaze again.

It works.

Not a confession.

Not yet.

But something had been spoken — even if Lucy had been the one to say it first.

Chapter 36: An Open Chair



Lucy brought it up again three nights after reading circle.

“She can come Thursday,” she said casually, spooning rice onto her plate. “That’s when she doesn’t have after-school stuff.”

Cynthia blinked. “Who?”

Lucy gave her a look.

“Miss Sarah.”

Of course.

Cynthia tried to sound neutral. “You’ve been planning her schedule now?”

Lucy shrugged. “I asked.”

“You asked.” Cynthia replied sharply.

“She said Thursdays are usually open.”

Cynthia pressed her lips together to hide the smile threatening to form.

“You two have been coordinating behind my back?”

Lucy grinned. “It’s not behind your back. I’m telling you now.”

There it was — that simple certainty children carried when something made sense to them.

“She should come to dinner,” Lucy continued. “Because she feels like family. And family eats dinner together.”

Cynthia’s chest tightened. There was that word again. Family.

She could say no. She could delay. She could hide behind timing and stability and careful pacing.

But Lucy wasn’t anxious when she talked about Sarah.

She wasn't spiraling. She wasn't clinging. She was... hopeful.

And maybe hope wasn't the enemy.

"Alright," Cynthia heard herself say.

Lucy froze mid-bite. "Really?"

"Really." Cynthia said with a smile.

Lucy's entire face lit up in a way that made the decision irreversible.

"I'll tell her tomorrow!"

"Lucy—" Cynthia started, but it was too late.

The invitation had already left the station.

Thursday arrived faster than Cynthia was prepared for.

She kept dinner simple. Roasted chicken. Vegetables. Rice. Nothing elaborate. Nothing that suggested this was anything more than what it was.

Which was... what, exactly?

Lucy set the table carefully, placing three plates down and then adjusting the spacing like precision mattered.

"Does this look normal?" she asked.

"It looks perfect," Cynthia replied.

The doorbell rang at exactly six. Of course, she was punctual.

Cynthia smoothed her shirt once before opening the door.

Miss Sarah stood there in jeans and a soft blue sweater, holding a small paper bag.

"I come bearing dessert," she said lightly. "Store-bought, so expectations stay reasonable."

Cynthia laughed — the sound coming easier than she expected.

"You didn't have to." Cynthia said with a smile as took the paper bag from Miss Sarah.

“I know.” Miss Sarah said in a flirty way.

Lucy appeared beside Cynthia instantly.

“You came!”

“I was invited,” Miss Sarah said solemnly. “It felt official.”

Lucy stepped forward and hugged her without hesitation.

Cynthia watched carefully.

No overwhelm.

No possessiveness.

Just ease.

“Come in,” she said softly.

Dinner was... easy.

That was the unsettling part.

Lucy talked about school. About a book they were reading. About how she’d managed a substitute teacher that week “without shutting down.”

Miss Sarah listened the way she always did — fully.

Not correcting.

Not performing.

Just present.

At one point, Lucy excused herself to grab a drawing from her room.

The house fell quiet.

Not awkward. Just aware.

“You didn’t have to do this,” Miss Sarah said gently.

“I know,” Cynthia replied.

Their eyes met across the table. “But I wanted to,” Cynthia added.

The words felt bigger than they should have.

Miss Sarah studied her for a moment.

“Are you sure?” she asked quietly. “Because I’ve been very careful not to assume.”

Cynthia exhaled slowly.

“I’ve noticed.”

A flicker of something vulnerable crossed Sarah’s face.

“Lucy is stable right now,” Cynthia continued. “She’s stronger. I don’t want to jeopardize that.”

“I would never jeopardize her,” Sarah said immediately.

“I know that too.” Cynthia said with warmth in her eyes.

Silence settled again. Thicker this time. Honest.

Cynthia’s voice softened.

“She asked if you were family.”

Sarah didn’t look surprised.

“What did you tell her?” Miss Sarah asked quietly.

“That you weren’t.” But this time when Cynthia said it there was a subtle change in her voice.

A beat.

“And?” Miss Sarah asked gently.

“And she said you feel like it.”

The air shifted.

Something unspoken rising between them.

“I’ve tried to stay in my lane,” Sarah admitted quietly. “Because the last thing Lucy needs is instability.

And the last thing you need is pressure.”

Cynthia’s heart pounded harder than the moment seemed to warrant.

“You’ve never felt like pressure,” she said. Sarah’s breath caught slightly. “Then what have I felt like?”

There it was. Not a declaration. Not dramatic. Just a question.

Cynthia stood slowly, crossing the space between them without fully deciding to.

“Safe,” she said. “You’ve felt safe.”

Sarah’s eyes softened.

“That’s all I’ve ever wanted to be.”

They were close now.

Close enough that the air felt warmer.

Close enough that Cynthia could see the hesitation in Sarah’s expression — not fear, but restraint.

“I’ve been afraid,” Cynthia admitted. “Not of you. Of losing balance.”

“And do we feel unbalanced right now?” Sarah asked gently.

Cynthia searched herself for the answer.

No panic. No alarm bells. No instinct to retreat. Just... steady warmth.

Before she could speak —

“Mom!”

Lucy’s voice echoed down the hallway. Both women stepped apart instinctively.

Lucy came running in, holding a new drawing.

“I added her,” she announced proudly.

Cynthia knelt to look.

Three figures. Hands touching. No missing piece.

Lucy looked between them; eyes bright but calm.

“It fits better this way,” she said simply.

Miss Sarah swallowed.

Cynthia felt the interruption not as frustration — but as confirmation.

They weren’t rushing. They weren’t hiding. They were building.

Lucy handed the drawing to Sarah.

“You can keep it. So, you don’t forget.”

“I won’t forget,” Sarah said softly.

Dinner finished gently after that. No grand declarations. No dramatic shifts.

But when Sarah stood at the door to leave, the goodbye felt different.

Longer. Weighted.

“Thank you,” she said quietly to Cynthia.

“For dinner?” Cynthia said with a smile.

“For trusting me enough to open the door.” Miss Sarah said with eyes that matched Cynthia’s warmth expression.

Cynthia stepped a fraction closer. “I’m still opening it,” she admitted.

Sarah smiled — not triumphant, not impatient.

“I’m not in a hurry.” Miss Sarah said with a warm smile.

Lucy appeared again at Cynthia’s side.

“You’re coming back, right?”

Sarah met Cynthia’s eyes before answering.

“If your mom invites me.”

Cynthia didn’t hesitate this time. “I will.” The door closed softly behind her.

Lucy leaned into Cynthia’s side. “You were going to say something,” Lucy observed.

Cynthia looked down. “Was I?”

“Yes.” Lucy nodded. “But it’s okay. You can say it later.”

Children see everything. Cynthia kissed the top of her daughter’s head.

“Yes,” she whispered. “I can.”

Chapter 37: When the Ground Shifts



*I*t started like any other Sunday.

Laundry in slow rotation. Soft music playing in the background. Lucy at the dining table working through a puzzle she'd already completed twice before — not because it challenged her, but because repetition felt steady.

Cynthia had just poured coffee when she heard it. The sound. Not loud. Not dramatic.

Just the subtle shift in breathing that every parent of a child with CDKL5 learns to recognize before it fully happens. She turned instantly.

Lucy's hands had stilled. Her body tightened. Eyes unfocused.

"Lucy," Cynthia said calmly, already moving.

The seizure was brief — under a minute — but it stole the color from the room anyway.

Cynthia knelt beside her, counting softly, one hand supporting Lucy's shoulder, the other brushing hair back from her face. "It's okay. I've got you."

Lucy's body relaxed gradually.

Breathing returned to normal.

The aftermath was always the hardest part — not the seizure itself, but the fragile space afterward.

Lucy blinked slowly, disoriented.

"I hate that," she whispered.

"I know," Cynthia said, keeping her voice even.

Fatigue set in quickly. Muscles weak. Coordination slightly off.

They moved to the couch.

Cynthia adjusted pillows automatically, checking for delayed symptoms, monitoring timing in her head.

They had been doing so well. Weeks without incident. Stability. Progress.

And still — this.

The reminder that CDKL5 didn't disappear just because life felt steady.

Lucy's fingers tightened slightly in Cynthia's shirt.

"Am I going backwards?" she asked quietly.

The question cracked something open inside her.

"No," Cynthia said firmly. "Never backwards. Just... managing."

Lucy nodded faintly, but doubt lingered in her eyes.

There was a soft knock at the door.

Cynthia frowned. She wasn't expecting anyone.

She eased Lucy back against the pillows before answering it.

Miss Sarah stood there, holding a small container.

"I was nearby," she said gently. "I made too much soup."

Cynthia stared at her for half a second — stunned by the timing.

And then she understood.

Lucy had mentioned feeling "a little buzzy" at school on Friday. Sarah must have noticed something in her energy. Filed it away. She noticed everything.

"There was a seizure," Cynthia said quietly.

Sarah's expression didn't shift to panic.

Didn't overreact. Just softened.

"Is she okay?"

"Yes. It was short." Cynthia said with a deep sigh of relief.

"Can I come in?" Miss Sarah asked with a subtle hesitation.

Cynthia stepped aside. Lucy looked up from the couch as Sarah entered.

“You didn’t have to come,” Lucy murmured.

Sarah crouched beside her.

“I know.”

No pity. No dramatics. Just presence.

Lucy studied her face carefully.

“Did I mess up?”

Sarah’s brow furrowed slightly.

“Mess up what?”

“Getting better.” Lucy said with sadness in her voice.

The air tightened.

Cynthia hadn’t realized how deeply that fear had taken root.

Sarah reached for Lucy’s hand — not abruptly, not claiming — just resting her fingers lightly over Lucy’s.

“You getting stronger doesn’t mean your body never has hard days,” she said evenly. “It means you know what to do when they happen.”

Lucy blinked slowly.

“That’s still strong?”

“That’s exactly strong,” Sarah said with a confident smile.

Cynthia felt tears sting unexpectedly.

Because that was the part she hadn’t known how to say.

Lucy exhaled, tension easing.

“I’m tired.”

“That makes sense,” Sarah replied. “Your brain worked very hard.”

Lucy nodded, eyes already drifting closed.

Cynthia adjusted the blanket. When Lucy finally fell asleep, the room went quiet again.

But it felt different this time. Less alone.

Cynthia moved into the kitchen mechanically, needing space to regulate herself.

Sarah followed, giving distance but not leaving.

“She was afraid she was regressing,” Cynthia said softly, staring at the counter.

“That fear makes sense,” Sarah replied.

“I’ve spent years trying to protect her from that feeling.”

“And you have,” Sarah said gently. “But you can’t erase the condition. You can only teach her she’s bigger than it.”

Cynthia closed her eyes briefly.

“I keep waiting for the other shoe to drop,” she admitted. “For stability to vanish.”

Sarah stepped closer — not touching yet.

“But it hasn’t,” she said quietly.

Cynthia looked at her.

“Even now. This doesn’t undo her progress. It doesn’t erase her confidence. It doesn’t destabilize her world.”

Her voice softened further.

“And I’m not leaving because things get hard.”

The words hung there.

Not dramatic. Not performative.

Just truth.

Cynthia’s chest tightened.

“You didn’t run,” she said.

“No.” Miss Sarah said with a smile.

“You didn’t look scared.” Cynthia said as she could feel tears.

“I was informed,” Sarah replied gently. “There’s a difference.”

A small, shaky laugh escaped Cynthia before she could stop it.

For years, vulnerability had meant isolation.

Handling it alone.

Managing appearances.

Bracing.

But Sarah standing in her kitchen — steady, calm, refusing to flinch — shifted something fundamental.

“You make it feel survivable,” Cynthia whispered.

Sarah’s voice lowered.

“It always was.”

The space between them narrowed again — not rushed, not reactive — but real.

Cynthia searched for panic.

For instability.

For that instinct to retreat.

It wasn’t there.

Lucy stirred softly in the living room but didn’t wake.

Cynthia stepped closer.

“This,” she said quietly, gesturing between them. “It doesn’t feel like risk anymore.”

Sarah’s breath caught.

“What does it feel like?”

Cynthia’s voice trembled just slightly.

“It feels like reinforcement.”

And this time, when their hands found each other, it wasn’t accidental.

It was deliberate. Grounded.

Lucy shifted again, murmuring in her sleep.

Both women turned instinctively toward her.

And in that synchronized movement — that shared orientation toward Lucy — Cynthia realized something with complete clarity.

Nothing about this weakened the foundation.

It strengthened it.

The ground hadn't shifted.

It had widened.

Chapter 38: Already True



L

Lucy woke the next morning like nothing monumental had happened.

That was the thing about seizures. They could shake the ground one day and leave only a faint echo the next. She moved slower, yes. A little softer around the edges. But she ate her breakfast. Packed her bag.

Asked if she could bring the puzzle piece drawing back to school to show Mrs. Bennett.

Life didn't collapse.

It continued.

And that, Cynthia realized, was the miracle.

Miss Sarah had texted earlier — simple and steady:

How's our girl this morning?

Not dramatic. Not anxious. Just present.

Cynthia had stared at the words *our girl* longer than she meant to.

Not possessive.

Inclusive.

She replied: *Tired but steady. Thank you for yesterday.*

The response came quickly.

There's nowhere else I would've been.

Cynthia didn't overanalyze it this time.

She didn't brace.

She simply let it land.

That evening, Lucy insisted on walking to the small park at the end of their street. Nothing strenuous — just air and space and the reassurance that her body still belonged to her.

Miss Sarah met them there.

Not because she had to.

Because she wanted to.

Lucy moved toward the swings, slower than usual but determined. Sarah adjusted the seat gently without being asked. Cynthia noticed — not as a grand gesture, but as instinct.

They stood side by side while Lucy swung carefully, the sky turning gold above them.

“She looks good,” Sarah said quietly.

“She does.” Cynthia said with a smile while watching Lucy play.

A comfortable silence settled.

No tension.

No hovering fears.

Just the rhythm of Lucy’s quiet laughter as she pushed herself gently back and forth.

Cynthia exhaled.

“I used to think love would feel like losing control,” she said, eyes still on Lucy.

Sarah didn’t interrupt.

“I thought if I let someone in, I’d be splitting my attention. Weakening something. Risking her stability.”

“And now?” Sarah asked softly. Cynthia turned to look at her.

“Now I think I was underestimating her. And you.”

The air didn’t crackle. It warmed.

Sarah’s expression didn’t flash with surprise — only understanding.

“I never wanted to replace anything,” she said. “Or complicate it.”

“You didn’t.” Cynthia replied with a warm smile.

Lucy’s laughter floated toward them again, unforced and bright.

Cynthia watched her daughter for a long moment before speaking again.

“She asked me once if you were family.”

Sarah smiled faintly. “I remember.”

“I told her you weren’t.” Cynthia said as she looks at Lucy.

A small pause.

“And now?” Sarah asks gently.

Cynthia didn’t hesitate this time.

“I think I was wrong.”

There was no dramatic swell of music. No rush of footsteps. No interruption.

Just truth, laid gently between them.

Sarah absorbed it slowly.

“Cynthia...” Sarah said slowly.

Her name sounded different when spoken without caution.

“I don’t feel confused anymore,” Cynthia continued. “I don’t feel afraid of what this could disrupt. When Lucy had that seizure yesterday, I watched you walk in without panic. Without pulling away. Without making it about you.”

She stepped a fraction closer.

“You didn’t make our world smaller. You stood inside it like you’d always belonged there.”

Sarah’s eyes softened, but she stayed steady.

“I’ve loved you for a while,” Sarah said.

Not rushed. Not apologetic. Just factual.

Cynthia's breath left her in a quiet exhale.

"I know."

The words surprised them both — not because they weren't true, but because of how peacefully they arrived.

"I think I've loved you too," Cynthia said. "I was just waiting for the fear to catch up to it."

"And did it?" Sarah asks without fear.

Cynthia glanced toward Lucy again.

Lucy had slowed the swing and was now dragging her shoes lightly against the ground, watching them from a distance with curious but calm eyes.

"No," Cynthia said softly. "It didn't."

There it was.

Not fireworks.

Foundation.

Sarah stepped closer, close enough that their shoulders brushed.

"Are you sure?" she asked — not doubting, just honoring the weight of it.

Cynthia nodded.

"I don't feel like I'm falling," she said. "I feel like I've been standing here for a long time."

A quiet smile touched Sarah's mouth.

"Good," she whispered.

Their hands found each other naturally this time — no hesitation, no accidental brush.

Intentional.

Steady.

Lucy hopped off the swing and jogged toward them carefully.

"Are we going home?" she asked.

“In a minute,” Cynthia said.

Lucy looked between their joined hands.

No alarm.

No confusion.

Just that perceptive gaze again.

“Okay,” she said simply.

And then she slipped her hand into Cynthia’s free one.

Balanced.

Three points connected.

No missing piece.

No sudden shift in the earth beneath them.

Just something that had already been true, finally spoken out loud.

As they walked home together, Cynthia realized something that would have terrified her months ago:

Nothing felt fragile.

Lucy wasn’t destabilized.

The diagnosis hadn’t disappeared.

The challenges weren’t erased.

But love hadn’t cracked the foundation.

It had reinforced it.

And for the first time in years, Cynthia wasn’t walking braced for impact.

She was walking forward.

Chapter 39: Perfect Fit



*T*here wasn't a grand moment when everything became easy.

CDKL5 didn't disappear.

Life didn't smooth into something glossy and untouched.

There were still appointments. Still careful planning.

Still days when Lucy's body reminded them that strength didn't mean invincible.

But there was laughter in the kitchen now.

There were three coffee mugs on the counter instead of one.

There was a second toothbrush beside Cynthia's in the bathroom — not rushed there, not dramatic — just slowly, over time, becoming permanent.

The change hadn't been loud.

It had been lived.

Lucy was almost through fourth grade when the school hosted its annual family picnic.

Once, events like this had made Cynthia anxious. Too much noise. Too many variables. Too many chances for Lucy to become overwhelmed.

But Lucy walked into the field with easy confidence now.

She carried her own water bottle. Wore her sunhat without complaint. Checked in once about the schedule and then ran toward her friends without hesitation.

Miss Sarah walked beside Cynthia, fingers brushing naturally, openly.

No hiding. No careful distance. They had stopped worrying about whispers months ago.

Lucy had been the barometer all along — and she had never faltered.

"She looks happy," Sarah said softly. "She is," Cynthia replied.

They stood watching as Lucy lined up for a relay race. She wasn't the fastest. She never had been. Her coordination still lagged slightly on hard days.

But she didn't hang back anymore.

When the whistle blew, Lucy ran.

Arms pumping. Determined. Joyfully imperfect.

She stumbled once near the halfway point — just enough to remind everyone watching that her body still carried its history.

Cynthia felt the instinctive surge of adrenaline.

But Lucy caught herself.

Adjusted.

Kept going.

She didn't look toward the sidelines for rescue.

She finished the race breathless and flushed, grinning like she'd won something far bigger than first place.

And maybe she had.

Later, sprawled across a picnic blanket between them, Lucy rested her head in Cynthia's lap and her feet against Sarah's thigh.

Balanced.

Grounded.

Whole.

"Remember when I used to get scared it would all go backwards?" Lucy asked suddenly.

Cynthia smoothed her daughter's hair. "I remember."

"I don't feel like that anymore."

Sarah glanced at Cynthia but didn't interrupt.

Lucy looked up at the sky, squinting against the sun. "It feels like we just build from where we are."

Cynthia swallowed against the thickness in her throat.

“That’s exactly what we do.”

Lucy shifted slightly, thoughtful.

“You know what I think?”

“What?” Sarah asked gently.

“I don’t think anyone was missing,” Lucy said. “I think we were just waiting.”

Waiting.

Not incomplete.

Not broken.

Just... becoming.

Cynthia looked at Sarah then — really looked at her.

All the moments layered between them:

School meetings. Science fairs. Seizure recoveries. Kitchen table homework. Almost-confessions. Finally spoken truths.

Nothing about it had been reckless.

Nothing about it had been forced.

It had unfolded the way Lucy’s strength had unfolded — slowly, intentionally, earned.

“I used to think love would shake everything,” Cynthia said quietly.

Sarah’s fingers laced with hers.

“And now?”

Cynthia watched Lucy laugh at something across the field, utterly unburdened in the way only hard-won stability allows.

“Now I think it’s the thing that holds.”

Sarah smiled — not wide, not triumphant. Certain.

Lucy rolled onto her side, looking between them.

“You’re doing the face again.”

“What face?” Cynthia asked.

“The one where you look like you figured something out.”

Cynthia laughed softly.

“Maybe I did.”

Lucy nodded, satisfied.

“Good. Because it fits.”

And that was it.

Not fireworks.

Not a dramatic declaration under a stormy sky.

Just a family — built with intention, reinforced with patience, and expanded with love that never tried to replace what was already strong.

Lucy would still have hard days.

Cynthia would still double-check medication alarms.

Sarah would still show up — not as a hero, not as a savior — but as something steadier.

A partner.

A presence.

A promise kept quietly over time.

The missing piece had never been about filling a gap.

It had been about alignment.

And as the afternoon sun stretched long shadows across the grass, Cynthia realized something that once would have terrified her: Nothing felt fragile anymore.

Not Lucy’s progress. Not their foundation. Not her heart.

They weren't surviving.

They were living.

Together.

And it was, in every quiet, ordinary way that mattered—

a perfect fit.

The End

YOU ARE NOT ALONE

If you or someone you love is living with **CDKL5 Deficiency Disorder**, please know that you are not alone.

A diagnosis can bring fear, uncertainty, questions, and sometimes feelings that are difficult to put into words. You may find yourself searching for answers, learning a language you never expected to need, and trying to understand what the future might look like.

But there is a community of families around the world who understand.

Families who have walked this road before you.

Families who are walking it beside you.

And families who are only just beginning their journey, just as you may be.

Sometimes, the most important thing we can find is someone who simply understands.

The organizations below provide information, family support, community connections, research information, and resources for people affected by CDKL5.

INTERNATIONAL FOUNDATION FOR CDKL5 RESEARCH

IFCR

The International Foundation for CDKL5 Research is a global organization dedicated to supporting individuals and families affected by CDKL5 Deficiency Disorder.

IFCR provides families with information, resources, research updates, family connections, and opportunities to become involved in the wider CDKL5 community.

Website:

<https://cdkl5.com/>

Family Support:

<https://cdkl5.com/support>

For Families:

<https://cdkl5.com/for-families>

CONNECT CDKL5

International Family Community

Connect CDKL5 is an international community that helps families connect with information, research opportunities, clinical studies, surveys, and other CDKL5 resources.

For families who may feel isolated after receiving a diagnosis, connecting with other families can be an important reminder that they are not walking this journey alone.

Website:

<https://cdkl5.com/connect-cdkl5>

CDKL5 RESEARCH COLLABORATIVE

The CDKL5 Research Collaborative works to advance research and understanding of CDKL5 Deficiency Disorder.

Their resources also provide information about CDKL5 family communities and support groups, helping families find others who understand the challenges and experiences that can come with CDKL5.

Website:

<https://www.cdkl5research.org/>

CDKL5 UK

United Kingdom

CDKL5 UK provides support and information for individuals and families affected by CDKL5 Deficiency Disorder.

Their family support services can help families navigate practical challenges, connect with others, and find support while living with CDKL5.

Website:

<https://curecdkl5.org.uk/>

Family Support:

<https://curecdkl5.org.uk/family-support-page/>

CDKL5 CANADA

Canada

CDKL5 Canada provides information, family connections, support, and resources for individuals and families affected by CDKL5.

They also help families connect with others within the Canadian CDKL5 community.

Website:

<https://cdkl5canada.ca/>

Family Support:

<https://cdkl5canada.ca/for-families/support/>

FINDING YOUR COMMUNITY

There are also online CDKL5 family communities where parents, grandparents, siblings, caregivers, and other loved ones can connect with people who understand their experiences.

Some communities include:

CDKL5 Parents Support Group

CDKL5 World – United in Hope

CDKL5 Canada Family Support Group

Boys with CDKL5

CDKL5 Extended Family and Provider Support Group

CDKL5 Dads Group

Many of these communities are private groups, often found through social media or through the organizations listed above.

If you are looking for a support group, the organizations above can help point you toward current communities and resources.

A MESSAGE TO FAMILIES

There may be days when you wonder how you are going to do this.

There may be days when the appointments seem endless, when the questions seem impossible to answer, or when you look at your child and wish you could take away every difficulty they face.

There may also be moments of laughter.

Small victories.

Unexpected milestones.

A smile that lights up the room.

A moment that nobody else might understand, but that means everything to you.

Hold onto those moments.

Because your child's life is not defined by a diagnosis.

CDKL5 is part of their story, but it is not the whole story.

Your child is still your child.

They have their own personality, their own likes and dislikes, their own way of communicating, their own dreams, their own beautiful little moments that make them uniquely who they are.

And just as every puzzle needs the right pieces to complete the picture, every child has a place in this world exactly as they are.

They do not need to become someone else's idea of perfect.

They already belong.

YOU ARE NOT ALONE

If you are reading this after receiving a CDKL5 diagnosis, you may feel like your world has suddenly changed.

It has.

But that doesn't mean your story has ended.

It may simply be the beginning of a different journey.

Reach out.

Ask questions.

Find other families.

Accept help when you need it.

Celebrate the little things.

And remember that you don't have to understand the entire journey today.

You only need to take the next step.

One day.

One moment.

One smile.

One little victory at a time.

You are not alone.

Your child is not alone.

And there is a community waiting to walk beside you.

RESOURCE NOTE

The organizations and resources listed on this page are provided for informational and support purposes. Websites, programs, support groups, and contact information may change over time. Please visit each organization's official website for the most current information.

This resource page is not intended to replace medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment from qualified healthcare professionals. Families should speak with their child's healthcare team regarding individual medical, developmental, therapeutic, and care needs.

A FINAL NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

To every parent, grandparent, sibling, caregiver, and family member who has ever wondered whether they were strong enough for this journey—

You are.

And to every child who has taught the people around them that there is more than one way to communicate, more than one way to learn, and more than one way to experience the world—

You are not broken.

You are not missing a piece.

You are a perfect fit, exactly as you are. ❤️



